TEDDY ROOK BOOK · VOCABULARY LADDER

1,000 Words, Pictured

Volume 1 of 4 · Topics 1–25

Each card gives a word, how to say it (the capital letters are stressed), its meaning, a memory hook with a picture, an example and its Greek or Latin parts. To learn a word: say the hook out loud, picture the scene, then cover the card and try to recall the meaning. Come back to it tomorrow and again next week.

1. Good and Bad: bene- and mal-
2. Kind and Cruel
3. Polite and Rude
4. Saying More or Less
5. Happy
6. Evidence and Proof
7. Fleeting and Lasting
8. Making Things Better
9. Agreeing and Disagreeing
10. Plenty and Scarcity
11. Belief, Trust and Truth: cred, fid and ver
12. Honest and Dishonest
13. Eager and Reluctant
14. Words of Praise
15. Sad
16. Belief and Doubt
17. Changeable
18. Making Things Worse
19. Laws and Rules
20. Ordinary and Overused
21. Looking and Seeing: spec and vid
22. Brave and Fearful
23. Strict and Lenient
24. Words of Blame
25. Angry and Hateful

Free at teddyrookbook.com/vocabulary/, with flashcards, quizzes and practice.

benevolent buh-**NEV**-uh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING kind and wishing good for others

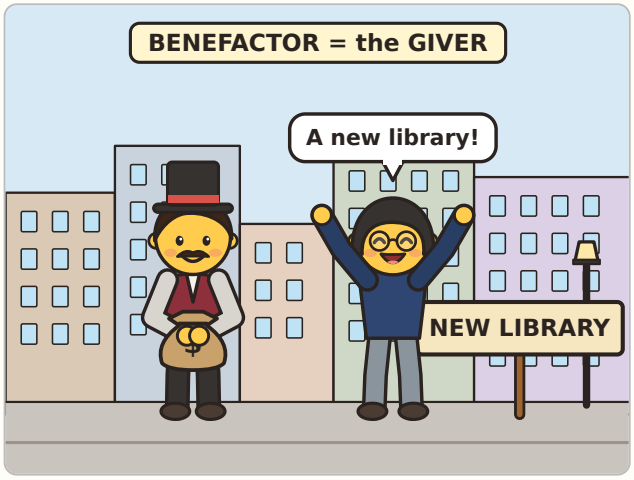
MEMORY HOOK **BEN VOLunteers.** Every Saturday, Ben volunteers at the bread table; a man who gives his time to help others is **benevolent**.

*The **benevolent** neighbor shoveled every driveway on the street after the storm.*

PARTS **bene** well + **vol** wish, will + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR kind, charitable, generous, kindly
OPPOSITE malevolent, cruel, spiteful

benefactor **BEN**-uh-fak-ter *noun*



MEANING a person who gives money or help to a person or cause

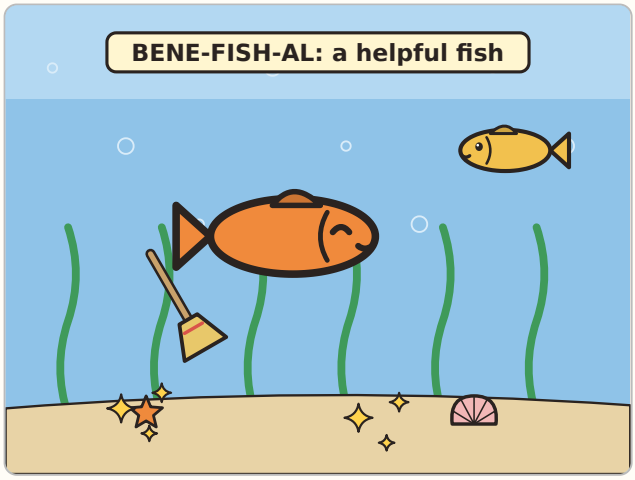
MEMORY HOOK **the owner of the BENEFIT FACTORY.** Picture a factory that makes good things for other people: its owner, the **benefactor**, is the one who gives.

*An unnamed **benefactor** paid for the new playground.*

PARTS **bene** well + **fact** do, make + **-or** one who

SIMILAR patron, donor, supporter, sponsor
OPPOSITE beneficiary, recipient

beneficial ben-uh-**FISH**-ul *adjective*



MEANING helpful; producing good results

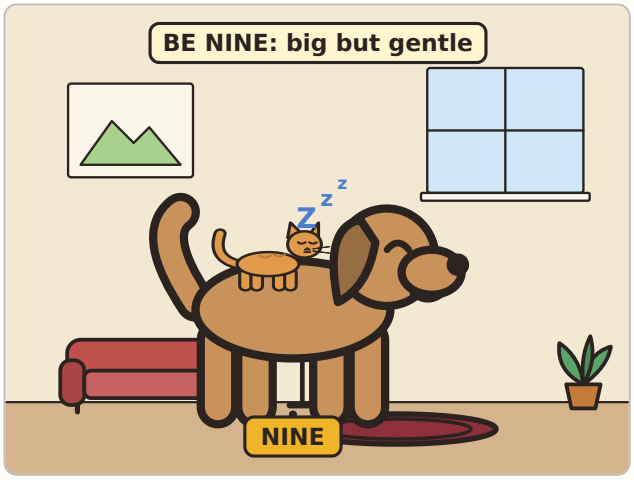
MEMORY HOOK **a BENE-FISH-al fish.** A fish that sweeps the sea floor clean helps every creature around it; its work is **beneficial**.

*Reading aloud every evening proved **beneficial** to her spelling.*

PARTS **bene** well + **fic** do, make + **-ial** having to do with (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR helpful, useful, advantageous, valuable
OPPOSITE harmful, detrimental, damaging

benign bih-**NINE** *adjective*



MEANING gentle and kind; also, not harmful

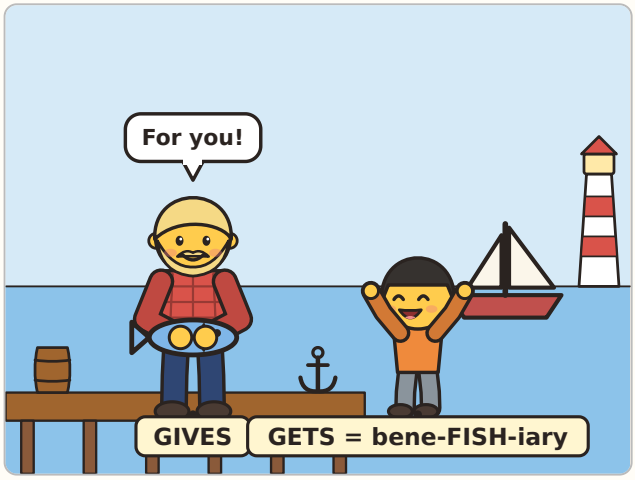
MEMORY HOOK **BE NINE: a big dog named Nine.** The family dog, Nine, is huge, but he is **benign**: he lets the kitten nap on his back.

*Despite his size, the farm's old horse was **benign** and let the children brush his mane.*

PARTS **bene** well

SIMILAR gentle, harmless, kindly, mild
OPPOSITE malignant, harmful, hostile

beneficiary ben-uh-**FISH**-ee-er-ee *noun*



MEANING a person who receives a benefit, such as money left in a will

MEMORY HOOK **the one who gets the FISH.** The fisherman gives; the boy who gets the fish is the bene-FISH-iary. The **beneficiary** is the one who receives.

Lila was the **beneficiary** *of her grandfather's garden and all his tools.*

PARTS **bene** well + **fic** do, make + **-iary** one connected with

SIMILAR recipient, receiver, heir

OPPOSITE benefactor, donor, giver

malevolent muh-**LEV**-uh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING wishing harm to others

MEMORY HOOK **MALL EVIL.** An evil villain sneaks through the mall wishing bad luck on every shopper: he is **malevolent**.

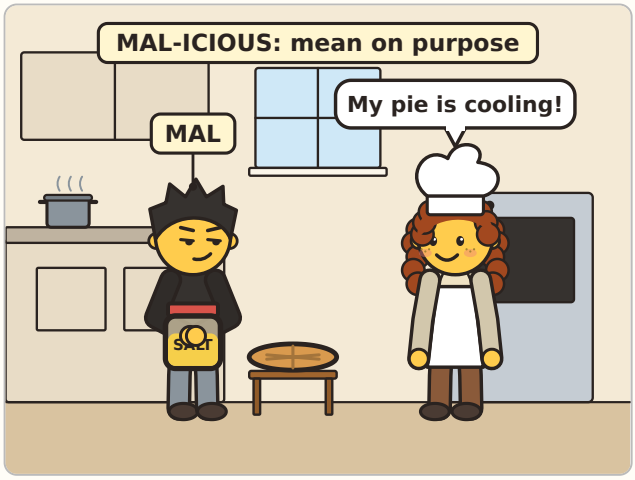
In the old story, a **malevolent** *sorcerer cast a spell of endless winter on the valley.*

PARTS **mal** badly + **vol** wish, will + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR evil, spiteful, malicious, hostile

OPPOSITE benevolent, kind, friendly

malicious muh-**LISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING meaning to hurt someone on purpose

MEMORY HOOK **MAL spoils your deLICIOUS pie.** Sneaky Mal pours salt into the baker's delicious pie on purpose; spoiling it just to hurt her is **malicious**.

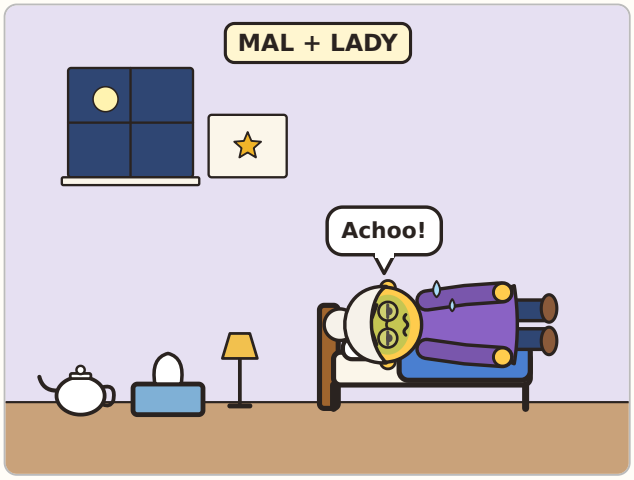
Spreading a **malicious** *rumor can hurt a person's friendships for years.*

PARTS **mal** bad + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR spiteful, mean, vicious, malevolent

OPPOSITE kind, benevolent, well-meaning

malady **MAL**-uh-dee *noun*



MEANING an illness, or a deep-rooted problem

MEMORY HOOK **the LADY has a MALady.** Poor Granny Mae is the lady with the bad cold; her **malady** keeps her in bed.

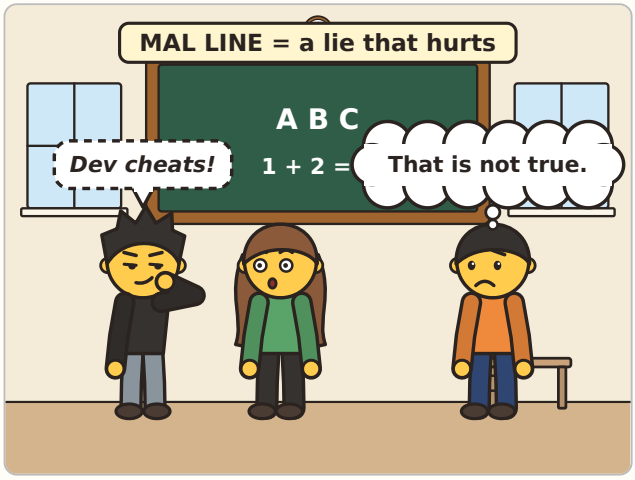
Boredom is a common **malady** *on long car trips.*

PARTS **mal** badly

SIMILAR illness, ailment, disorder, affliction

OPPOSITE health, wellness

malign muh-**LINE** *verb*



MEANING to say harmful and untrue things about someone

MEMORY HOOK **a MAL LINE.** A mean line about someone that is not true: whispering “Dev cheats!” is a way to **malign** him.

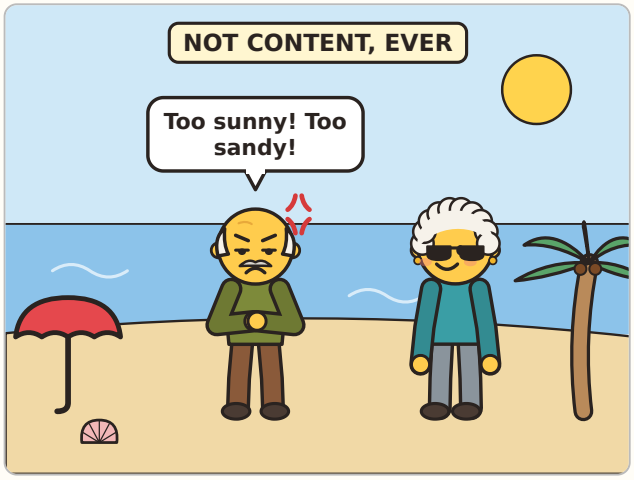
It is unfair to **malign** *a teammate who is not there to answer.*

PARTS **mal** bad, badly

SIMILAR slander, smear, disparage, defame
OPPOSITE praise, defend, compliment

1. Good and Bad: bene- and mal-

malcontent **MAL**-kun-tent *noun*



MEANING a person who is always dissatisfied and complaining

MEMORY HOOK **MAL-CONTENT: never content.** Grandpa Gus is never content, not even at the beach: he is a **malcontent**.

Even on a perfect beach day, the **malcontent** *found something to grumble about.*

PARTS **mal** badly + **content** satisfied

SIMILAR grumbler, complainer, grouch

1. Good and Bad: bene- and mal-

compassionate kum-**PASH**-uh-nit *adjective*



MEANING feeling for others who suffer and wanting to help them

MEMORY HOOK **a heart like a COMPASS.** Maya’s heart works like a compass: it always points her toward whoever is hurting. She is **compassionate**.

The **compassionate** *nurse held the frightened boy’s hand until his parents arrived.*

PARTS **com** with + **pass** suffer (Latin pati) + **-ate** having (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR sympathetic, caring, kindhearted, merciful
OPPOSITE callous, heartless, cold

2. Kind and Cruel

considerate kun-**SID**-er-it *adjective*



MEANING careful not to hurt, bother or inconvenience others

MEMORY HOOK **CONSIDER IT first.** Before Jonah bangs his drum, he stops to consider it: is the baby asleep? Thinking of others first makes him **considerate**.

It was **considerate** *of Omar to call ahead and say he would be late.*

SIMILAR thoughtful, mindful, kind, attentive
OPPOSITE inconsiderate, thoughtless, selfish

2. Kind and Cruel

altruistic al-troo-**IS**-tik *adjective*



MEANING helping others with no thought of reward for oneself

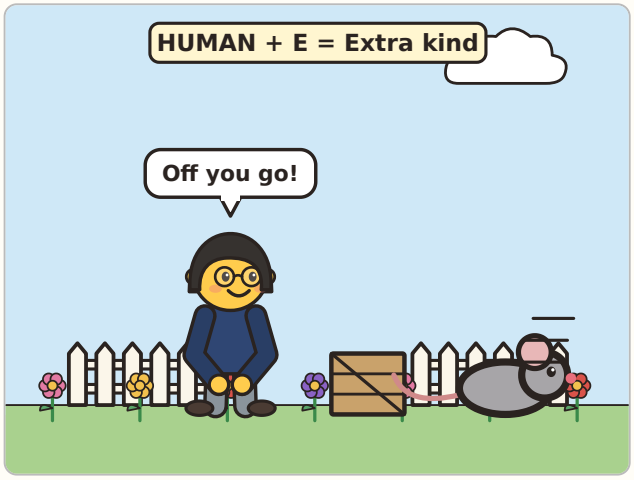
MEMORY HOOK **AL TRUly helps for free.** Al shovels every neighbor's walk and waves away their money. Al truly helps for nothing in return: he is **altruistic**.

*The **altruistic** teen spent her summer teaching little kids to swim for free.*

PARTS **altru** others (from Latin alter, other) + **-istic** having to do with

SIMILAR selfless, unselfish, charitable, generous
OPPOSITE selfish, self-serving, greedy

humane hyoo-**MAYN** *adjective*



MEANING kind and merciful; causing no needless pain

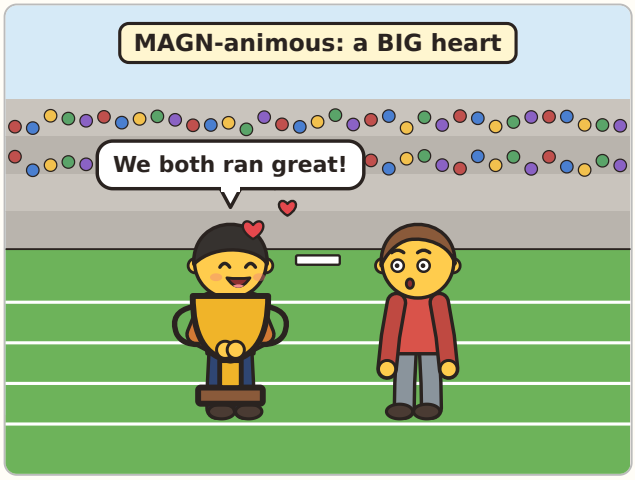
MEMORY HOOK **HUMAN + E = Extra kind.** Add an E to human for Extra kindness: Ada's **humane** trap catches the mouse without a scratch, and she lets it go in the garden.

*The shelter found a **humane** way to catch the stray cats without hurting them.*

PARTS **human** of people (Latin humanus)

SIMILAR kind, merciful, compassionate, gentle
OPPOSITE inhumane, cruel, brutal

magnanimous mag-**NAN**-uh-mus *adjective*



MEANING generous and forgiving, especially toward a rival

MEMORY HOOK **MAGN = BIG, as in MAGNIFY.** Dev wins the race, then lifts the trophy with the runner-up and cheers for him too. A heart that big toward a rival is **magnanimous**.

*In a **magnanimous** gesture, the champion invited the runner-up to share the stage.*

PARTS **magn** great + **anim** mind, spirit + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR big-hearted, gracious, generous, forgiving
OPPOSITE petty, vindictive, spiteful

solicitous suh-**LIS**-ih-tus *adjective*



MEANING eagerly caring about someone's comfort and well-being

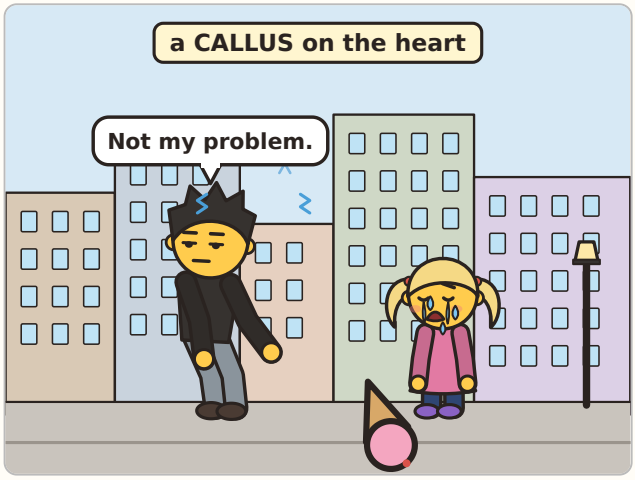
MEMORY HOOK **so-LIS-it-us: "SO, LIST US your needs!".** "So, list us your needs: tea? a pillow? another blanket?" Lila fusses over Granny Mae's sniffle. She is **solicitous**.

*The **solicitous** host kept asking whether everyone had enough to eat.*

PARTS **solicit** anxious (Latin sollicitus) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR attentive, caring, concerned, thoughtful
OPPOSITE neglectful, indifferent, unconcerned

callous KAL-us *adjective*



MEANING unfeeling toward other people's pain or trouble

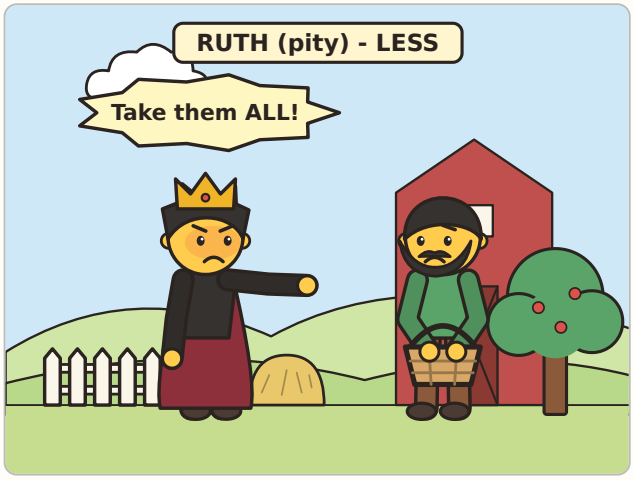
MEMORY HOOK **a CALLUS on the heart.** A callus is hard skin that feels nothing. Rex walks past the crying girl without a glance, as if his heart had a callus: he is **callous**.

Laughing at the boy who dropped his lunch tray was a **callous** *thing to do.*

PARTS **call** hard skin (Latin callum) + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR heartless, unfeeling, insensitive, cold
OPPOSITE compassionate, sympathetic, caring

ruthless ROOTH-lis *adjective*



MEANING showing no pity; willing to hurt others to get one's way

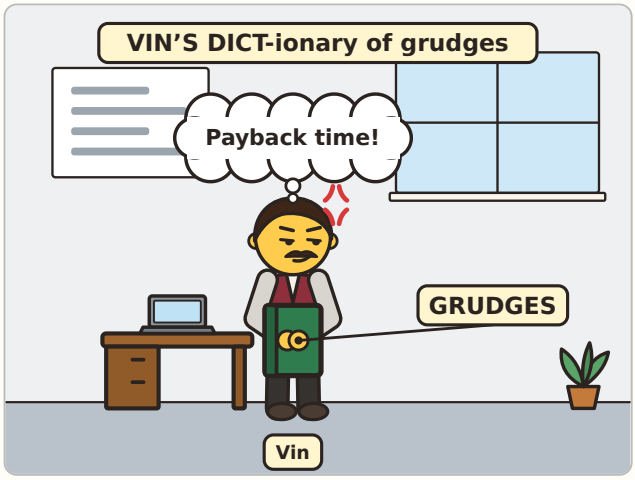
MEMORY HOOK **RUTH = pity: RUTH-LESS.** Ruth is an old word for pity. The cartoon king who takes the farmers' very last pears has no ruth at all: he is **ruthless**.

Lin is a **ruthless** *checkers player who never lets anyone take back a move.*

PARTS **ruth** pity (an old English word) + **-less** without

SIMILAR merciless, pitiless, heartless, cruel
OPPOSITE merciful, humane, compassionate

vindictive vin-DIK-tiv *adjective*



MEANING wanting revenge; set on paying someone back

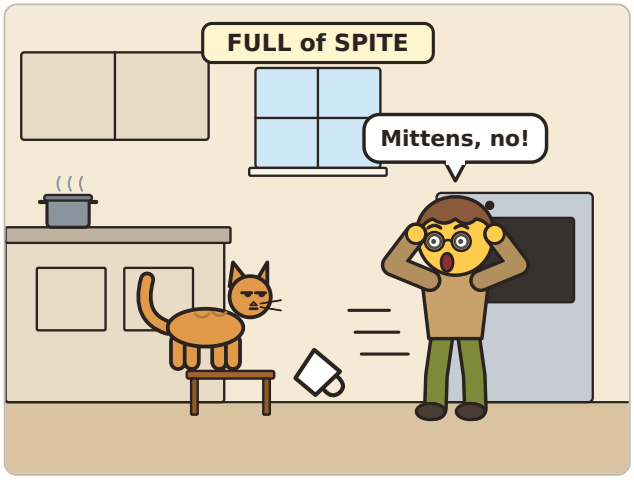
MEMORY HOOK **VIN's DICTionary of grudges.** Vin keeps a whole dictionary of everyone who ever wronged him, and he plans to pay back every one. Vin is **vindictive**.

After losing at checkers, my **vindictive** *cousin hid the winner's shoes.*

PARTS **vindict** revenge (Latin vindicta) + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR vengeful, unforgiving, revengeful, resentful
OPPOSITE forgiving, magnanimous, merciful

spiteful SPITE-ful *adjective*



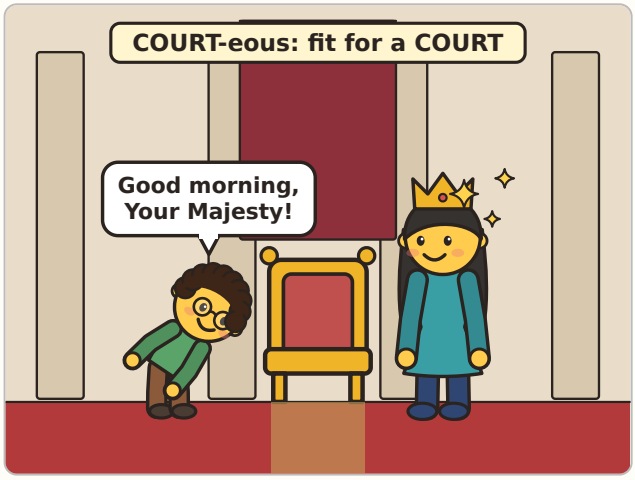
MEANING mean on purpose, out of petty ill will

MEMORY HOOK **a cat FULL of SPITE.** Dinner was late, so Mittens looks Felix in the eye and slowly pushes his cup off the table: a **spiteful** cat.

The **spiteful** *cat stared right at me and pushed my cup off the table.*

SIMILAR mean, malicious, nasty, petty
OPPOSITE kind, generous, charitable

courteous KUR-tee-us *adjective*



MEANING polite and respectful toward others

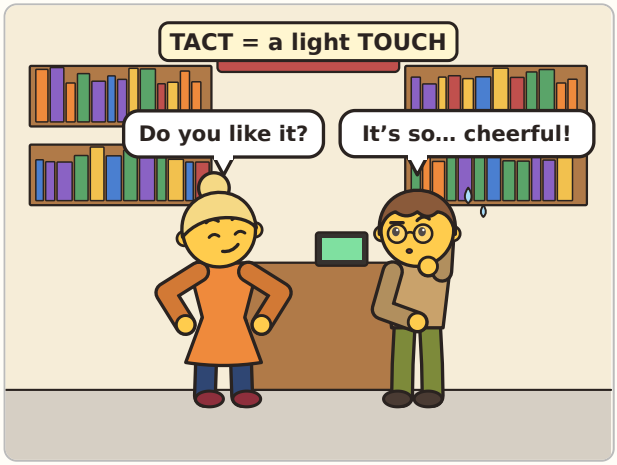
MEMORY HOOK **manners fit for a royal COURT.** Sami bows to the queen and says, “Good morning, Your Majesty.” Manners fit for a royal court are **courteous**.

The **courteous** *bus driver waited for the running boy and greeted him with a smile.*

PARTS **court** a royal court + **-eous** full of, having

SIMILAR polite, respectful, gracious, civil
OPPOSITE rude, discourteous, impolite

tactful TAKT-ful *adjective*



MEANING careful to say things without hurting anyone’s feelings

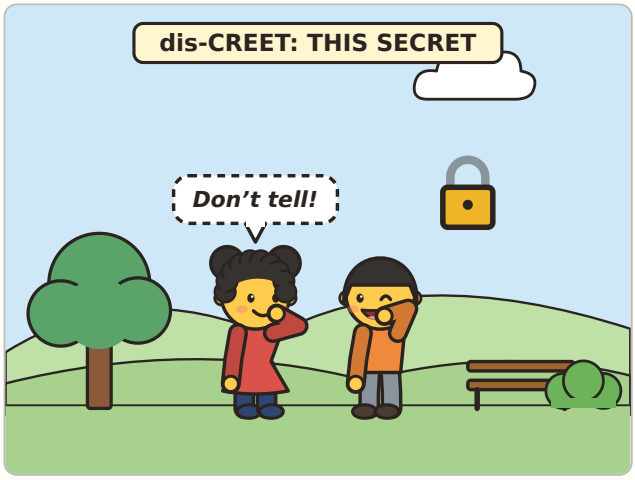
MEMORY HOOK **TACT = TOUCH: a light touch.** Tact comes from the Latin for touch. Aunt Greta asks if Felix likes her bright orange sweater, and he answers with a light touch: “It’s so cheerful!” He is **tactful**.

Felix gave a **tactful** *answer when his aunt asked whether he liked her very orange sweater.*

PARTS **tact** touch (Latin tactus) + **-ful** full of

SIMILAR diplomatic, sensitive, thoughtful, considerate
OPPOSITE tactless, blunt, insensitive

discreet dih-SKREET *adjective*



MEANING careful in what one says or does, especially in keeping secrets

MEMORY HOOK **dis-CREET: “THIS SECRET stays with me”.** Zoe whispers her news, and Kai zips his lips: “This secret stays with me.” He never tells a soul. Kai is **discreet**.

Be **discreet** *about the surprise party; Grandma notices everything.*

PARTS **dis** apart + **cre** sift, sort (Latin cernere)

SIMILAR careful, tactful, guarded, prudent
OPPOSITE indiscreet, careless, tactless

urbane ur-BAYN *adjective*



MEANING polished, courteous and at ease in any social setting

MEMORY HOOK **URBAN + E: city-polished manners.** At the museum gala, Victor greets each guest by name, bows, and tells just the right joke. His manners are city-polished: he is **urbane**.

The **urbane** *host remembered every guest’s name and made each one feel welcome.*

PARTS **urb** city

SIMILAR polished, sophisticated, refined, worldly
OPPOSITE boorish, uncouth, crude

suave SWAHV *adjective*



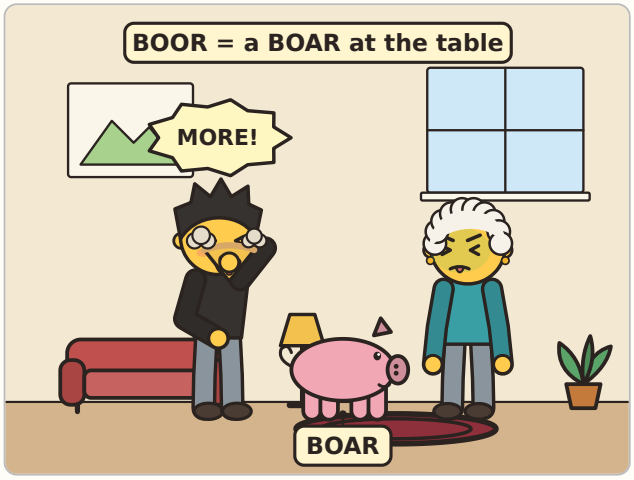
MEANING charming, confident and smooth in manner

MEMORY HOOK **S-U-A-V-E: Smooth, Unruffled, At ease.** Spell it out: Smooth, Unruffled, At ease, Very charming, Elegant. Jamal glides across the stage in his bow tie and never misses a step: he is **suave**.

The **suave** *magician bowed, winked and pulled a rose from behind his hat.*

SIMILAR smooth, charming, polished, debonair
OPPOSITE awkward, clumsy, graceless

boorish BOOR-ish *adjective*



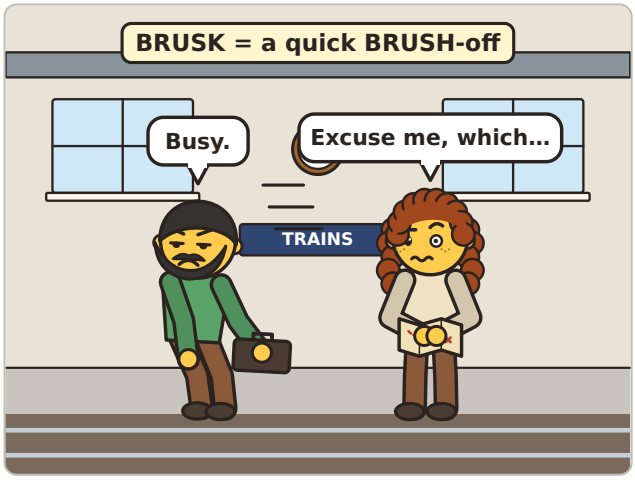
MEANING rough, loud and bad-mannered

MEMORY HOOK **a BOAR at the dinner table.** Picture a wild boar at a dinner party: snorting, grabbing, crumbs everywhere. Rex eats just like one. He is **boorish**.

His **boorish** *habit of talking with his mouth full annoyed everyone at the table.*

SIMILAR rude, coarse, crude, loutish
OPPOSITE courteous, refined, gracious

brusque BRUSK *adjective*



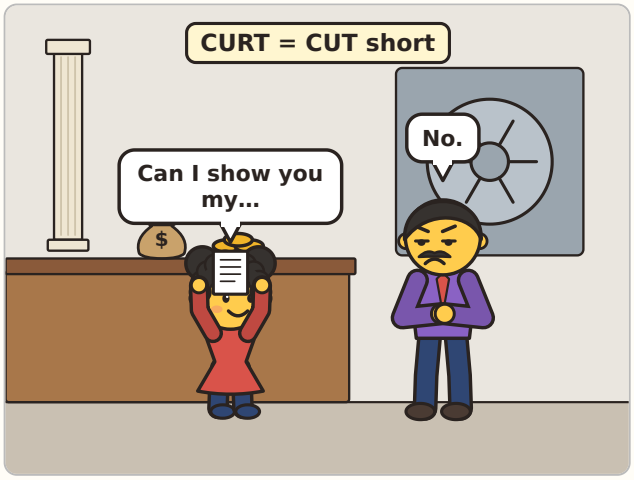
MEANING abrupt and short in speech or manner

MEMORY HOOK **BRUSK: a quick BRUSH-off.** Nell asks a hurrying man for directions, and he brushes her off with one word, “Busy,” and keeps walking. A brush-off that quick is **brusque**.

The busy clerk gave a **brusque** *nod and turned to the next customer.*

SIMILAR abrupt, blunt, short, gruff
OPPOSITE gracious, warm, courteous

curt KURT *adjective*



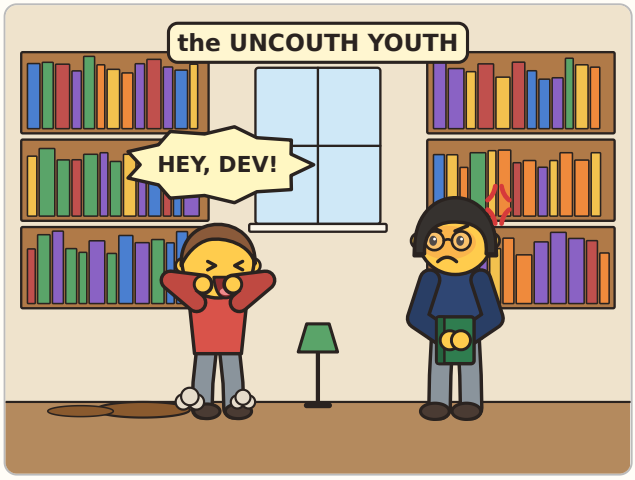
MEANING rudely brief

MEMORY HOOK **CURT = CUT short.** Zoe starts to show the banker her whole plan for a lemonade stand, and he cuts her short: “No.” A reply cut that short is **curt**.

Her **curt** *reply, “No,” ended the conversation.*

SIMILAR short, terse, abrupt, clipped
OPPOSITE friendly, gracious, expansive

uncouth un-**KOOTH** *adjective*



MEANING lacking good manners or refinement

MEMORY HOOK **the UNCOUTH YOUTH.** It rhymes: the youth with no manners is uncouth. Jonah stomps into the quiet library in muddy boots, yelling for his friend. He is **uncouth**.

Talking loudly on the phone all through the movie was **uncouth**.

PARTS **un** not + **couth** known (Old English cuth)

SIMILAR rude, crude, coarse, ill-mannered
OPPOSITE refined, polished, urbane

churlish **CHUR**-lish *adjective*



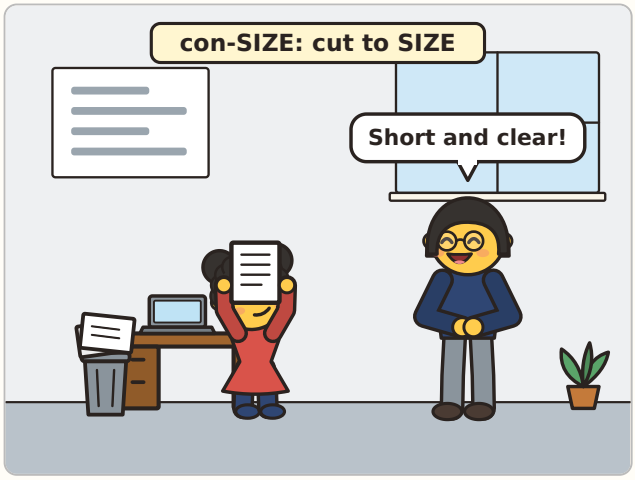
MEANING rude and mean-spirited; ungracious

MEMORY HOOK **CHURL rhymes with HURL.** Ivy gives Uncle Marcus a scarf she knitted herself, and he hurls it back with a grunt: “Itchy.” Hurling back a kind gift is **churlish**.

It would be **churlish** *to refuse a gift from a friend who saved for months to buy it.*

SIMILAR ungracious, rude, surly, mean
OPPOSITE gracious, courteous, polite

concise kun-**SICE** *adjective*



MEANING giving all the needed information in few words

MEMORY HOOK **con-SIZE: CUT TO SIZE.** Zoe’s report ran three pages, so she cut it to size: one tight paragraph that still says it all. Now it is **concise**.

Her **concise** *note said everything: “Pizza in the oven. Back at six.”*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **cis** cut (Latin caedere)

SIMILAR brief, compact, succinct, to the point
OPPOSITE wordy, long-winded, verbose

succinct suk-**SINKT** *adjective*



MEANING brief and clear; said in few words

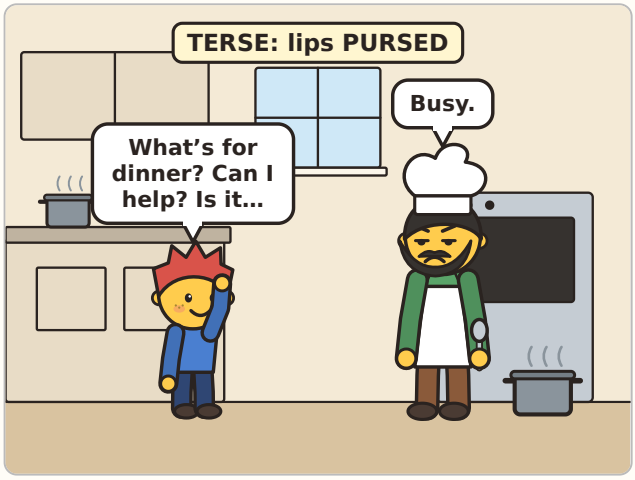
MEMORY HOOK **suk-SINKT: SINK it in one shot.** Kai sinks the ball in the bucket with one clean toss: no extra bounces, no wasted moves. A **succinct** answer is like that: it makes its point in one shot.

When the coach asked what went wrong, Lin gave a **succinct** *answer: “We stopped passing.”*

PARTS **suc** up from under (Latin sub) + **cinct** belted (Latin cingere)

SIMILAR brief, concise, crisp, pointed
OPPOSITE wordy, rambling, long-winded

terse TURS *adjective*



MEANING brief, sometimes to the point of seeming rude

MEMORY HOOK **TERSE: lips PURSED tight.** Chef Omar keeps his lips pursed while he cooks and answers every question with one word: "Busy." "Later." "No." His answers are **terse**.

*The **terse** text, "K," left Jamal wondering whether his sister was upset.*

SIMILAR brief, short, clipped, curt
OPPOSITE wordy, chatty, expansive

laconic luh-**KON**-ik *adjective*



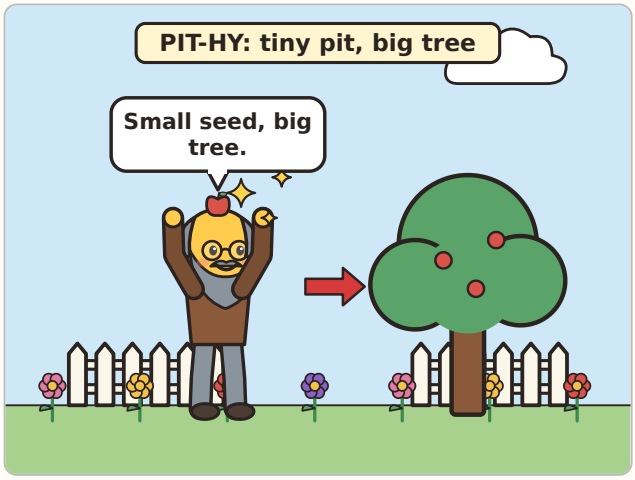
MEANING using very few words

MEMORY HOOK **LACK-ONIC: he LACKS words.** Asked how his long, long trip across the desert went, the rancher says only, "Fine." He lacks words to spare: he is **laconic**.

*The **laconic** rancher answered every question with "Yep" or "Nope."*

PARTS **Lacon** Laconia, the land around ancient Sparta + **-ic** like
SIMILAR brief, terse, of few words
OPPOSITE verbose, garrulous, talkative

pithy **PITH**-ee *adjective*



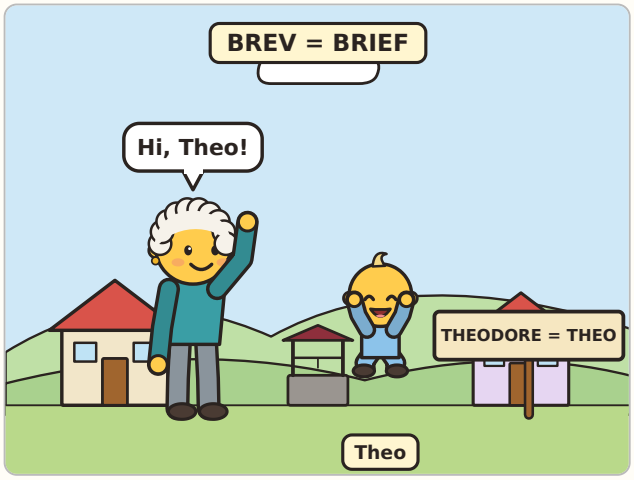
MEANING short but full of meaning

MEMORY HOOK **PIT-HY: a tiny PIT, a whole tree.** A tiny peach pit holds a whole tree inside it. A **pithy** saying is the same: a few words with a big idea packed in.

*Grandpa's **pithy** advice fit on a sticky note: "Measure twice, cut once."*

SIMILAR meaningful, punchy, concise, telling
OPPOSITE wordy, rambling, empty

brevity **BREV**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING shortness, especially in speech or writing

MEMORY HOOK **BREV = BRIEF: THEODORE becomes THEO.** Nobody calls little Theodore by his whole name; he is just Theo. Brev- means brief, and **brevity** is the art of keeping it short.

*The **brevity** of the speech delighted the hungry dinner guests.*

PARTS **brev** short + **-ity** the quality of
SIMILAR shortness, conciseness, briefness, terseness
OPPOSITE wordiness, length, verbosity

verbose ver-**BOSE** *adjective*



MEANING using more words than are needed

MEMORY HOOK **VERB-HOSE: a fire hose of words.** Ask the lawyer a yes-or-no question, and words gush out like water from a fire hose: "Firstly, secondly, furthermore…" He is **verbose**.

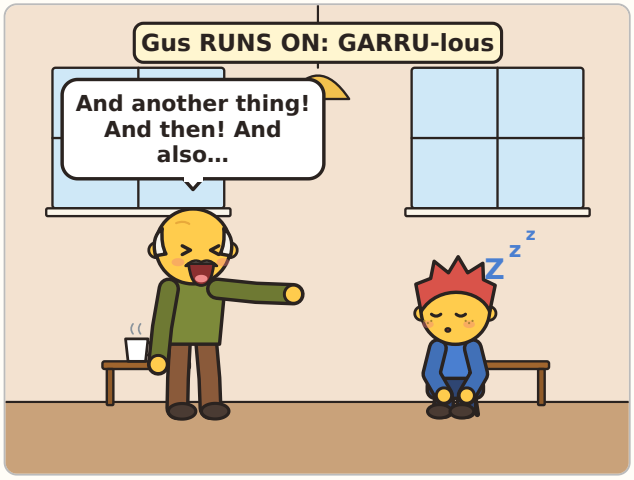
The **verbose** *instructions took three pages to explain how to plug in a lamp.*

PARTS **verb** word + **-ose** full of

SIMILAR wordy, long-winded, rambling, windy

OPPOSITE concise, succinct, terse

garrulous **GAIR**-uh-lus *adjective*



MEANING talking too much, especially about unimportant things

MEMORY HOOK **GARRU-lous: Gus RUNS ON.** Once Grandpa Gus starts talking, he runs on and on: the weather, his knees, the fish he almost caught. Gus is **garrulous**.

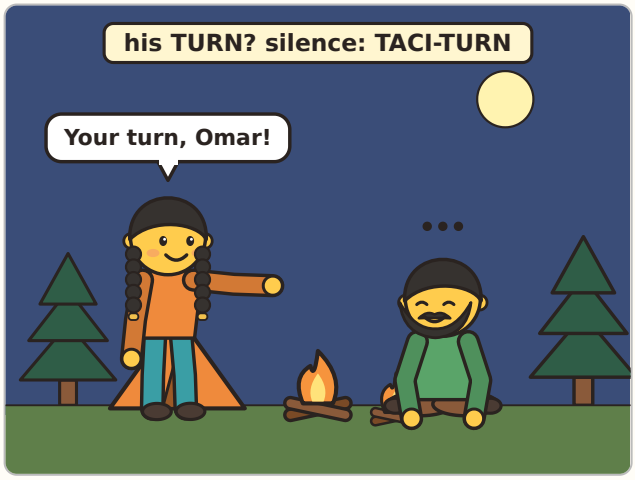
Our **garrulous** *seatmate told us about every one of her eleven cats.*

PARTS **garrul** chattering (Latin garrire, to chatter) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR talkative, chatty, gabby, long-winded

OPPOSITE taciturn, quiet, reticent

taciturn **TAS**-ih-turn *adjective*



MEANING quiet by habit; saying very little

MEMORY HOOK **TACIT TURN: his turn, and silence.** Around the campfire everyone takes a turn telling a story. When it is Omar's turn, he just smiles and pokes the fire. He is **taciturn**.

Her **taciturn** *uncle spoke perhaps ten words during the whole holiday dinner.*

PARTS **tacit** silent (Latin tacitus)

SIMILAR quiet, reserved, silent, reticent

OPPOSITE talkative, garrulous, voluble

voluble **VOL**-yuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING talking easily, quickly and at length

MEMORY HOOK **VOL-yuh-bul: VOLLEYBALL talk.** Lila and Maya talk like a volleyball game: words fly fast, bounce right back and never hit the ground. Both girls are **voluble**.

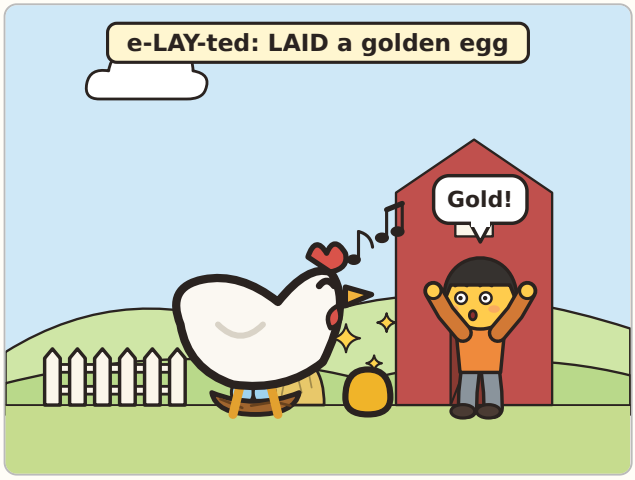
The **voluble** *tour guide chatted happily all the way up the mountain.*

PARTS **volu** roll (Latin volvere) + **-ble** able to

SIMILAR talkative, fluent, chatty, loquacious

OPPOSITE taciturn, reticent, quiet

elated ih-**LAY**-tid *adjective*



MEANING very happy and excited about something good

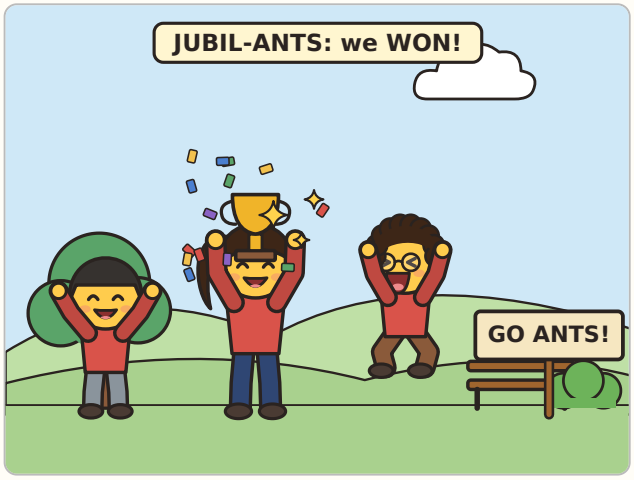
MEMORY HOOK **e-LAY-ted: she LAID a golden egg!.** Henrietta the hen has just laid a golden egg, and she flaps and clucks with joy. She is **elated**.

Maya was **elated** *when the letter said she had made the team.*

PARTS **e** out, up (from ex) + **lat** carried, lifted

SIMILAR overjoyed, thrilled, delighted, exhilarated
OPPOSITE dejected, crestfallen, despondent

jubilant JOO-buh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING joyful and triumphant, especially after a success

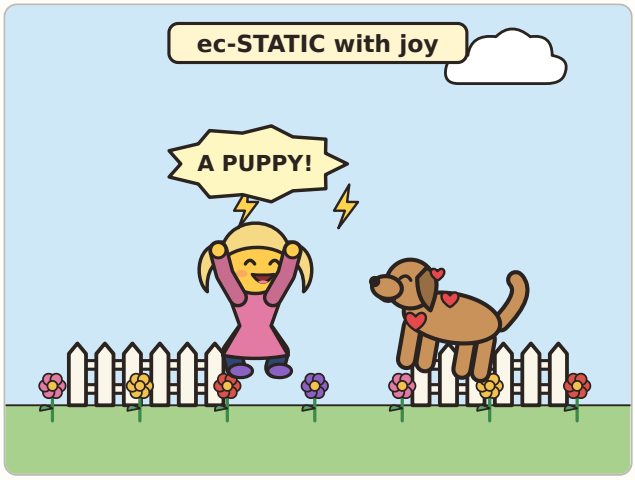
MEMORY HOOK **JUBIL-ANTS: the Ants won the cup!.** The Ants, the smallest team in the league, just won the cup, and every player is leaping and cheering. They are **jubilant**.

The **jubilant** *fans poured onto the field after the final whistle.*

PARTS **jubil** shout for joy (Latin jubilare) + **-ant** doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR triumphant, exultant, joyful, overjoyed
OPPOSITE dejected, despondent, defeated

ecstatic ek-**STAT**-ik *adjective*



MEANING overwhelmingly happy and excited

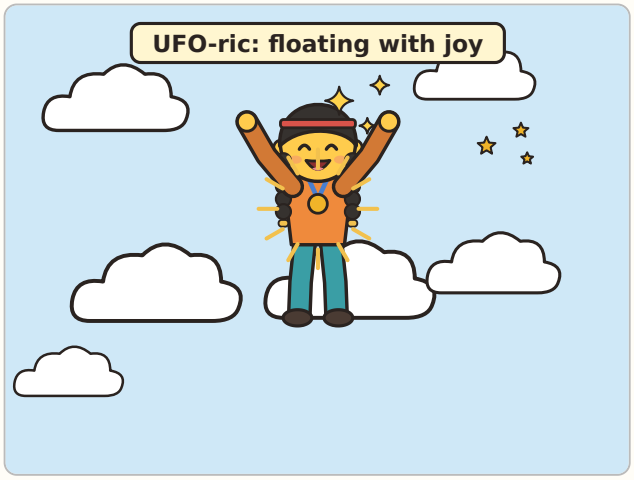
MEMORY HOOK **ec-STATIC: crackling with joy.** Ivy is so happy about her new puppy that she crackles like static electricity: she jumps, squeals and sparks with joy. She is **ecstatic**.

The puppy was **ecstatic** *to see its family come home after a week away.*

PARTS **ec** out (Greek ek) + **stat** stand, place + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR overjoyed, thrilled, euphoric, delighted
OPPOSITE miserable, devastated, glum

euphoric yoo-**FOR**-ik *adjective*



MEANING intensely happy and excited

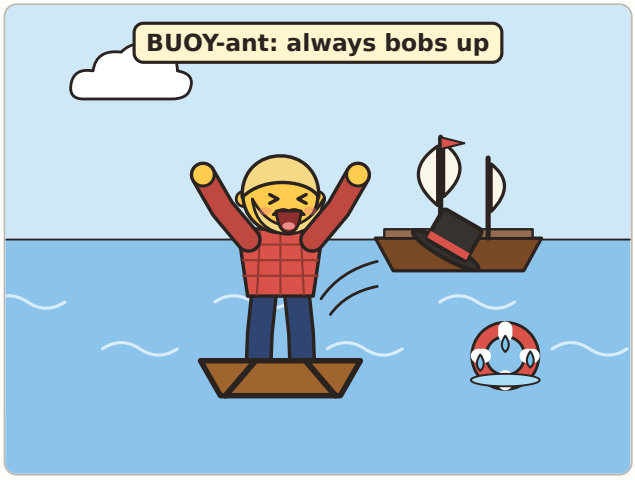
MEMORY HOOK **yoo-FOR-ik: floating like a UFO.** Tia finishes her first marathon and feels so light with joy that she could float off into the sky like a UFO. She is **euphoric**.

The **euphoric** *climbers hugged and took pictures on the summit.*

PARTS **eu** good, well + **phor** bearing, carrying (Greek pherein) + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR elated, ecstatic, overjoyed, exhilarated
OPPOSITE depressed, miserable, gloomy

buoyant **BOY**-unt *adjective*



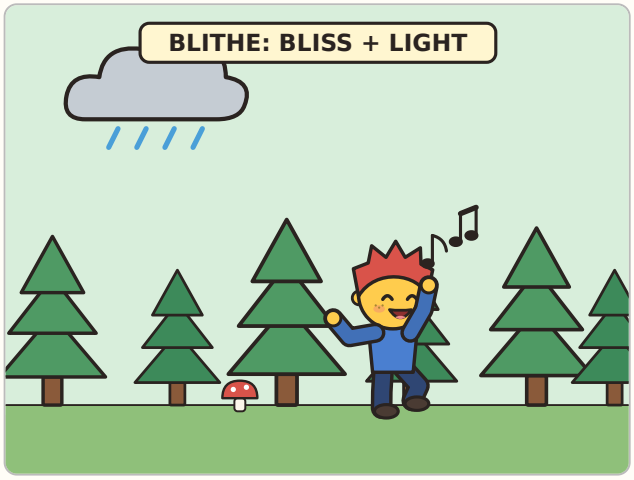
MEANING cheerful and hopeful; also, able to float

MEMORY HOOK **BUOY-ant: bobs up like a BUOY.** A wave knocks Sven's hat into the sea, and he just laughs and bobs along like a buoy. His spirits always float back up: he is **buoyant**.

Despite the rain, the campers stayed **buoyant**, *singing all the way back to their cabins.*

SIMILAR cheerful, upbeat, lighthearted, optimistic
OPPOSITE depressed, gloomy, despondent

blithe **BLYTHE** *adjective*



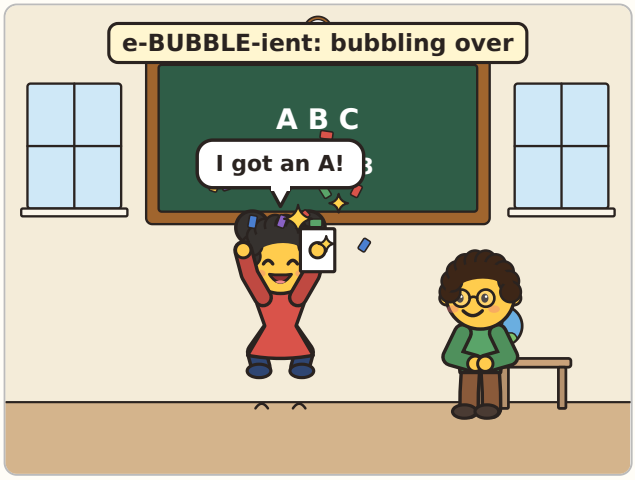
MEANING cheerful and carefree, sometimes carelessly so

MEMORY HOOK **BLITHE = BLISS + LIGHT.** Pip skips home whistling, blissful and light as a feather, without a care in the world, not even for the storm cloud right behind him. He is **blithe**.

Humming a **blithe** *tune, Zoe skipped down the lane to the pond.*

SIMILAR carefree, lighthearted, breezy, unconcerned
OPPOSITE worried, anxious, careful

ebullient ih-**BUL**-yunt *adjective*



MEANING bubbling over with cheerful energy

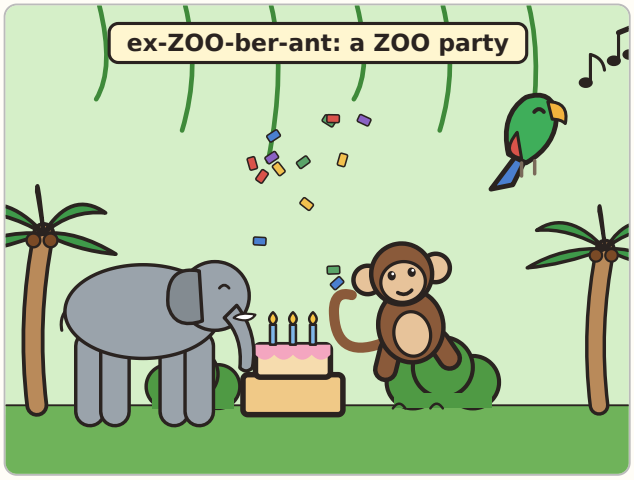
MEMORY HOOK **e-BUBBLE-ient: BUBBLING over.** Like a pot bubbling over, Zoe can't hold in her joy at her first A: she jumps, laughs and hugs the whole class. She is **ebullient**.

The **ebullient** *host greeted every guest with a hug and a joke.*

PARTS **e** out (from ex) + **bull** bubble, boil (Latin bullire) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR exuberant, bubbly, effervescent, buoyant
OPPOSITE subdued, gloomy, flat

exuberant ig-**ZOO**-ber-unt *adjective*



MEANING full of energy, excitement and joy

MEMORY HOOK **ex-ZOO-ber-ant: a ZOO bursting with joy.** The keeper rolls in a birthday cake, and the whole zoo bursts with joy: the monkey leaps, the parrot sings, the elephant sprays a happy fountain. The animals are **exuberant**.

The **exuberant** *puppy raced around the yard, leaping at every leaf.*

PARTS **ex** thoroughly + **uber** fruitful, rich (Latin uber) + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR lively, energetic, high-spirited, vivacious
OPPOSITE subdued, listless, glum

mirth MURTH *noun*



MEANING laughter, fun and amusement

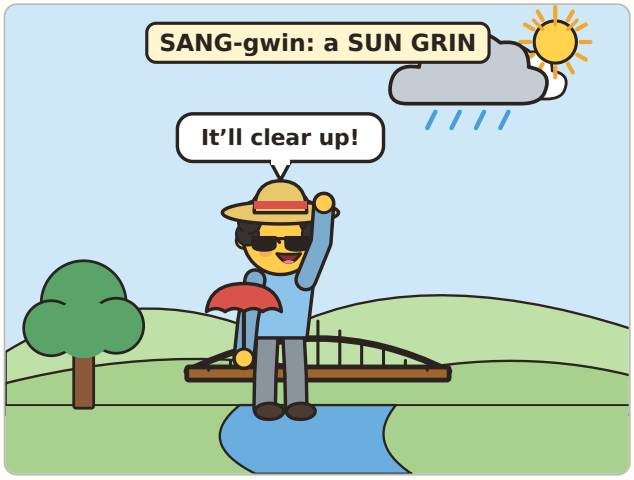
MEMORY HOOK **MIRTH rhymes with BIRTHday.** At Theo's birthday party, the puppy steals the party hat and wears it, and the whole room bursts into laughter. Birthdays bring **mirth**.

The puppet show filled the library with **mirth**.

SIMILAR laughter, merriment, glee, hilarity
OPPOSITE gloom, sadness, solemnity

5. Happy

sanguine SANG-gwin *adjective*



MEANING hopeful and confident about the future

MEMORY HOOK **SANG-gwin: a SUN GRIN.** The sky is gray, but Jamal wears a sun grin and packs the beach umbrella anyway: "It'll clear up by noon!" He is **sanguine**.

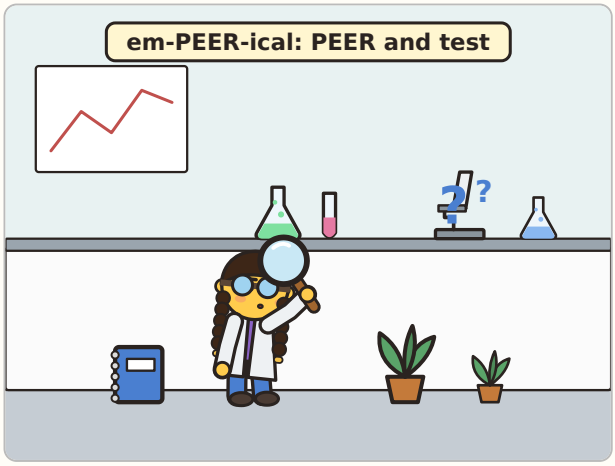
Despite the gray sky, Dad was **sanguine** *about our chances for a beach day.*

PARTS **sanguin** blood (Latin sanguis)

SIMILAR optimistic, hopeful, confident, upbeat
OPPOSITE pessimistic, gloomy, despairing

5. Happy

empirical em-PEER-ih-kul *adjective*



MEANING based on observation or experiment, not on theory alone

MEMORY HOOK **em-PEER-ical: PEER at it yourself.** Don't just guess how many seeds will sprout: peer at them, count them, write it down. Knowledge you get by peering and testing is **empirical**.

Sami gathered **empirical** *evidence by timing how long each paper airplane stayed in the air.*

PARTS **empir** experience (Greek empeiria) + **-ical** having to do with

SIMILAR observed, experimental, evidence-based, firsthand
OPPOSITE theoretical, speculative, hypothetical

6. Evidence and Proof

anecdotal an-ik-DOH-tul *adjective*



MEANING based on personal stories rather than careful study

MEMORY HOOK **ANNIE'S DOTE-TALE: just a story.** Annie swears her lucky socks win every game. Her only proof is Annie's tale about last Saturday, not a count of wins and losses. Her evidence is **anecdotal**.

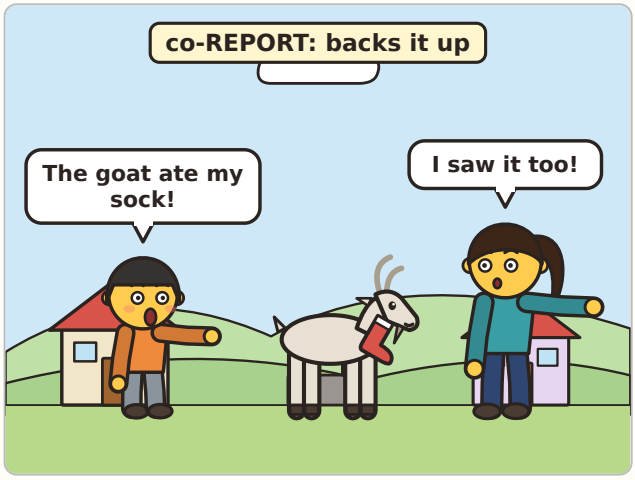
The only proof that the shortcut was faster was **anecdotal**: *Dev said it felt quicker.*

PARTS **an** not (Greek) + **ekdot** given out, published (Greek ekdotos)

SIMILAR story-based, informal, unverified
OPPOSITE empirical, scientific, systematic

6. Evidence and Proof

corroborate kuh-**ROB**-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to confirm or support with more evidence

MEMORY HOOK **co-ROB: a CO-REPORT backs it up.** "The goat ate my sock!" says Kai. "I saw it too!" says Maya, pointing at the sock in the goat's mouth. Her second report helps **corroborate** his story.

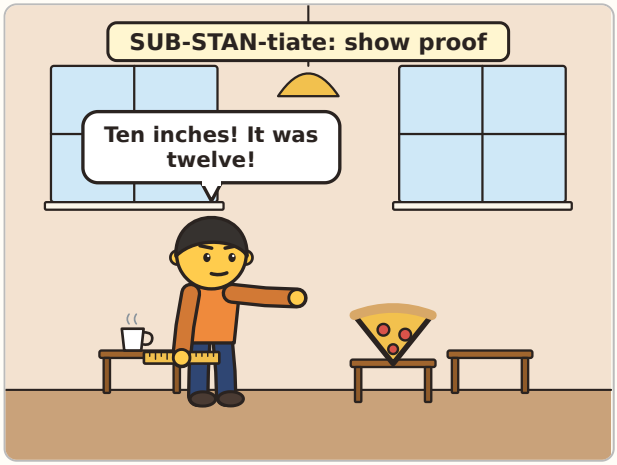
Two neighbors **corroborated** *the boy's story about the runaway goat.*

PARTS **cor** thoroughly (from con) + **robor** strength (Latin robur, oak) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR confirm, back up, support, bear out

OPPOSITE contradict, refute, disprove

substantiate sub-**STAN**-shee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to support a claim with proof

MEMORY HOOK **SUB-STAN-tiate: solid ground to STAND on.** A claim needs something solid to stand on. Dev backs up "The pizza shrank!" with a ruler and last month's photo. Now he can **substantiate** it.

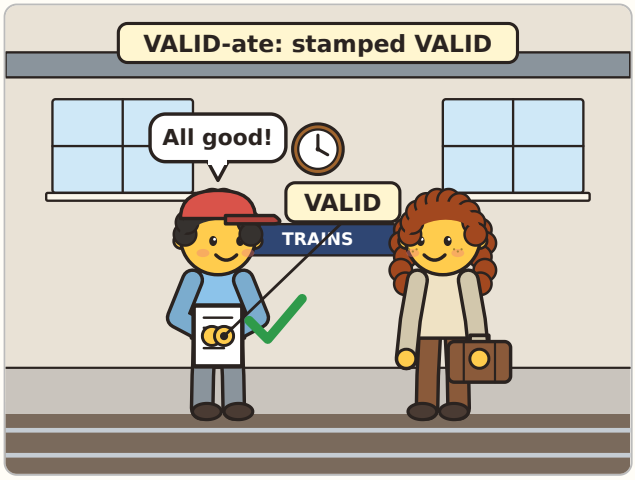
Can you **substantiate** *your claim that the cafeteria pizza is getting smaller?*

PARTS **sub** under + **stant** standing (Latin stare, to stand) + **-iate** to make

SIMILAR prove, support, back up, confirm

OPPOSITE disprove, refute, discredit

validate **VAL**-ih-dayt *verb*



MEANING to check or prove that something is sound or correct

MEMORY HOOK **VALID-ATE: stamped VALID.** The conductor checks Nell's ticket against the schedule and stamps it VALID. To check that something is sound and correct is to **validate** it.

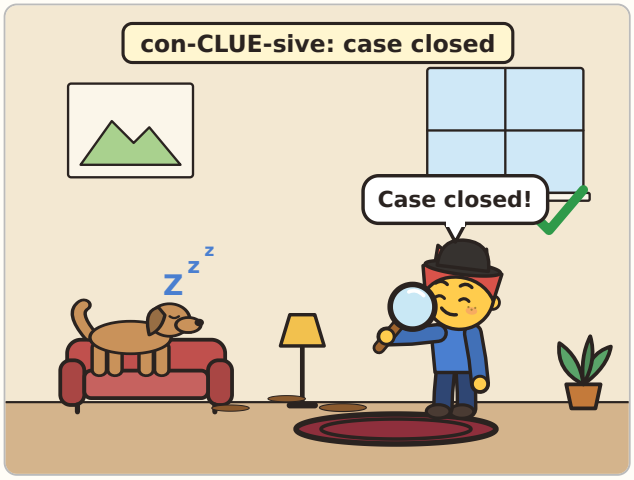
The lab ran the test three more times to **validate** *the surprising result.*

PARTS **val** strong, worth (Latin valere) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR confirm, verify, certify, prove

OPPOSITE invalidate, disprove, refute

conclusive kun-**KLOO**-siv *adjective*



MEANING settling a question beyond doubt

MEMORY HOOK **con-CLUE-sive: the CLUE that closes the case.** Muddy paw prints lead from the door straight to the dog asleep on the sofa: the last clue that closes the case. The evidence is **conclusive**.

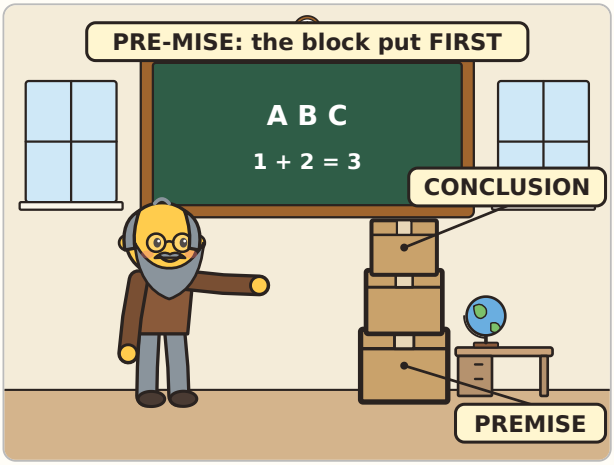
The muddy paw prints on the sofa were **conclusive***: the dog had been inside.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **clus** shut, close + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR decisive, definitive, convincing, final

OPPOSITE inconclusive, doubtful, questionable

premise PREM-is *noun*



MEANING a statement assumed true and used as a starting point for reasoning

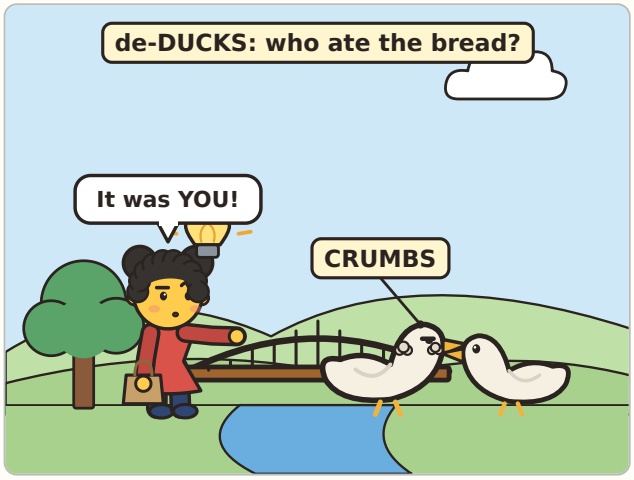
MEMORY HOOK **PRE-MISE: the block that goes FIRST.** An argument is a tower of blocks, and the **premise** is the block at the bottom: set down first, before anything is built on it. If it is wobbly, the whole tower falls.

The whole plan rested on one **premise***: that the store would still be open at nine.*

PARTS **pre** before + **mis** sent, put (Latin mittere)

SIMILAR assumption, basis, starting point, supposition
OPPOSITE conclusion

deduce dih-DOOS *verb*



MEANING to reach a conclusion by reasoning from facts

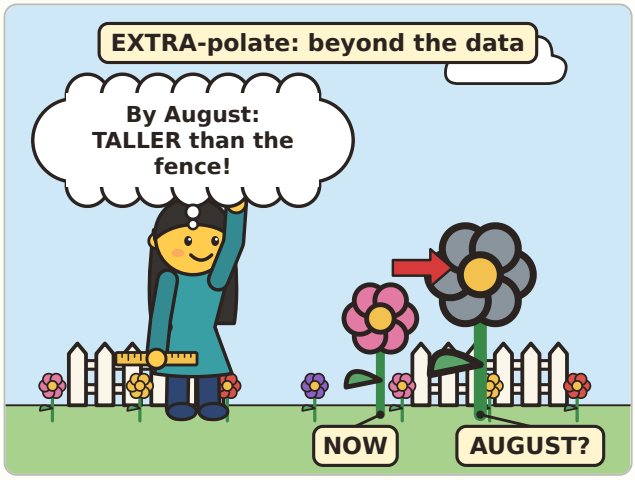
MEMORY HOOK **de-DUCKS: crumbs on whose beak?.** The bread is gone, and one duck has crumbs all over its beak. Zoe didn't see it happen, but she can **deduce** who ate it.

From the crumbs on his shirt, Mom **deduced** *who had eaten the last cookie.*

PARTS **de** down, from + **duc** lead

SIMILAR infer, reason, conclude, work out
OPPOSITE guess

extrapolate ik-STRAP-uh-layt *verb*



MEANING to use known facts or trends to predict what lies beyond them

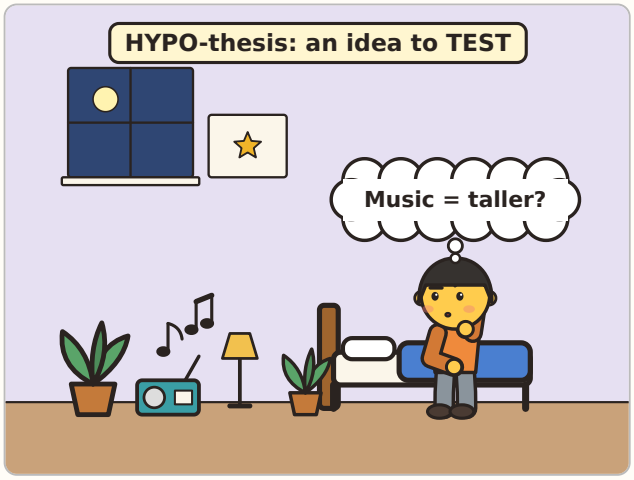
MEMORY HOOK **EXTRA-polate: draw the line EXTRA far.** Lin's sunflower grew a foot each week, so she draws the line extra far, past what she has measured: "By August it will beat the fence!" To predict that way is to **extrapolate**.

From three weeks of growth, Lin **extrapolated** *that her sunflower would top the fence by August.*

PARTS **extra** beyond, outside

SIMILAR project, extend, predict, infer

hypothesis hye-POTH-uh-sis *noun*



MEANING a proposed explanation that can be tested

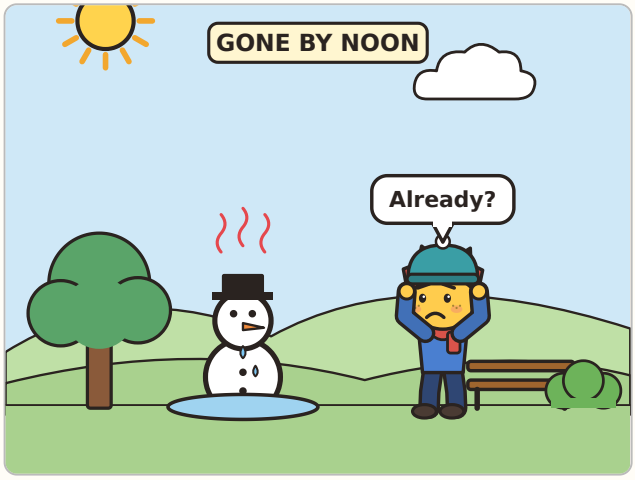
MEMORY HOOK **HYPO = UNDER: an idea put UNDER a test.** Kai guesses that music helps plants grow, so he plays songs to one plant and not to the other. A guess that you put under a test is a **hypothesis**.

Kai's **hypothesis** *was that plants given music would grow taller.*

PARTS **hypo** under + **thesis** a placing, a proposal (Greek)

SIMILAR educated guess, proposition, supposition, conjecture
OPPOSITE fact, certainty

ephemeral ih-**FEM**-er-ul *adjective*



MEANING lasting a very short time

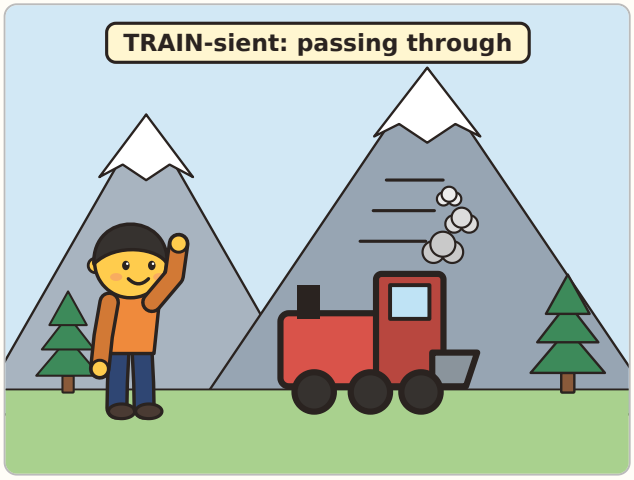
MEMORY HOOK **a snowman in the noon sun.** Pip's snowman stood proud at breakfast; by lunch it was a puddle and a carrot. Its life was **ephemeral**.

The rainbow was **ephemeral**, *gone before Lila could find her camera.*

PARTS **epi** upon, for (Greek) + **hemer** day (Greek hemera)

SIMILAR short-lived, brief, passing, momentary
OPPOSITE lasting, enduring, permanent

transient **TRAN**-zee-unt *adjective*



MEANING lasting only a short time; staying only briefly

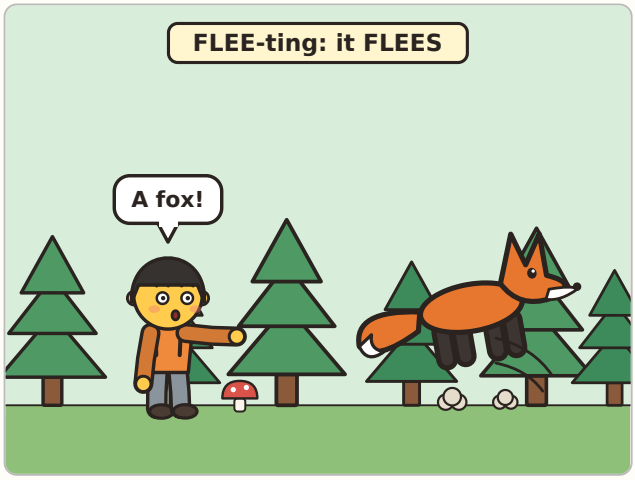
MEMORY HOOK **TRAIN-sient: a TRAIN passing through.** The express train roars through the mountain valley, toots once and is gone. Its visit is **transient**: here for a moment, then away.

The **transient** *storm soaked the picnic and moved on within ten minutes.*

PARTS **trans** across, through + **i** go (Latin ire) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR temporary, passing, brief, short-lived
OPPOSITE permanent, lasting, enduring

fleeting **FLEE**-ting *adjective*



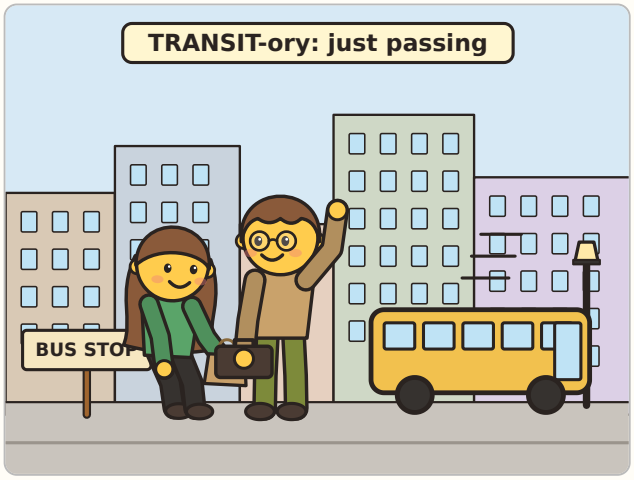
MEANING passing very quickly

MEMORY HOOK **FLEE-ting: it FLEES before you look.** Kai turns, and the fox flees into the trees: one flash of orange tail, and it is gone. His look at it was **fleeting**.

Kai caught a **fleeting** *glimpse of the fox before it vanished into the trees.*

SIMILAR brief, momentary, passing, quick
OPPOSITE lasting, long, enduring

transitory **TRAN**-sih-tor-ee *adjective*



MEANING not permanent; lasting only for a time

MEMORY HOOK **TRANSIT-ory: life at a bus stop.** Nobody stays long at a bus stop: people wait a few minutes, then ride away in transit. A stay that short is **transitory**.

Her disappointment was **transitory**; *by dinner she was laughing again.*

PARTS **trans** across + **it** gone (Latin ire, to go) + **-ory** having to do with

SIMILAR temporary, impermanent, short-lived, passing
OPPOSITE permanent, lasting, enduring

evanescent ev-uh-**NES**-unt *adjective*



MEANING quickly fading from sight or memory

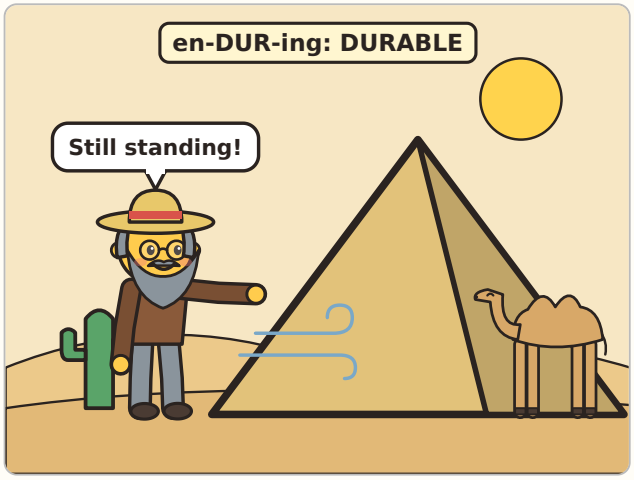
MEMORY HOOK **e-VANISH-ent: blink, and it is gone.** Each firefly glows for a moment, then vanishes into the dark before Zoe can point to it. Their light is **evanescent**.

*The **evanescent** glow of the fireflies flickered across the meadow.*

PARTS **e** out (from ex) + **vanesc** vanish (Latin vanescere) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR fading, vanishing, fleeting, ephemeral
OPPOSITE permanent, lasting, enduring

enduring en-**DOOR**-ing *adjective*



MEANING lasting a long time

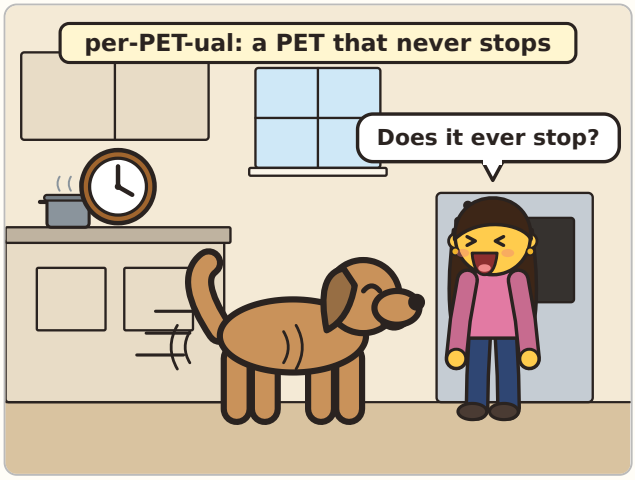
MEMORY HOOK **en-DUR-ing: as DURABLE as stone.** The great stone pyramid has stood through thousands of years of sun and sandstorms, and visitors still come to see it. It is **enduring**.

*Their **enduring** friendship began in kindergarten and is still going strong.*

PARTS **en** in, thoroughly + **dur** hard, lasting (Latin durus)

SIMILAR lasting, long-lived, abiding, durable
OPPOSITE fleeting, short-lived, transient

perpetual per-**PECH**-oo-ul *adjective*



MEANING never ending or changing; constant

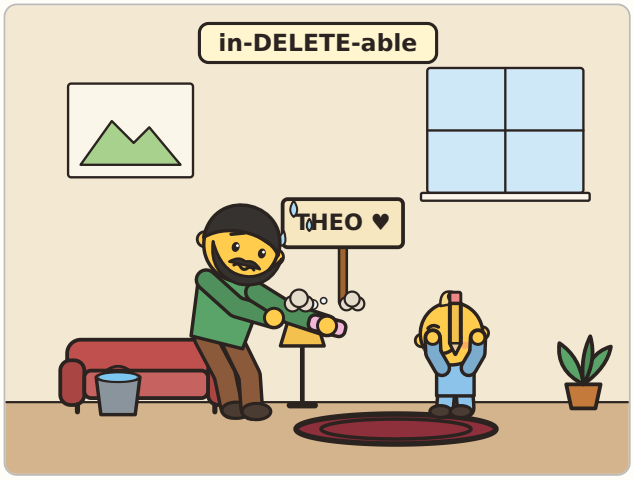
MEMORY HOOK **per-PET-ual: a PET whose tail never stops.** Biscuit the dog wags his tail morning, noon and night; even in his sleep it thumps. His wagging is **perpetual**.

*The **perpetual** drip of the leaky faucet kept Felix awake all night.*

PARTS **per** through

SIMILAR endless, constant, unending, everlasting
OPPOSITE temporary, brief, intermittent

indelible in-**DEL**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING impossible to erase, remove or forget

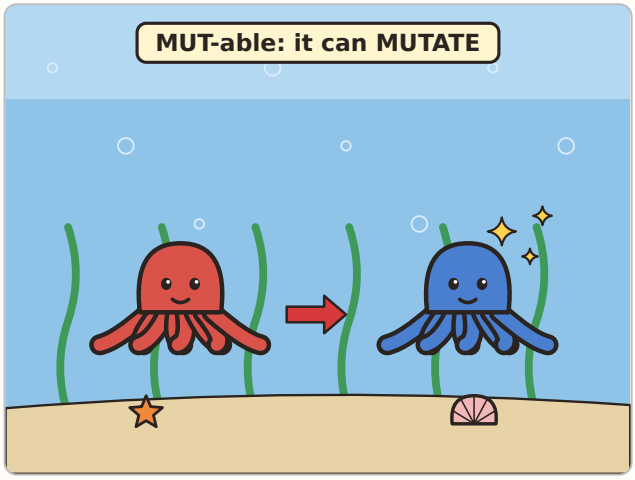
MEMORY HOOK **in-DELETE-able: you can't DELETE it.** Theo's marker drawing won't wash off the wall, no matter how hard Dad scrubs: you can't delete it. The ink is **indelible**.

*Theo drew on the wall with **indelible** marker, and no amount of scrubbing helped.*

PARTS **in** not + **del** wipe out (Latin delere) + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR permanent, lasting, unforgettable, ineradicable
OPPOSITE erasable, temporary, fleeting

mutable MYOO-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING able or likely to change

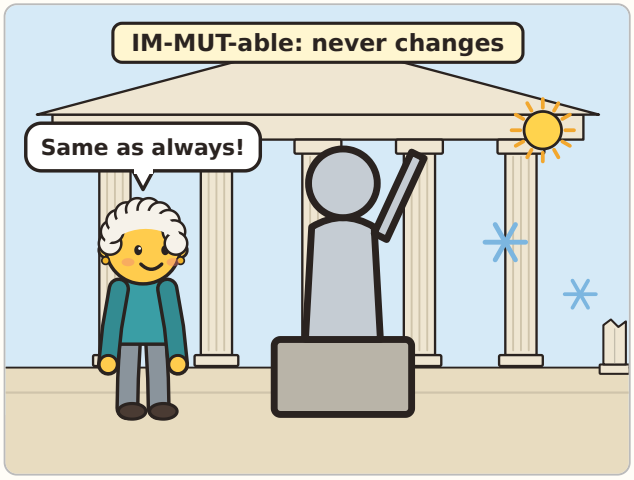
MEMORY HOOK **MUT = MUTATE: able to change.** The octopus turns red, then blue, then sandy brown to match whatever it touches. A creature that changes that easily is **mutable**.

Spring weather is **mutable***: sunshine at noon, hail by three.*

PARTS **mut** change (Latin mutare) + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR changeable, variable, alterable, fluid
OPPOSITE immutable, fixed, constant

immutable ih-MYOO-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING never changing; unable to be changed

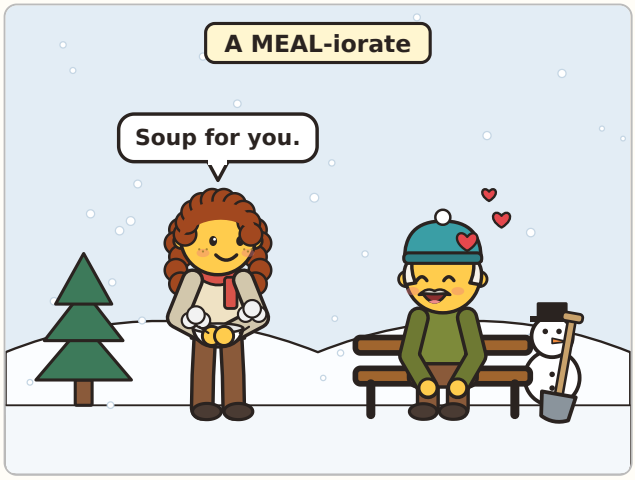
MEMORY HOOK **IM-MUT-able: the statue never changes.** Sun, snow, rain or wind, the old stone statue in the square keeps the very same pose year after year. It is **immutable**.

For Grandma, Sunday dinner at five o'clock was an **immutable** *rule.*

PARTS **im** not (in- before m) + **mut** change + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR unchangeable, fixed, permanent, constant
OPPOSITE mutable, changeable, variable

ameliorate uh-MEEL-yuh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to make a bad situation better

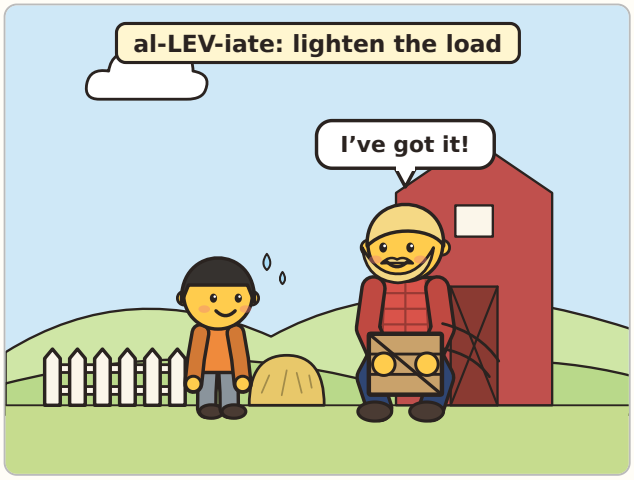
MEMORY HOOK **A MEAL-iorate: a MEAL makes it better.** Grandpa Gus is cold, tired and cranky after shoveling, until Nell brings him a hot bowl of soup. A good meal can **ameliorate** a gloomy afternoon.

New streetlights helped **ameliorate** *the problem of dark, lonely corners.*

PARTS **a** to (from ad) + **melior** better (Latin melior) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR improve, better, ease, relieve
OPPOSITE worsen, aggravate, exacerbate

alleviate uh-LEE-vee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to make pain or trouble easier to bear

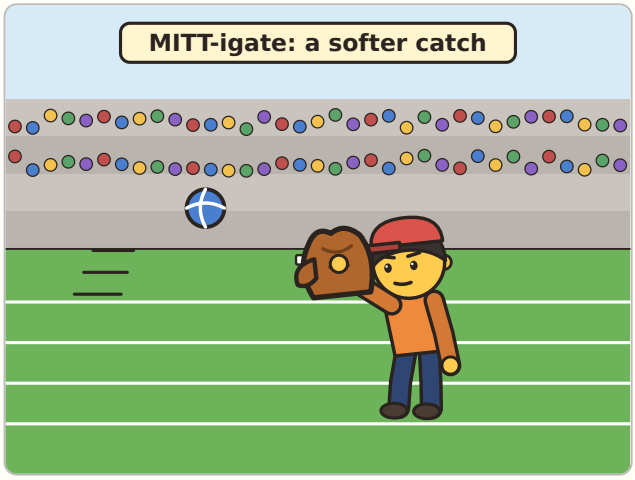
MEMORY HOOK **al-LEV-iate: LIGHTEN the load.** Kai staggers under a heavy crate until Sven lifts it onto his own broad shoulders. Taking some of the weight is a way to **alleviate** a burden.

An extra checkout lane helped **alleviate** *the long lines at the store.*

PARTS **al** to (from ad) + **lev** light (not heavy), lift + **-iate** to make

SIMILAR ease, relieve, lessen, lighten
OPPOSITE aggravate, worsen, intensify

mitigate **MIT**-ih-gayt *verb*



MEANING to make less severe or harmful

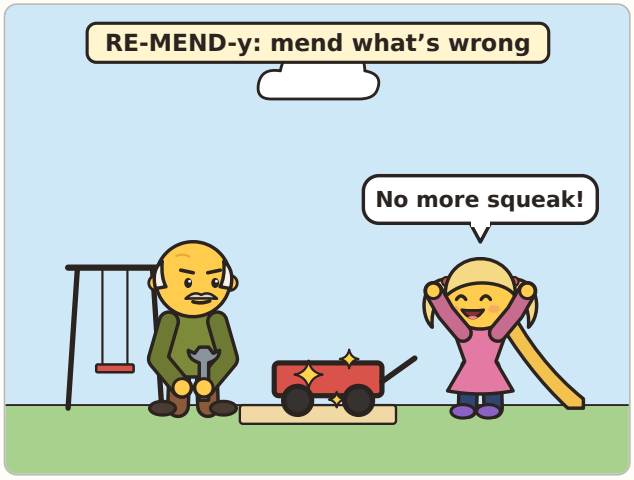
MEMORY HOOK **MITT-igate: a big MITT softens the blow.** A fast ball stings a bare hand, but a thick padded mitt softens the catch. The mitt helps **mitigate** the sting.

Planting trees along the river helped **mitigate** *the spring floods.*

PARTS **mitig** soft, mild (Latin mitis) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR lessen, reduce, soften, ease
OPPOSITE worsen, intensify, aggravate

remedy **REM**-ih-dee *verb*



MEANING to fix or correct something that is wrong

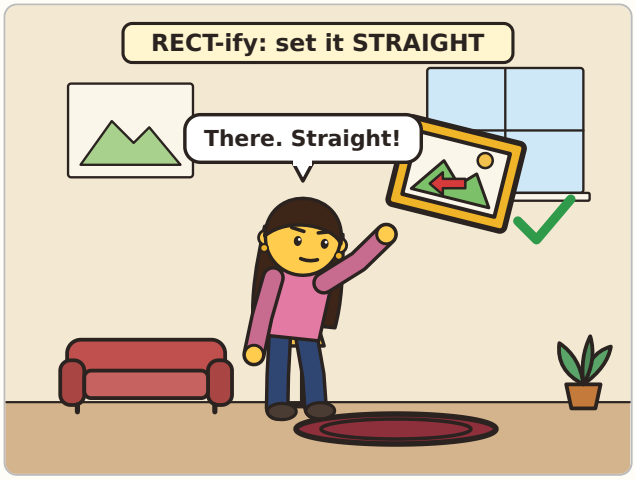
MEMORY HOOK **RE-MEND-y: MEND what's wrong.** The wagon wheel squeaks and wobbles until Grandpa Gus mends it with a wrench and a drop of oil. To mend what's wrong is to **remedy** it.

The mechanic **remedied** *the squeak with a single drop of oil.*

PARTS **re** back, again + **med** heal (Latin mederi)

SIMILAR fix, correct, repair, cure
OPPOSITE worsen, aggravate

rectify **REK**-tuh-fye *verb*



MEANING to put right; to correct

MEMORY HOOK **RECT = straight, as in RECTangle.** The family photo hangs crooked, so Priya nudges it until every corner is square, like a rectangle. To set something straight is to **rectify** it.

The store **rectified** *its mistake by refunding the extra charge.*

PARTS **rect** straight, right + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR correct, fix, put right, amend
OPPOSITE worsen

enhance en-**HANS** *verb*



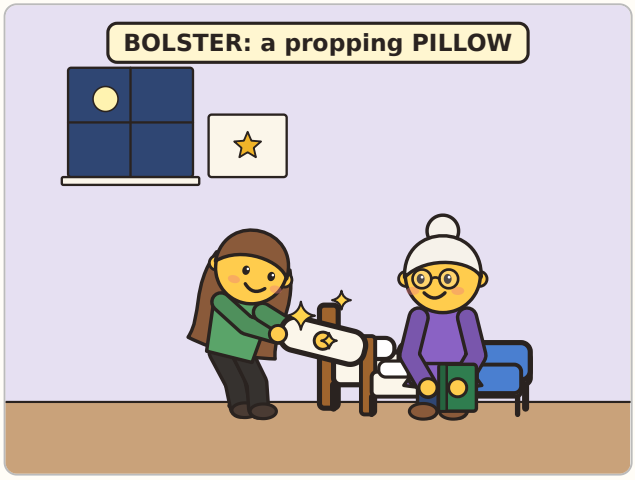
MEANING to improve the quality, value or appeal of

MEMORY HOOK **en-HANS: Hans adds the cherry on top.** The sundae is already good, but Hans adds whipped cream and a cherry on top. Little touches like that **enhance** it.

A pinch of salt will **enhance** *the sweetness of the caramel.*

SIMILAR improve, boost, heighten, strengthen
OPPOSITE diminish, reduce, worsen

bolster **BOHL**-ster *verb*



MEANING to support or strengthen

MEMORY HOOK **a BOLSTER is a propping PILLOW.** Granny Mae keeps slumping on the bed until Rosa props her up with a long, firm pillow called a bolster. To prop up and support something is to **bolster** it.

Winning the first game **bolstered** *the team's confidence.*

SIMILAR strengthen, support, reinforce, boost
OPPOSITE weaken, undermine

rejuvenate rih-**JOO**-vuh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to make young, fresh or lively again

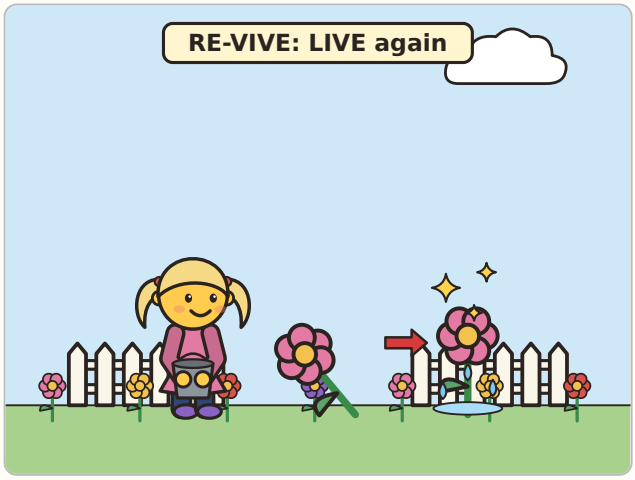
MEMORY HOOK **re-JUVEN-ate: JUVENILE again.** Grandpa Gus borrows Pip's skateboard and rolls down the sidewalk laughing like a ten-year-old. The ride seems to **rejuvenate** him.

A week at the lake **rejuvenated** *the whole family.*

PARTS **re** again + **juven** young (Latin juvenis) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR refresh, renew, revitalize, restore
OPPOSITE age, exhaust, drain

revive rih-**VIVE** *verb*



MEANING to bring back to life, strength or use

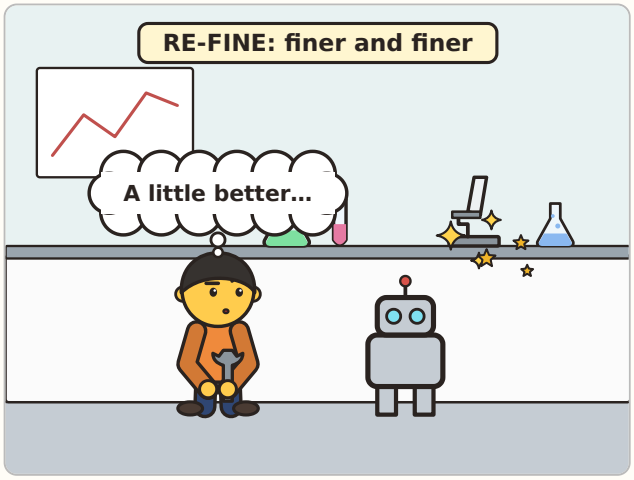
MEMORY HOOK **RE-VIVE: make it LIVE again.** The droopy flowers perk right up after Ivy gives them a long drink: they live again! Water can **revive** a wilted plant.

A bucket of water **revived** *the wilted tomato plants.*

PARTS **re** again + **viv** live, life

SIMILAR restore, renew, bring back, resuscitate
OPPOSITE extinguish, abandon

refine rih-**FINE** *verb*



MEANING to improve by making small changes; also, to purify

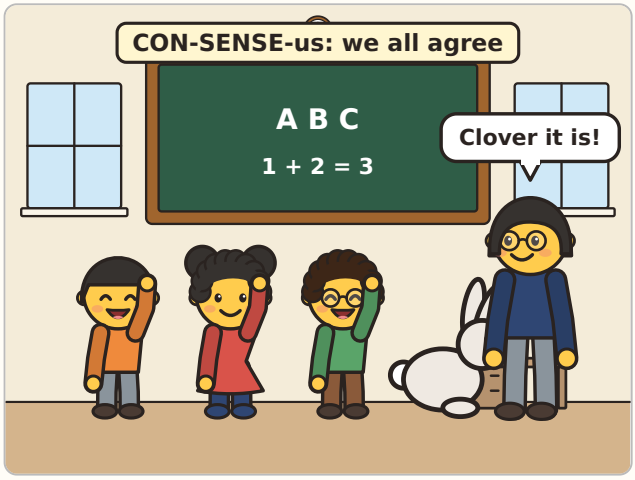
MEMORY HOOK **RE-FINE: fine, then FINER.** Dev's robot rolls, but it wobbles. He tightens one gear, then another, making it a little finer each time. Little by little, he will **refine** it.

Lila **refined** *her essay through five careful drafts.*

PARTS **re** again + **fine** fine, pure

SIMILAR polish, perfect, improve, hone
OPPOSITE coarsen, worsen

consensus kun-**SEN**-sus *noun*



MEANING general agreement among a group

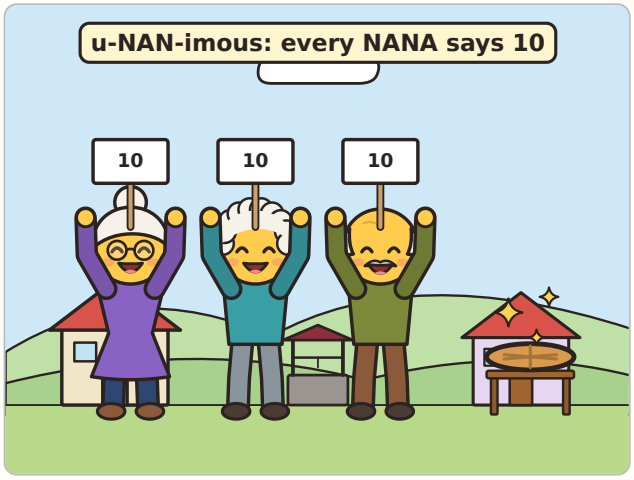
MEMORY HOOK **CON-SENSE-us: we all SENSE the same.** The class votes on a name for the new bunny, and almost every hand goes up for “Clover.” When nearly everyone senses the same, the group has a **consensus**.

After a long debate, the club reached a **consensus** *: pizza on Fridays.*

PARTS **con** together + **sens** feel, think

SIMILAR agreement, accord, harmony, unity
OPPOSITE disagreement, dissent, discord

unanimous yoo-**NAN**-uh-mus *adjective*



MEANING agreed on by everyone

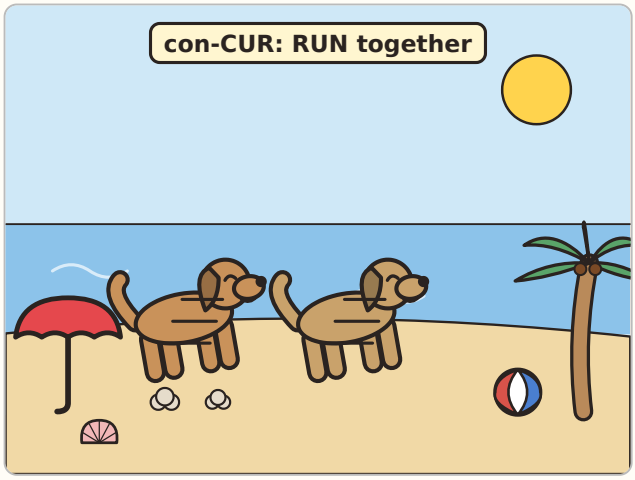
MEMORY HOOK **u-NAN-imous: every NANA votes 10.** Nana Mae, Nana Lou and Grandpa Gus judge the pie contest, and all three hold up a perfect 10 for the cherry pie. Every vote the same: the decision is **unanimous**.

The vote was **unanimous** *: all twelve players wanted the blue jerseys.*

PARTS **un** one (Latin unus) + **anim** mind, spirit + **-ous** having

SIMILAR united, undivided, of one mind
OPPOSITE divided, split

concur kun-**KUR** *verb*



MEANING to agree

MEMORY HOOK **con-CUR: minds that RUN together.** Two dogs spot the same ball and race for it side by side, of one mind. When two people’s thoughts run together like that, they **concur**.

Both coaches **concurred** *that the game should wait until the storm passed.*

PARTS **con** together + **cur** run

SIMILAR agree, assent, see eye to eye
OPPOSITE disagree, dissent, differ

accord uh-**KORD** *noun*



MEANING agreement; harmony

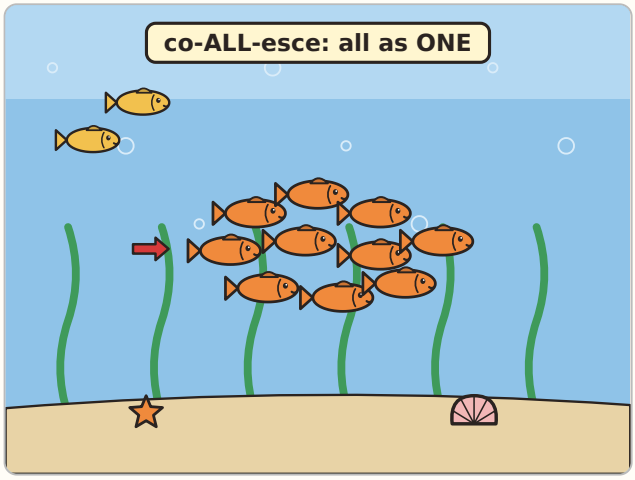
MEMORY HOOK **ac-CHORD: notes in harmony.** Lin plays three notes at once on the piano, and they sound lovely together: a chord. People who get along in harmony like that are in **accord**.

The neighbors reached an **accord** *about where to build the shared fence.*

PARTS **ac** to (from ad) + **cord** heart

SIMILAR agreement, harmony, pact, treaty
OPPOSITE discord, conflict, disagreement

coalesce koh-uh-**LES** *verb*



MEANING to come together to form one whole

MEMORY HOOK **co-ALL-esce: ALL together as one.** Dozens of little fish swim closer and closer until they move like one big fish. When separate parts join into a single whole, they **coalesce**.

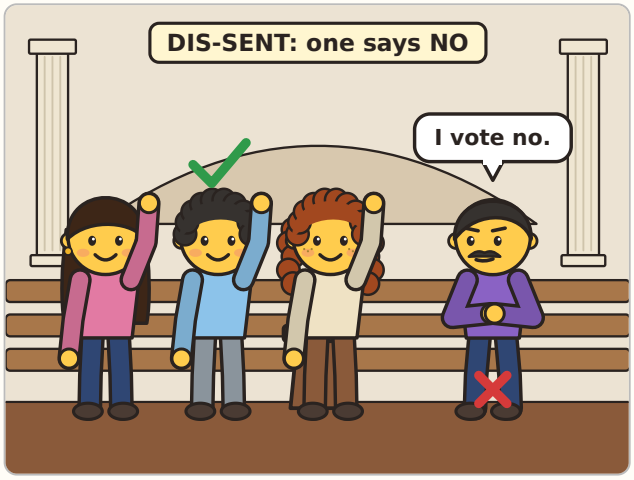
Tiny raindrops **coalesced** *into one fat drop at the edge of the roof.*

PARTS **co** together (from con) + **alesc** grow (Latin alescere)

SIMILAR merge, unite, combine, fuse

OPPOSITE separate, divide, split

dissent dih-**SENT** *noun*



MEANING disagreement with an official or majority view

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-SENT: one vote SENT the other way.** Every hand goes up for the new rule except Marcus's; he sends his vote the other way and says why. His "no" is a **dissent**.

Only one hand went up in **dissent** *when the class voted for the zoo trip.*

PARTS **dis** apart + **sent** feel, think

SIMILAR disagreement, objection, opposition, protest

OPPOSITE agreement, consensus, assent

discord **DIS**-kord *noun*



MEANING disagreement; a lack of harmony

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-CHORD: notes that clash.** Kai strums one song on the guitar while Lila plays a different one on the violin, and the dog howls. Sounds that clash, like people who clash, are in **discord**.

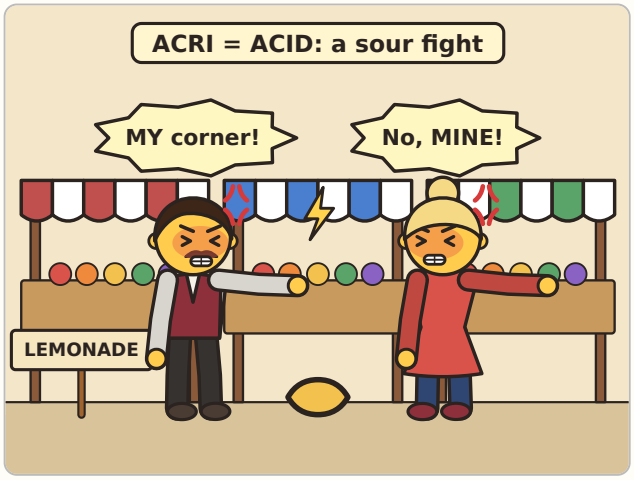
A quarrel over the last pancake brought **discord** *to the breakfast table.*

PARTS **dis** apart + **cord** heart

SIMILAR conflict, strife, friction, disharmony

OPPOSITE harmony, accord, agreement

acrimonious ak-ruh-**MOH**-nee-us *adjective*



MEANING angry and bitter in tone

MEMORY HOOK **ACRI = ACID: a sour, bitter fight.** The two lemonade sellers argue over the best corner until their words turn as sour as acid. Their quarrel is **acrimonious**.

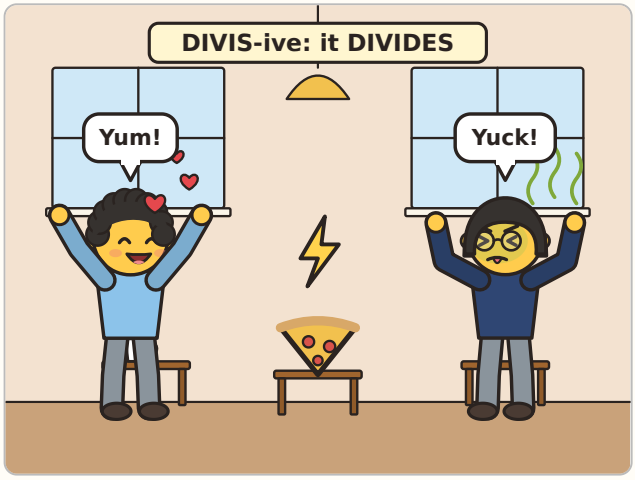
The **acrimonious** *argument over the parking space lasted twenty minutes.*

PARTS **acri** sharp, sour (Latin acer) + **-mony** the state of + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR bitter, hostile, angry, rancorous

OPPOSITE friendly, cordial, harmonious

divisive dih-**VYE**-siv *adjective*



MEANING causing disagreement or splitting people into sides

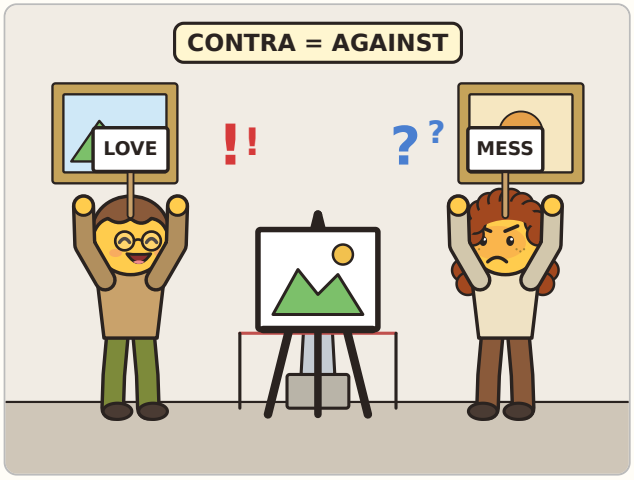
MEMORY HOOK **DIVIS-ive: it DIVIDES the table.** Put a pineapple pizza on the table, and the family splits in two: half cheer, half groan. A topic that divides people is **divisive**.

Pineapple on pizza is a surprisingly **divisive** *topic in our family.*

PARTS **divis** divided (Latin dividere) + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR polarizing, controversial, contentious
OPPOSITE unifying, uniting

controversy **KON**-truh-vur-see *noun*



MEANING a long public disagreement

MEMORY HOOK **CONTRA-VERSE: views turned AGAINST.** At the museum, half the crowd loves the new painting and half calls it a mess, and the argument goes on for weeks in public. Views turned against each other make a **controversy**.

The new school mascot stirred up a **controversy** *on the letters page of the local paper.*

PARTS **contro** against (from contra) + **vers** turn

SIMILAR dispute, debate, argument, quarrel
OPPOSITE agreement, consensus, accord

abundant uh-**BUN**-dunt *adjective*



MEANING existing in large amounts; more than enough

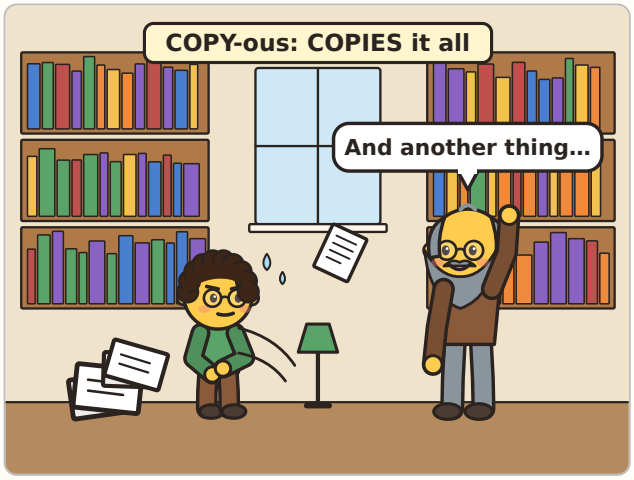
MEMORY HOOK **a-BUN-dant: a BUN DANCE.** The baker made so many buns that they cover every shelf and table, and he does a happy bun dance. Buns are **abundant**.

Blackberries were **abundant** *along the creek that summer.*

PARTS **ab** off, away + **und** wave (Latin unda) + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR plentiful, ample, bountiful, copious
OPPOSITE scarce, sparse, meager

copious **KOH**-pee-us *adjective*



MEANING plentiful; in large amounts

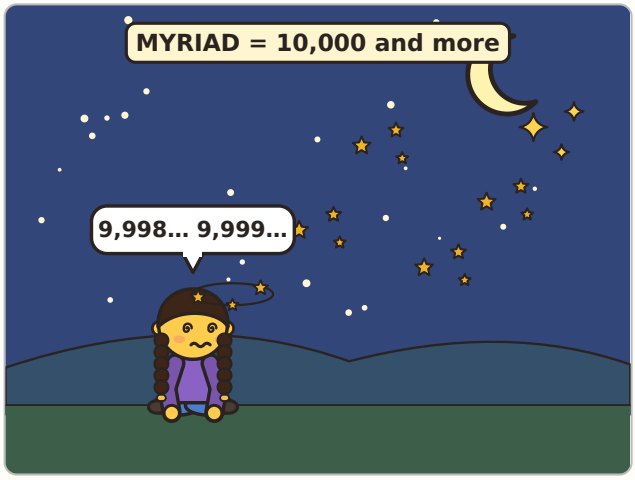
MEMORY HOOK **COPY-ous: he COPIES down everything.** Sami copies down every word the guide says, page after page after page. His notes are **copious**.

Sami took **copious** *notes on the museum tour, filling half his notebook.*

PARTS **copi** plenty (Latin copia) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR plentiful, abundant, ample, profuse
OPPOSITE scant, meager, sparse

myriad **MEER**-ee-ud *adjective*



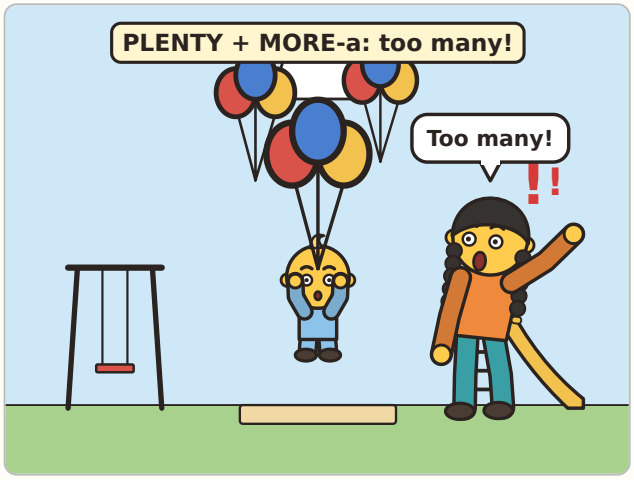
MEANING countless; extremely many

MEMORY HOOK **MYRIAD: Greek for TEN THOUSAND.** Lila tries to count the stars above the campsite and gives up after ten thousand. There are **myriad** stars.

On a clear night in the desert, **myriad** *stars fill the sky.*

SIMILAR countless, innumerable, numerous, untold
OPPOSITE few

plethora **PLETH**-er-uh *noun*



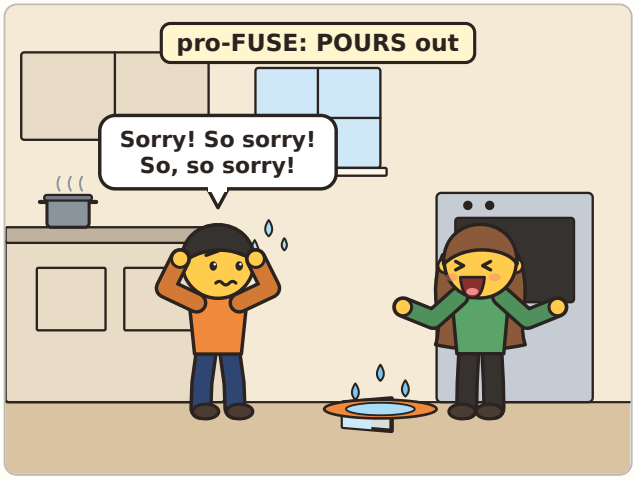
MEANING too many; a great excess

MEMORY HOOK **PLETH-ora: PLENTY and then MORE-a.** Theo asked for one balloon and got sixty, so many that his toes leave the ground. Sixty is a **plethora** of balloons.

The new phone came with a **plethora** *of settings that no one ever used.*

SIMILAR excess, glut, surplus, overabundance
OPPOSITE dearth, shortage, paucity

profuse pruh-**FYOOS** *adjective*



MEANING pouring out in great amounts

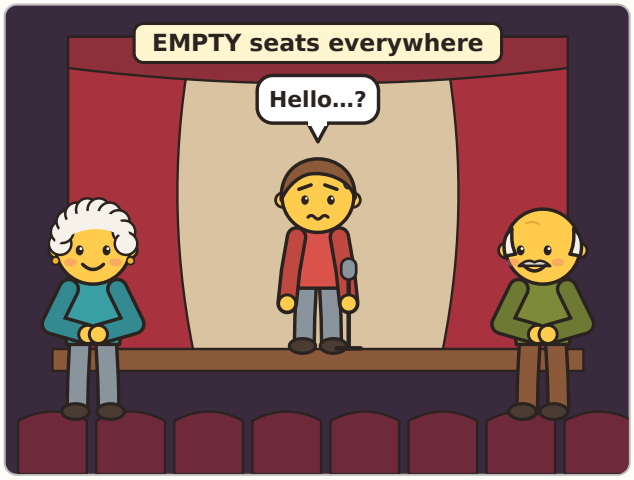
MEMORY HOOK **pro-FUSE: FUS = POUR.** Dev knocks over the juice, and apologies pour out of him: “Sorry! So sorry! I’m so, so sorry!” His apologies are **profuse**.

The roses grew in **profuse** *clusters, spilling over the fence onto the sidewalk.*

PARTS **pro** forth + **fus** poured (Latin fundere)

SIMILAR abundant, lavish, plentiful, copious
OPPOSITE scant, meager, sparse

sparse **SPARSS** *adjective*



MEANING thinly scattered; few and far between

MEMORY HOOK **SPARSE: lots of SPARE seats.** On the night of the big storm, nearly every seat at Jonah’s concert is spare; just two fans sit far apart. The crowd is **sparse**.

The desert’s **sparse** *bushes offered little shade.*

SIMILAR scattered, thin, scanty, meager
OPPOSITE dense, thick, abundant

scant **SKANT** *adjective*



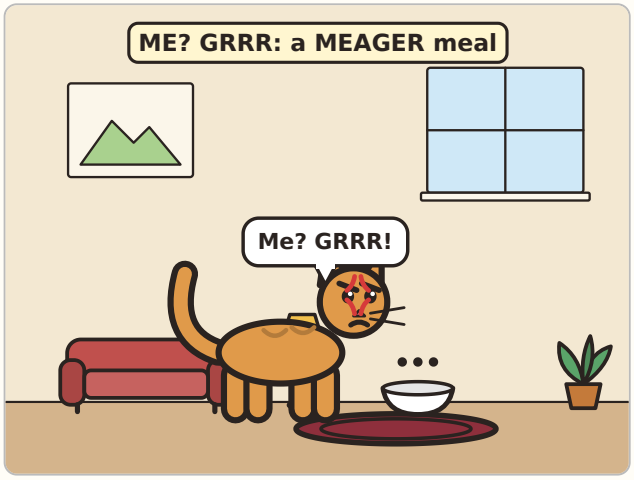
MEANING barely enough; very little

MEMORY HOOK **S-CAN'T: can't call that enough.** Zoe shakes the cereal box and gets five flakes and some dust. You can't call that breakfast: the cereal is **scant**.

The recipe calls for a **scant** *teaspoon of salt.*

SIMILAR little, limited, meager, insufficient
OPPOSITE ample, abundant, plentiful

meager **MEE**-ger *adjective*



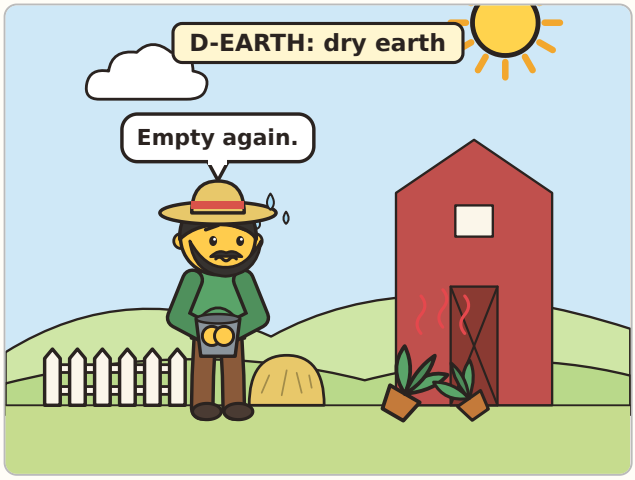
MEANING too small in amount or quality; skimpy

MEMORY HOOK **MEE-GRRR: "Is that all?".** The cat stares at the three tiny crumbs in its bowl and growls, "Me? Grrr! That's all?" Its dinner is **meager**.

The hikers shared a **meager** *lunch of two pears and a granola bar.*

SIMILAR scanty, paltry, skimpy, inadequate
OPPOSITE generous, ample, abundant

dearth **DURTH** *noun*



MEANING a lack or shortage

MEMORY HOOK **D-EARTH: DRY EARTH.** No rain for months, and the field is nothing but dry, cracked earth. The dry earth shows a **dearth** of rain.

There is a **dearth** *of good pizza places in our small town.*

SIMILAR lack, shortage, scarcity, absence
OPPOSITE abundance, plenty, surplus

paucity **PAW**-sih-tee *noun*



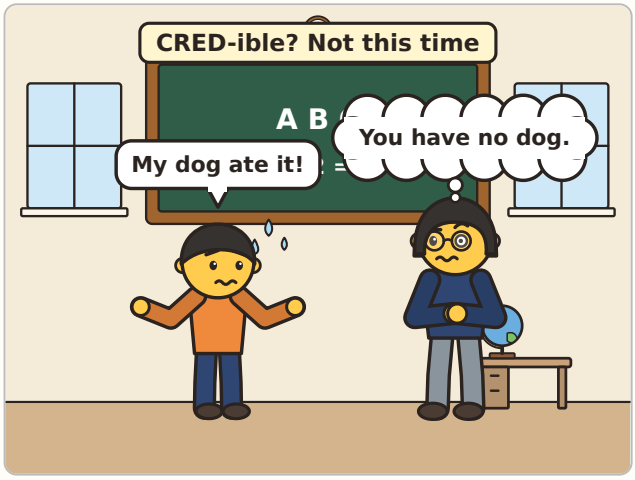
MEANING a very small amount; scarcity

MEMORY HOOK **PAW-CITY: hardly any PAWS.** Paw City built a giant dog park, and on opening day just one dog showed up. With so few paws, the park suffers a **paucity** of dogs.

The report's **paucity** *of facts made it hard to believe.*

PARTS **pauc** few (Latin paucus) + **-ity** the state of
SIMILAR scarcity, lack, shortage, dearth
OPPOSITE abundance, plethora, profusion

credible **KRED**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING believable; worthy of trust

MEMORY HOOK **CRED-ible: can you give it CREDIT?.** Dev says the dog ate his homework, but Dev has no dog. His teacher gives the story no credit at all: it isn't **credible**.

Dev's excuse was hardly **credible***: a dog ate his homework, and he has no dog.*

PARTS **cred** believe + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR believable, plausible, convincing, trustworthy
OPPOSITE incredible, unbelievable, implausible

incredulous in-**KREJ**-uh-lus *adjective*



MEANING unwilling or unable to believe something

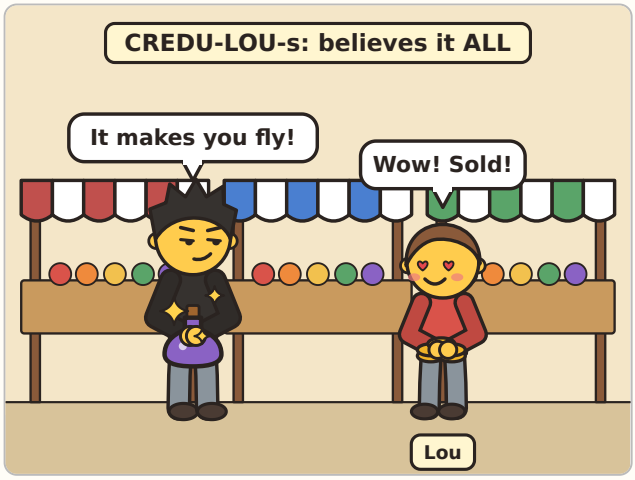
MEMORY HOOK **IN-CRED-ulous: "I can't believe it!".** Kai says he cleaned his room, but Maya can see socks on the floor and books on the bed. Her raised eyebrows are **incredulous**.

Maya gave an **incredulous** *laugh when her little brother said he had cleaned his room.*

PARTS **in** not + **cred** believe + **-ulous** inclined to

SIMILAR disbelieving, doubtful, skeptical, unconvinced
OPPOSITE credulous, believing, trusting

credulous **KREJ**-uh-lus *adjective*



MEANING too ready to believe things; easily fooled

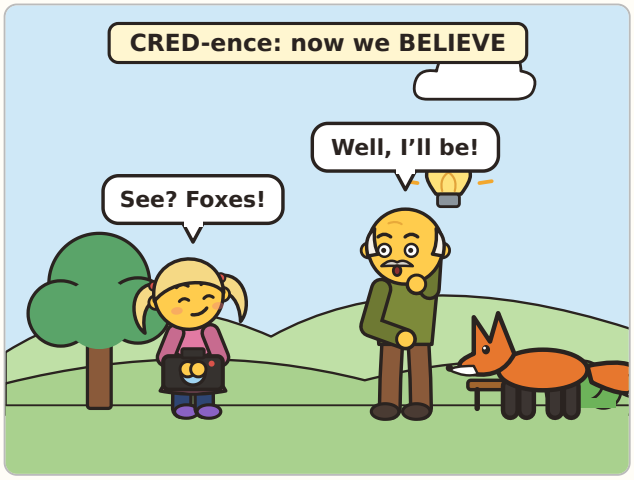
MEMORY HOOK **CREDU-LOU-s: Lou believes ANYTHING.** Rex sells young Lou a "flying potion," and Lou pays him on the spot without a single question. Lou believes anything: he is **credulous**.

The **credulous** *tourist paid ten dollars for a "real" moon rock.*

PARTS **cred** believe + **-ulous** inclined to

SIMILAR gullible, naive, trusting, unsuspecting
OPPOSITE skeptical, incredulous, suspicious

credence **KREED**-uns *noun*



MEANING belief or acceptance that something is true

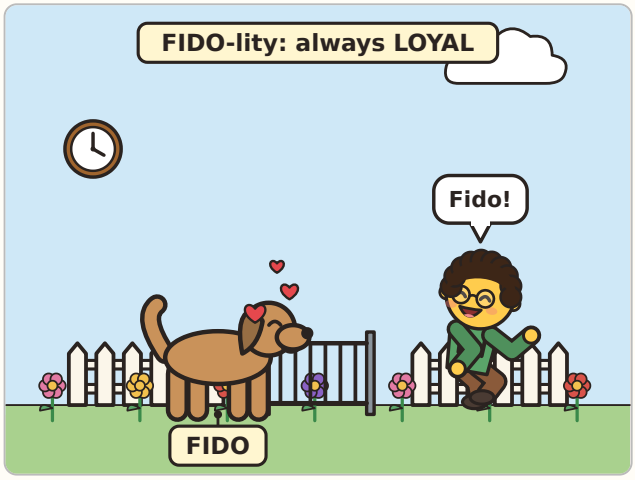
MEMORY HOOK **CRED-ence: give it CREDIT, believe it.** Nobody believed Ivy's story about a fox family in the park, until she showed her photos. The pictures lend **credence** to her story.

Nobody gave much **credence** *to the rumor that school would close for a month.*

PARTS **cred** believe + **-ence** the state of

SIMILAR belief, acceptance, trust, faith
OPPOSITE disbelief, doubt, skepticism

fidelity fih-**DEL**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING faithfulness and loyalty; also, accuracy

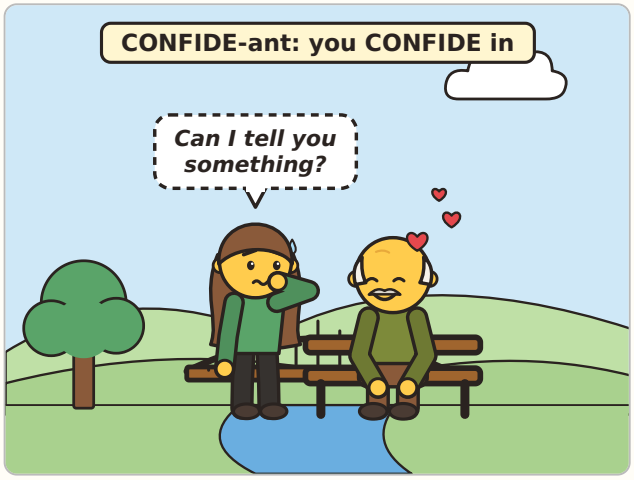
MEMORY HOOK **FIDO-lity: loyal as a dog named FIDO.** Every afternoon at three, Fido waits at the gate for Sami to come home from school, rain or shine. Fido's **fidelity** never wavers.

The old dog's **fidelity** *was famous: he waited at the gate every afternoon for his boy.*

PARTS **fid** trust, faith + **-ity** the quality of

SIMILAR loyalty, faithfulness, devotion, accuracy
OPPOSITE disloyalty, betrayal, inaccuracy

confidant **KON**-fih-dahnt *noun*



MEANING a trusted friend you can share secrets with

MEMORY HOOK **CONFIDE-ANT: the one you CONFIDE in.** Rosa confides her biggest worries to Grandpa Gus on the park bench, and he never tells a soul. The person you confide in is your **confidant**.

Grandpa was Rosa's **confidant**; *she told him things she told no one else.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **fid** trust

SIMILAR close friend, trusted friend, intimate

diffident **DIF**-ih-dunt *adjective*



MEANING shy and lacking confidence in oneself

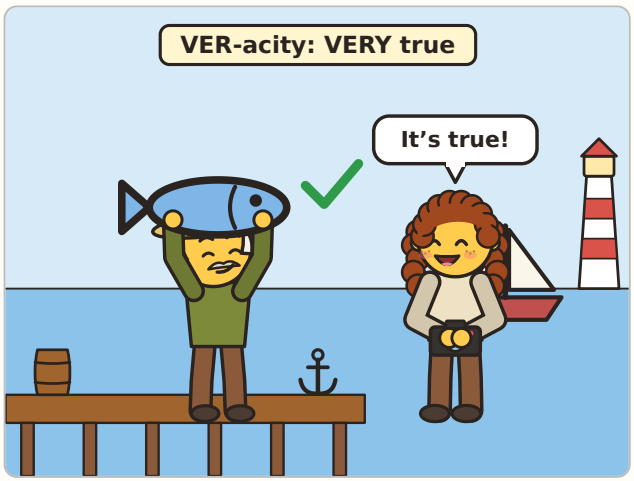
MEMORY HOOK **DIF-fident: the opposite of conFIDENT.** Lin sings beautifully, but she hides behind the curtain and lets someone else take the solo. She is the opposite of confident: **diffident**.

The **diffident** *new student spoke so softly that the teacher asked her to repeat her name.*

PARTS **dif** not (from dis) + **fid** trust + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR shy, timid, bashful, self-doubting
OPPOSITE confident, self-assured, bold

veracity vuh-**RAS**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING truthfulness; accuracy

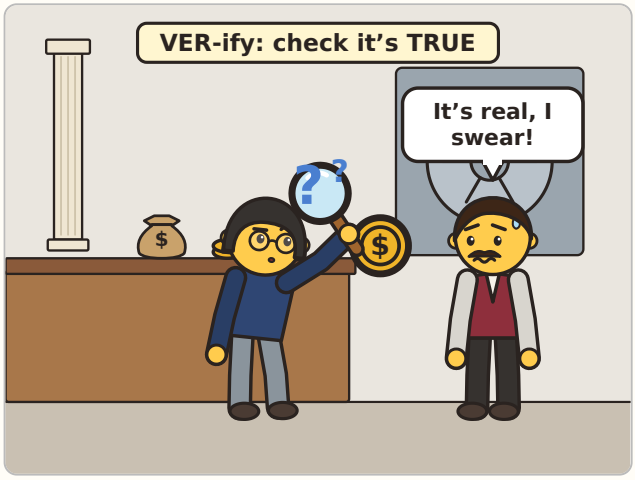
MEMORY HOOK **VER-acity: VERY true.** Grandpa Gus swears he caught a fish as long as his arm, and this time the photo proves every word. The **veracity** of his story is beyond doubt.

No one doubted the **veracity** *of Nana's story; she had the photos to prove it.*

PARTS **ver** true + **-acity** the quality of

SIMILAR truthfulness, accuracy, honesty, truth
OPPOSITE falsehood, dishonesty, inaccuracy

verify **VAIR**-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to check or prove that something is true

MEMORY HOOK **VER-ify: make sure it's VERY true.** Before she buys the old coin, Ada studies it under her magnifying glass, front and back. She wants to **verify** that it is real gold.

*Please **verify** your address before you click send.*

PARTS **ver** true + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR confirm, check, prove, validate
OPPOSITE disprove, refute

verdict **VUR**-dikt *noun*



MEANING a decision or judgment, especially a jury's

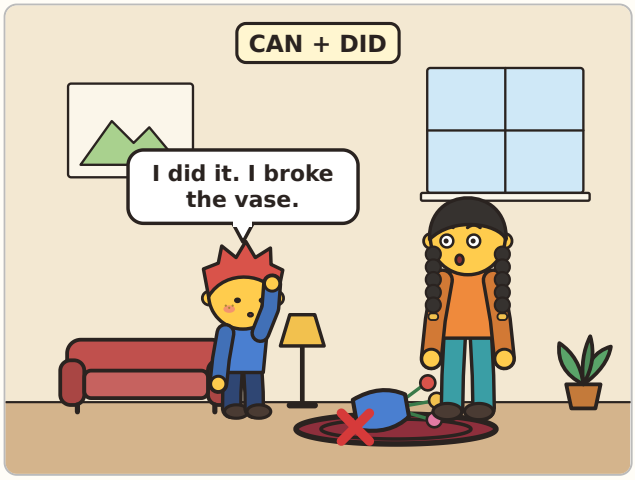
MEMORY HOOK **VER + DICT = TRUE + SAID.** In the case of the missing cake, the jury says what it truly believes: "Not guilty!" The dog wags happily at the **verdict**.

*After one bite, Grandpa gave his **verdict**: the best chili he had ever tasted.*

PARTS **ver** true + **dict** say, speak

SIMILAR judgment, decision, ruling, finding

candid **KAN**-did *adjective*



MEANING open and honest in what one says

MEMORY HOOK **CAN + DID: I CAN tell what I DID.** "I did it. I broke the vase," says Pip, before anyone even asks. He can tell what he did: he is **candid**.

*In a **candid** interview, the coach admitted the team had played badly.*

SIMILAR frank, honest, open, forthright
OPPOSITE guarded, evasive, deceitful

frank **FRANK** *adjective*



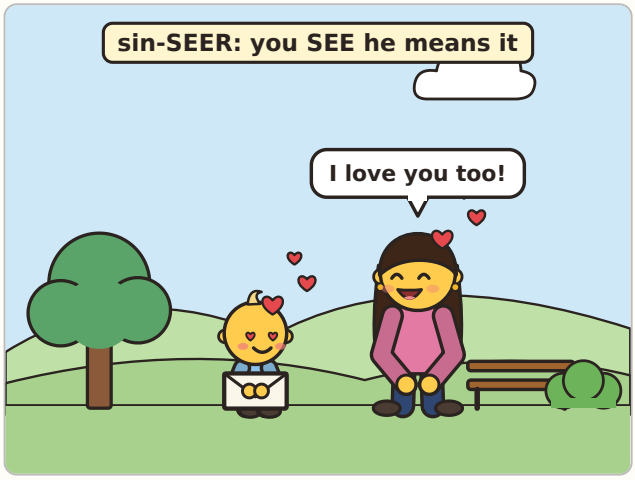
MEANING direct and honest, even when it is uncomfortable

MEMORY HOOK **FRANK: straight as a PLANK.** Nana Lou tastes the soup and gives it to you straight as a plank: "Needs salt. Lots of salt." No sugarcoating: she is **frank**.

*Dad was **frank** with us: the car needed repairs, and the trip would have to wait.*

SIMILAR blunt, direct, candid, outspoken
OPPOSITE evasive, guarded, indirect

sincere sin-**SEER** *adjective*



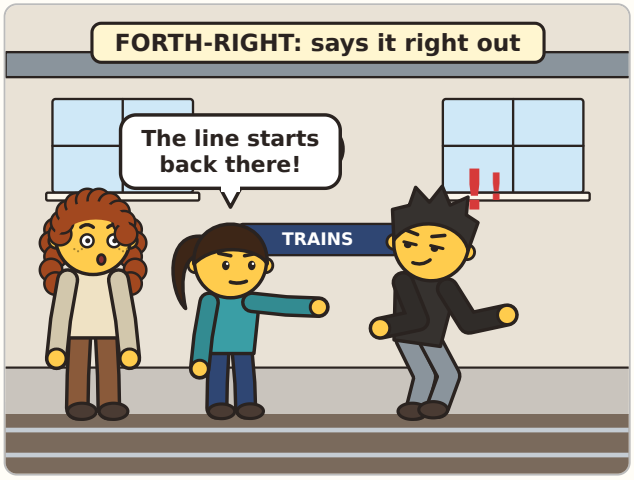
MEANING meaning what one says; free of pretense

MEMORY HOOK **sin-SEER: you can SEE he means it.** Theo hands Mom a crumpled crayon card that says “I LUV U,” and she can see he means every word. His card is **sincere**.

Her apology was **sincere**; *she had tears in her eyes.*

SIMILAR heartfelt, honest, earnest, wholehearted
OPPOSITE insincere, false, fake

forthright **FORTH**-rite *adjective*



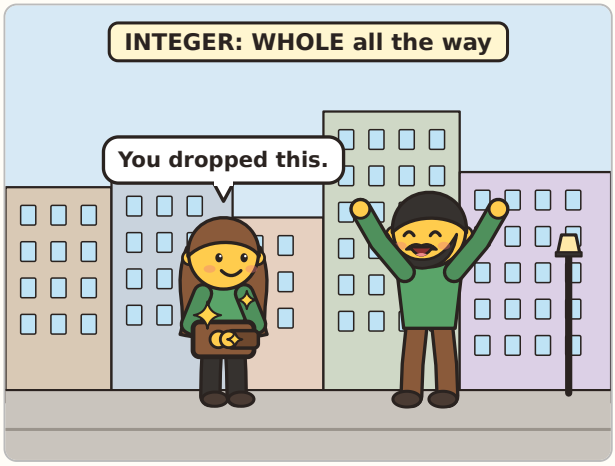
MEANING direct and outspoken; saying plainly what one thinks

MEMORY HOOK **FORTH-RIGHT: steps FORTH, says it RIGHT.** When Rex cuts into the ticket line, Maya steps forth and says it right out: “That’s not fair. The line starts back there.” She is **forthright**.

The **forthright** *referee explained exactly why the goal did not count.*

PARTS **forth** forward + **right** straight
SIMILAR direct, frank, outspoken, plainspoken
OPPOSITE evasive, indirect, devious

integrity in-**TEG**-rih-tee *noun*



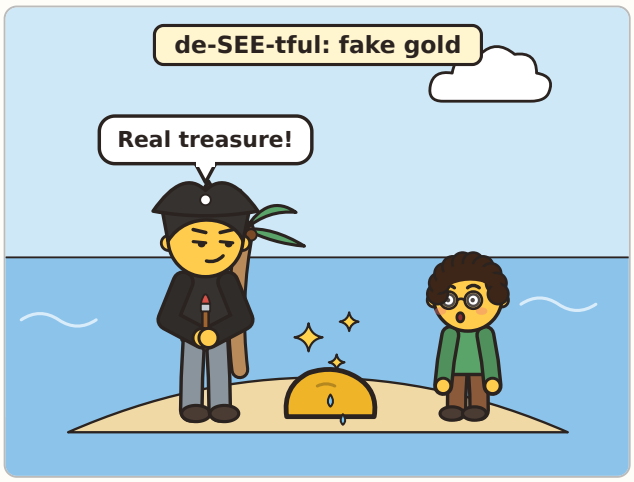
MEANING the quality of being honest and having strong moral principles

MEMORY HOOK **INTEGER = WHOLE: honest all through.** Like a whole number, Rosa is honest all the way through: she finds a wallet full of cash and returns every dollar to its owner. She has **integrity**.

A person of **integrity** *keeps a promise even when no one would ever find out.*

PARTS **integr** whole, untouched (Latin integer) + **-ity** the quality of
SIMILAR honesty, honor, uprightness, principle
OPPOSITE dishonesty, corruption, deceit

deceitful dih-**SEET**-ful *adjective*



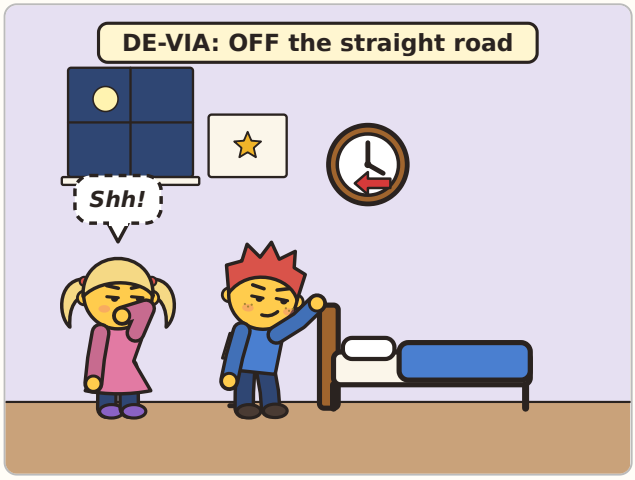
MEANING trying to make others believe what is false

MEMORY HOOK **de-SEE-tful: you SEE what isn’t there.** Rex paints a plain rock gold and tells the tourists it is pirate treasure. Making people see what isn’t there is **deceitful**.

The **deceitful** *player pretended to be hurt so the referee would call a foul.*

SIMILAR dishonest, lying, deceptive, false
OPPOSITE honest, truthful, candid

devious **DEE**-vee-us *adjective*



MEANING sly and tricky in getting one's way

MEMORY HOOK **DE-VIA: OFF the straight road.** Instead of asking for a later bedtime, Pip and Ivy take the sneaky road: they tiptoe in and turn the clock back an hour. That trick is **devious**.

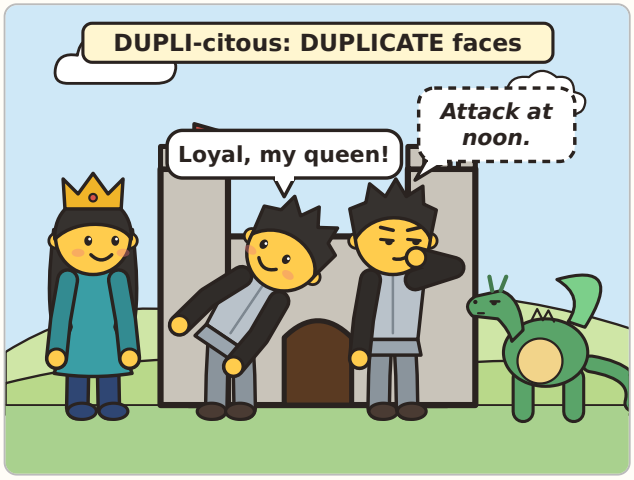
The cat came up with a **devious** *plan to reach the fish tank.*

PARTS **de** away from + **vi** way, road (Latin via) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR sly, sneaky, scheming, cunning

OPPOSITE honest, direct, forthright

duplicitous doo-**PLIS**-ih-tus *adjective*



MEANING two-faced; saying one thing and doing another

MEMORY HOOK **DUPLI-citous: a DUPLICATE face.** Rex smiles at the queen, "I'm your loyal knight!", then turns around and whispers plans to the dragon. Two faces, like a duplicate: he is **duplicitous**.

The **duplicitous** *spy smiled at both sides while secretly working for neither.*

PARTS **dupl** double (Latin duplex) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR double-dealing, two-faced, deceitful, treacherous

OPPOSITE honest, sincere, aboveboard

disingenuous dis-in-**JEN**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING insincere; pretending to be more innocent or less informed than one is

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-INGENUOUS: fake innocence.** "What cookies?" asks Dev, wide-eyed, with chocolate all over his chin and an empty jar behind him. Pretending to be innocent like that is **disingenuous**.

It was **disingenuous** *of Dev to ask "What cookies?" with chocolate on his chin.*

PARTS **dis** not + **ingenu** innocent, frank (Latin ingenuus) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR insincere, misleading, feigned, hypocritical

OPPOSITE sincere, candid, honest

guileless **GYLE**-lis *adjective*



MEANING innocent and without tricks; open and honest

MEMORY HOOK **GUILE-LESS: no tricks at all.** Theo plays cards holding his hand face out so everyone can see it: no tricks, no secrets, no bluffing. He is **guileless**.

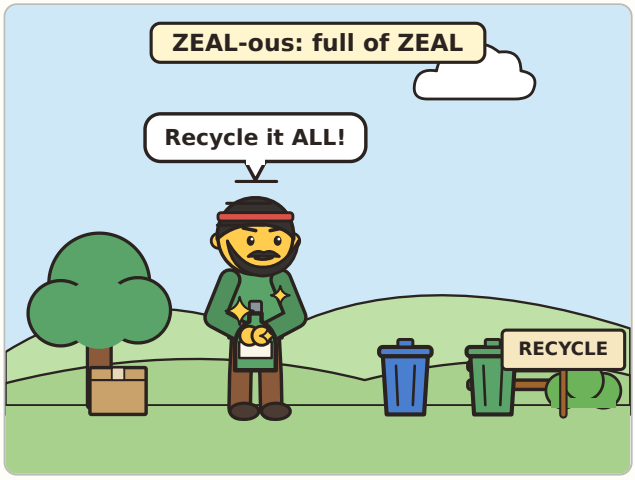
The puppy's **guileless** *eyes made it impossible to stay angry.*

PARTS **guile** sly trickery + **-less** without

SIMILAR innocent, naive, artless, trusting

OPPOSITE sly, cunning, devious

zealous ZEL-us *adjective*



MEANING full of eager devotion to a cause or task

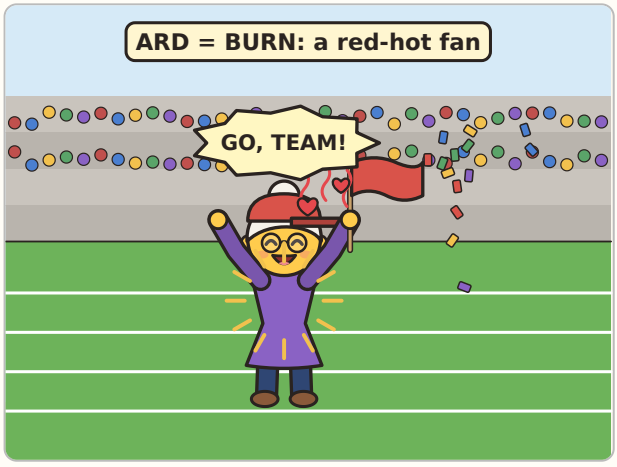
MEMORY HOOK **ZEAL-ous: full of ZEAL, A to Z.** Omar sorts every can, bottle and scrap of paper into the right bin and cheers each one in. His zeal for recycling makes him **zealous**.

*The **zealous** volunteers cleaned the whole beach before breakfast.*

PARTS **zeal** eager devotion (Greek zelos) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR devoted, passionate, fervent, enthusiastic
OPPOSITE apathetic, indifferent, halfhearted

ardent AHR-dunt *adjective*



MEANING passionate and enthusiastic

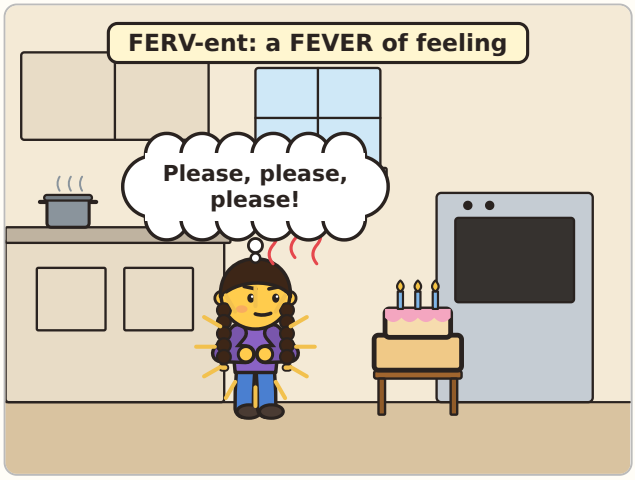
MEMORY HOOK **ARD = BURN: a red-hot fan.** Granny Mae has cheered for the home team for forty years, and her love still burns hot: cap, flag and a voice you can hear in the parking lot. She is an **ardent** fan.

*Grandma is an **ardent** baseball fan; she has not missed a home game in forty years.*

PARTS **ard** burn (Latin ardere) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR passionate, fervent, devoted, enthusiastic
OPPOSITE indifferent, apathetic, lukewarm

fervent FUR-vunt *adjective*



MEANING showing strong, warm feeling

MEMORY HOOK **FERV-ent: a FEVER of feeling.** Lila squeezes her eyes shut and wishes so hard over her birthday candles that she glows as if she had a fever. Her wish is **fervent**.

*Lila made a **fervent** wish as she blew out the candles.*

PARTS **ferv** boil, glow (Latin fervere) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR passionate, intense, heartfelt, ardent
OPPOSITE halfhearted, cool, indifferent

avid AV-id *adjective*



MEANING very eager and enthusiastic

MEMORY HOOK **AV-id: "I have to HAVE it!".** The moment the new book arrives, Zoe grabs it: "I have to have it!" She has read it twice by Sunday. She is an **avid** reader.

*Zoe is an **avid** reader who finishes a book every two days.*

PARTS **av** crave (Latin avere) + **-id** having the quality of

SIMILAR eager, keen, enthusiastic, passionate
OPPOSITE indifferent, apathetic, uninterested

keen KEEN *adjective*



MEANING eager and enthusiastic; also, sharp

MEMORY HOOK **a KEEN TEEN.** Dev, the keen teen, is first in line at the climbing rock, helmet on, an hour before it opens. He is **keen** to climb.

*Dev was **keen** to try the new climbing wall.*

SIMILAR eager, enthusiastic, avid, sharp
OPPOSITE reluctant, unwilling, dull

alacrity uh-**LAK**-rih-tee *noun*



MEANING cheerful readiness and speed

MEMORY HOOK **AL-ACRO-ity: up like an ACROBAT.** When Grandpa asks who wants to help build the treehouse, Kai springs off the couch like an acrobat: “Me! Now!” He answers with **alacrity**.

*When Mom asked who wanted ice cream, the kids answered with **alacrity**.*

PARTS **alacr** lively, brisk (Latin alacer) + **-ity** the quality of
SIMILAR eagerness, readiness, willingness, promptness
OPPOSITE reluctance, hesitation, sluggishness

reluctant rih-**LUK**-tunt *adjective*



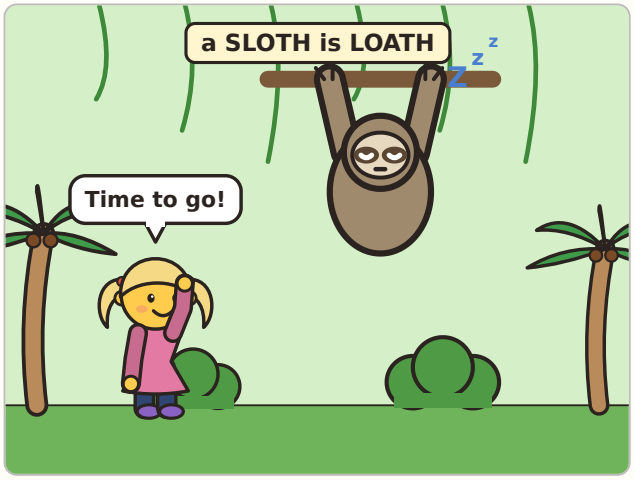
MEANING unwilling and hesitant

MEMORY HOOK **re-LUCK-tant: no LUCK getting him to go.** Maya tugs Kai toward the dance floor, but he leans back with all his weight: no luck. He is **reluctant** to dance.

*The **reluctant** puppy had to be carried into the bath.*

PARTS **re** back, against + **luct** struggle (Latin luctari) + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)
SIMILAR unwilling, hesitant, disinclined, loath
OPPOSITE eager, willing, keen

loath LOHTH *adjective*



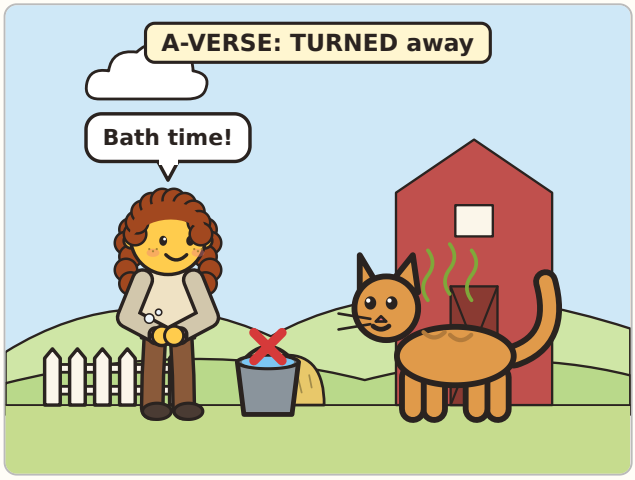
MEANING unwilling; reluctant

MEMORY HOOK **a SLOTH is LOATH to let go.** Time to climb down? The sloth hugs its cozy branch and won’t budge an inch. A sloth is always **loath** to let go.

*Grandpa was **loath** to sell the old truck he had driven for forty years.*

SIMILAR unwilling, reluctant, disinclined, averse
OPPOSITE eager, willing, keen

averse uh-**VURS** *adjective*



MEANING strongly opposed or unwilling

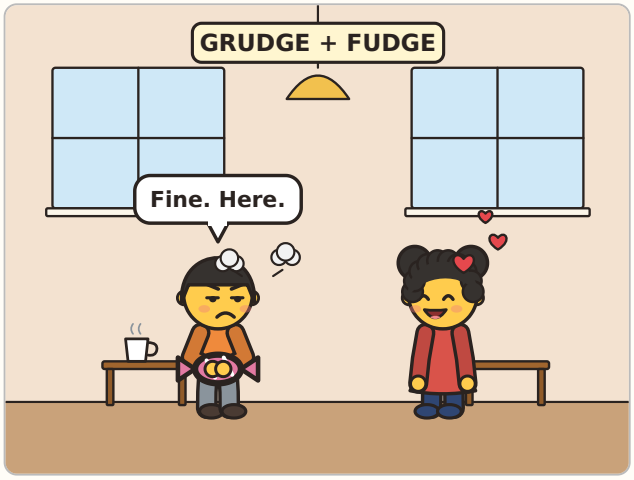
MEMORY HOOK **A-VERSE: TURNED AWAY.** Show Mittens the washtub, and she turns her whole body away, nose in the air. She is **averse** to baths.

Our cat is **averse** *to baths.*

PARTS **a** away (from ab) + **vers** turn

SIMILAR opposed, unwilling, disinclined, reluctant
OPPOSITE eager, keen, inclined

grudging **GRUJ**-ing *adjective*



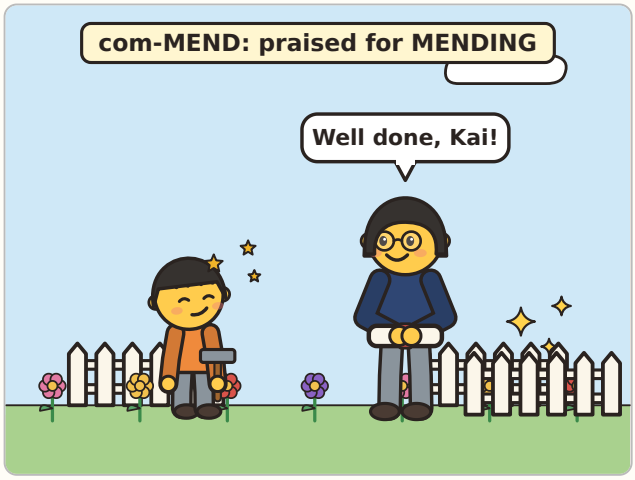
MEANING given or done unwillingly

MEMORY HOOK **GRUDGE + FUDGE.** Mom says Kai must share, so he hands his sister half of his fudge with a scowl and a long sigh. His sharing is **grudging**.

Kai gave a **grudging** *apology to his sister, staring at his shoes the whole time.*

SIMILAR reluctant, unwilling, halfhearted, resentful
OPPOSITE wholehearted, willing, generous

commend kuh-**MEND** *verb*



MEANING to praise formally or officially

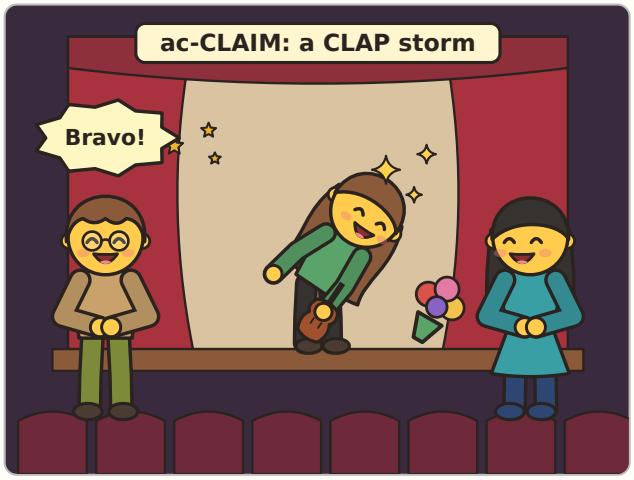
MEMORY HOOK **com-MEND: praised for MENDING it.** Kai mends the broken garden fence all by himself, and the principal hands him a certificate in front of the whole school. To praise someone formally like that is to **commend** him.

The principal **commended** *the students who organized the food drive.*

PARTS **com** thoroughly (from con) + **mend** entrust (Latin mandare)

SIMILAR praise, compliment, applaud
OPPOSITE criticize, condemn, censure

acclaim uh-**KLAYM** *noun*



MEANING enthusiastic public praise

MEMORY HOOK **ac-CLAIM: a CLAP storm.** Rosa plays her last note, and the whole hall rises, clapping and calling out “Bravo!” That storm of public praise is **acclaim**.

Her first novel won wide **acclaim**.

PARTS **ac** to (from ad) + **claim** shout, call out (Latin clamare)

SIMILAR applause, acclamation, ovation, approval
OPPOSITE criticism, disapproval, censure

laud LAWD *verb*



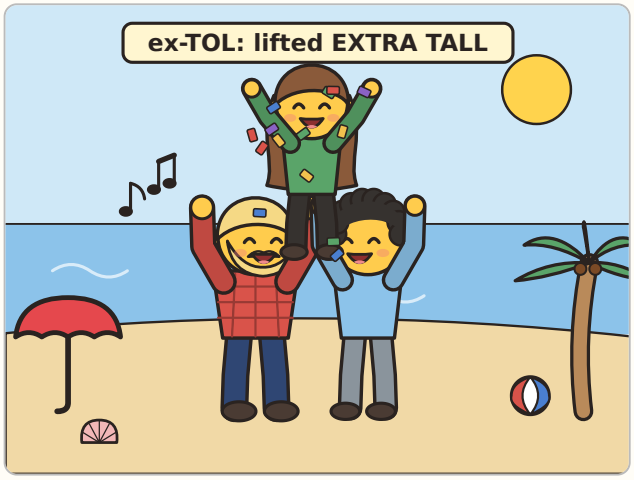
MEANING to praise highly

MEMORY HOOK **LAUD = praise out LOUD.** Grandpa Gus reads Pip's poem and praises it so loud the whole street can hear: "Best poem ever written!" To praise that highly is to **laud**.

Critics **lauded** *the new bridge as a work of art.*

SIMILAR praise, hail, acclaim
OPPOSITE criticize, condemn, belittle

extol ik-STOHL *verb*



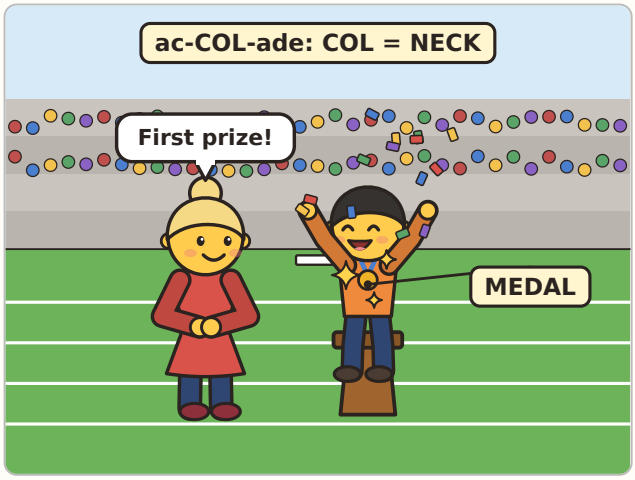
MEANING to praise enthusiastically

MEMORY HOOK **ex-TOL: lifted up EXTRA TALL.** After the beach volleyball final, the team lifts Rosa onto their shoulders and sings her praises. To lift someone up with praise is to **extol** her.

Nana never stops **extolling** *the virtues of a good night's sleep.*

PARTS **ex** out, up + **tol** lift (Latin tollere)
SIMILAR celebrate, rave about, sing the praises of
OPPOSITE criticize, disparage, belittle

accolade AK-uh-layd *noun*



MEANING an award, honor or expression of praise

MEMORY HOOK **ac-COL-ade: COL = NECK, a medal.** The judge hangs a gold medal around Dev's neck for his science project. Col means neck, and an **accolade** is an honor like that.

The firefighter received the town's highest **accolade** *for bravery.*

PARTS **ac** to (from ad) + **col** neck (Latin collum)
SIMILAR award, honor, distinction
OPPOSITE criticism, censure

tribute TRIB-yoot *noun*



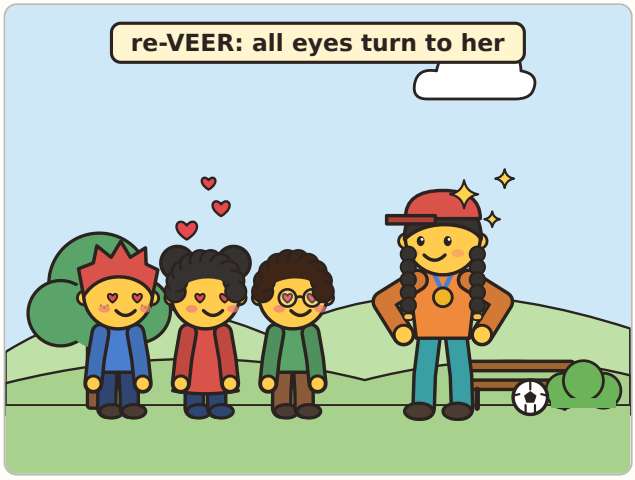
MEANING an act, statement or gift that shows respect or admiration

MEMORY HOOK **TREE-bute: a TREE planted in her honor.** When Ms. Ada retires, her students plant an oak in the schoolyard with a sign: "For Ms. Ada, who taught us to wonder." The tree is a **tribute** to her.

The concert was a **tribute** *to the town's beloved music teacher.*

PARTS **tribut** paid, given (Latin tribuere)
SIMILAR homage, salute, testimonial
OPPOSITE insult, slight

revere rih-**VEER** *verb*



MEANING to feel deep respect and admiration for

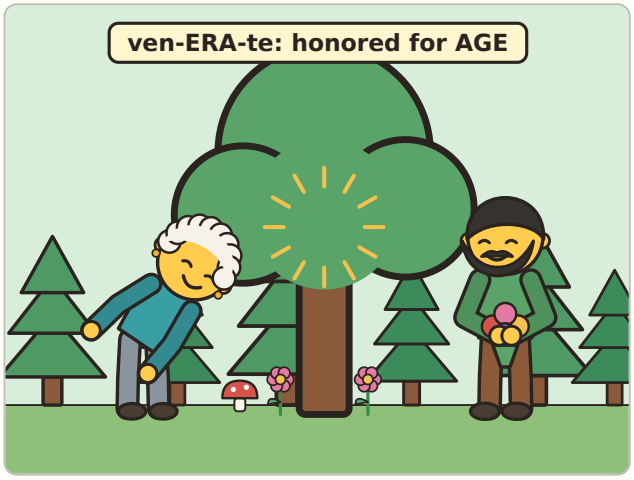
MEMORY HOOK **re-VEER: every eye VEERS toward her.** When Coach Tia walks onto the field, every player's eyes veer toward her with awe: she once played for the national team. They **revere** her.

The young players **revere** *their coach, who once played for the national team.*

PARTS **re** thoroughly + **ver** stand in awe (Latin vereri)

SIMILAR admire, respect, esteem
OPPOSITE scorn, despise, disdain

venerate **VEN**-er-ayt *verb*



MEANING to regard with deep respect, often for age or wisdom

MEMORY HOOK **ven-ERA-te: honored from an old ERA.** Every spring the town gathers under the five-hundred-year-old oak, a survivor from a long-ago era, and leaves flowers at its roots. The townspeople **venerate** it.

The villagers **venerate** *the ancient oak that has shaded their square for five hundred years.*

PARTS **vener** honor, love (Latin venerari) + **-ate** to do

SIMILAR revere, deeply respect, look up to
OPPOSITE scorn, despise, disrespect

exalt ig-**ZAWLT** *verb*



MEANING to raise high in rank, power or praise

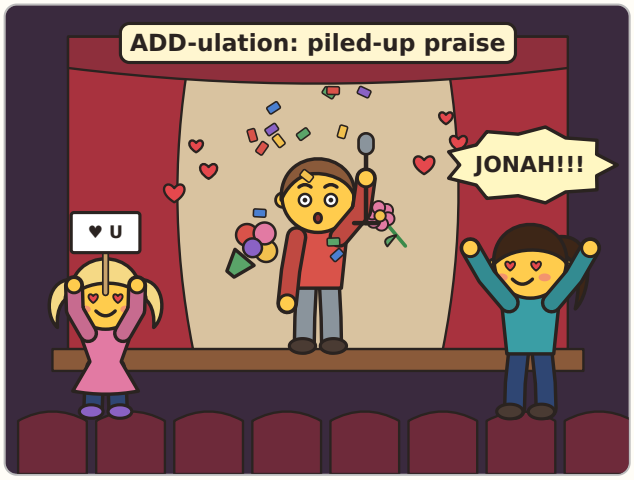
MEMORY HOOK **ex-ALT: to a high ALTitude.** The village lifts its brave baker onto the tallest platform in the square, as high as the rooftops. To raise someone high in honor is to **exalt** her.

The old legends **exalt** *the village baker who fed everyone through the long winter.*

PARTS **ex** out, up + **alt** high

SIMILAR glorify, elevate, raise up
OPPOSITE humble, degrade, belittle

adulation aj-uh-**LAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING excessive praise or admiration

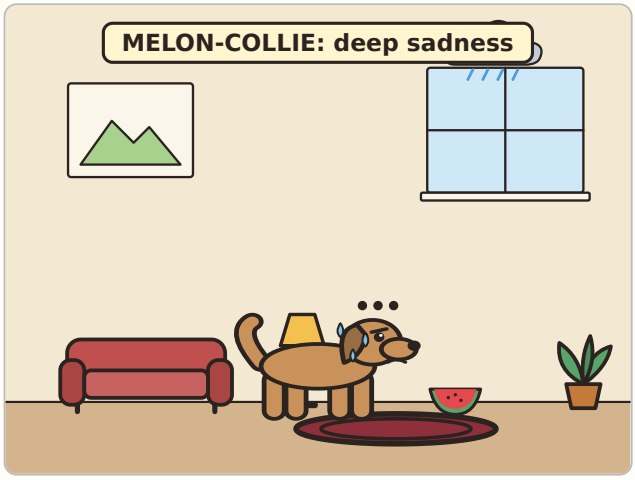
MEMORY HOOK **ADD-ulation: ADD praise on praise.** The fans scream, wave signs and toss flowers, adding praise upon praise until the young singer can barely be seen. That flood of admiration is **adulation**.

The young singer was overwhelmed by the **adulation** *of her fans.*

PARTS **adul** fawn, flatter (Latin adulari) + **-ation** the act of

SIMILAR adoration, idolization, hero worship, flattery
OPPOSITE scorn, criticism, contempt

melancholy **MEL**-un-kol-ee *noun*



MEANING a deep, lasting sadness

MEMORY HOOK **a MELON-COLLIE.** Ever since his melon ball rolled into the river, the old collie lies by the window and sighs all day. Poor melon-collie: he is full of **melancholy**.

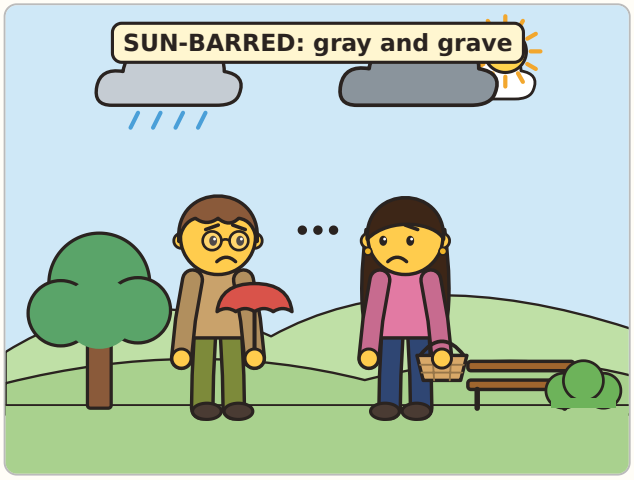
A gentle **melancholy** *settled over the house after the last guests drove away.*

PARTS **melan** black (Greek melas) + **chol** bile (Greek chole)

SIMILAR sadness, sorrow, gloom, despondency

OPPOSITE happiness, cheer, joy

somber **SOM**-ber *adjective*



MEANING dark and gloomy; serious

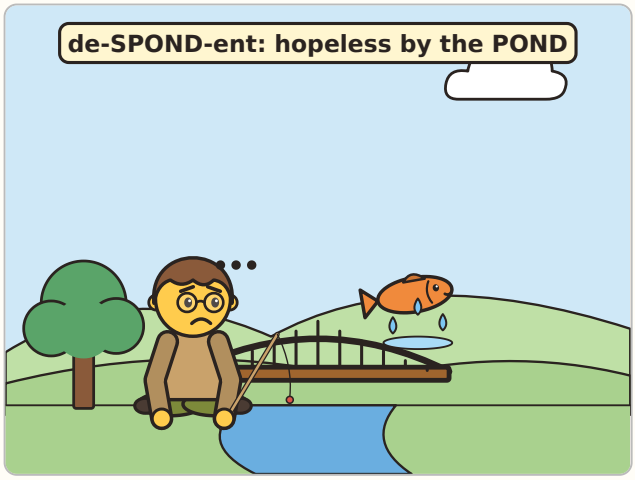
MEMORY HOOK **SOM-BER: SUN-BARRED, gray and grave.** Clouds bar the sun, the sky turns gray, and the picnic goes quiet and serious. With the sun barred, the mood is **somber**.

The **somber** *gray sky matched our mood on the last day of vacation.*

SIMILAR gloomy, dark, grave, serious

OPPOSITE cheerful, bright, lighthearted

despondent dih-**SPON**-dunt *adjective*



MEANING in low spirits from loss of hope

MEMORY HOOK **de-SPOND-ent: no hope by the POND.** Felix has fished the pond all day without a single nibble, and now he slumps on the bank, all hope gone. He is **despondent**.

After the third rejection letter, Felix was **despondent**.

PARTS **de** away + **spond** promise (Latin spondere)

SIMILAR hopeless, dejected, downcast, discouraged

OPPOSITE hopeful, cheerful, optimistic

forlorn fer-**LORN** *adjective*



MEANING sad and lonely; abandoned

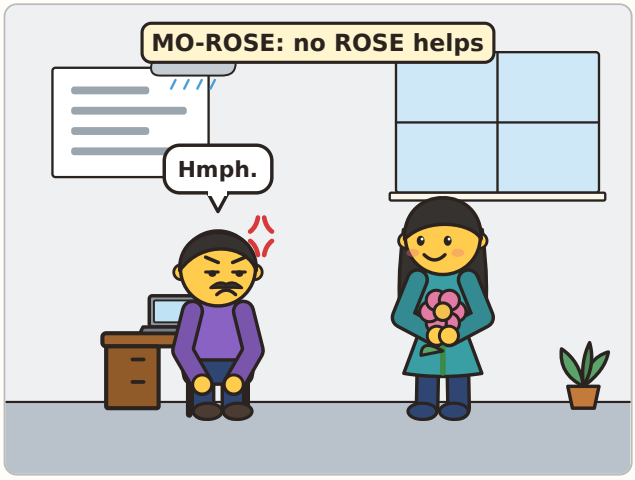
MEMORY HOOK **for-LORN: left all a-LONE.** Everyone has gone home from the playground, and one little teddy bear sits all alone on the bench in the rain. It looks **forlorn**.

A **forlorn** *teddy bear sat in the rain beside the empty swing.*

SIMILAR lonely, abandoned, desolate, wretched

OPPOSITE cheerful, joyful

morose muh-**ROHS** *adjective*



MEANING sullen, gloomy and bad-tempered

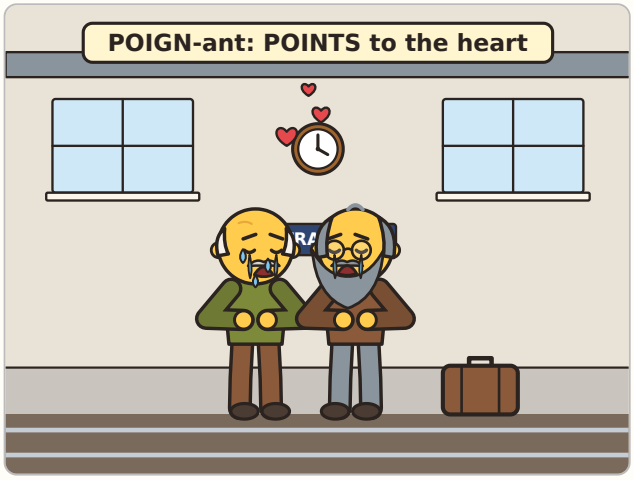
MEMORY HOOK **MO-ROSE: no ROSE can cheer him.** Lin brings Marcus a rose to cheer him up, and he only scowls and grunts. No rose can brighten his sullen mood: he is **morose**.

The **morose** *goalie barely spoke during the long bus ride home.*

SIMILAR sullen, gloomy, glum, surly
OPPOSITE cheerful, sunny, jovial

15. Sad

poignant **POIN**-yunt *adjective*



MEANING deeply moving; stirring sadness or tender regret

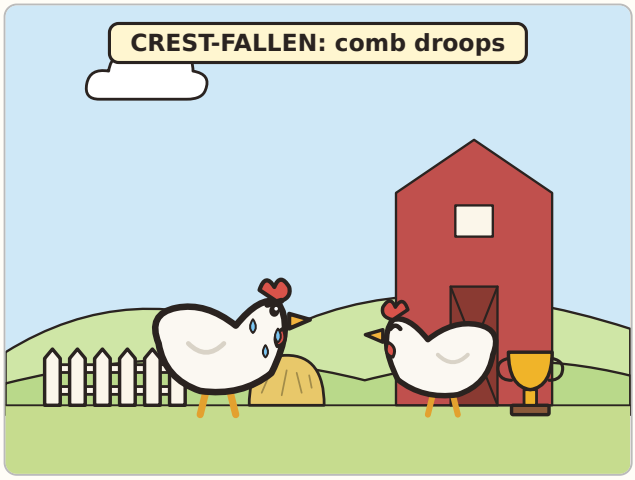
MEMORY HOOK **POIGN-ant: POINTS straight at the heart.** Two old friends meet again on the platform where they said goodbye sixty years before, and the moment points straight at your heart. It is **poignant**.

Grandpa's **poignant** *letter to his younger self made the whole family cry.*

SIMILAR moving, touching, affecting, tender
OPPOSITE unmoving, trivial

15. Sad

crestfallen **KREST**-faw-lun *adjective*



MEANING disappointed and downcast

MEMORY HOOK **CREST-FALLEN: the comb droops.** Rocky the rooster loses the crowing contest, and his proud red comb flops down over one eye. He is **crestfallen**.

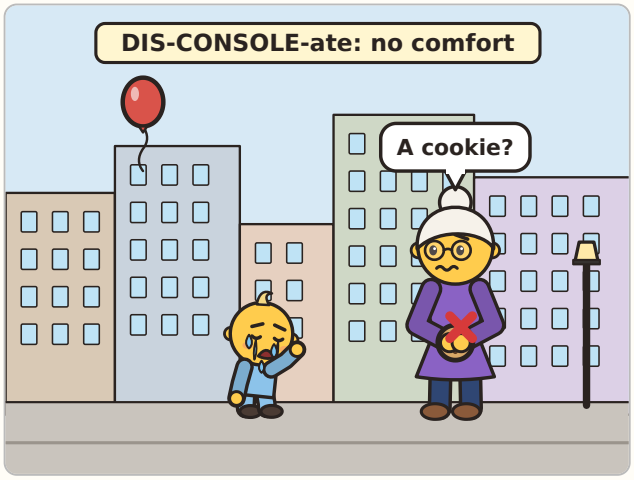
Kai was **crestfallen** *when the trip to the lake was canceled.*

PARTS **crest** the comb or plume on top of the head + **fallen** dropped

SIMILAR disappointed, dejected, downcast, deflated
OPPOSITE elated, jubilant, cheerful

15. Sad

disconsolate dis-**KON**-suh-lit *adjective*



MEANING so sad that nothing can comfort

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-CONSOLE-ate: can't be CONSOLED.** Theo's balloon floats away, and nothing helps: not a hug, not a cookie, not even a new balloon. He cannot be consoled; he is **disconsolate**.

The **disconsolate** *toddler cried for an hour after his balloon floated away.*

PARTS **dis** not + **consol** comfort (Latin consolari) + **-ate** having (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR inconsolable, heartbroken, miserable, desolate
OPPOSITE cheerful, comforted, consoled

15. Sad

wistful **WIST**-ful *adjective*



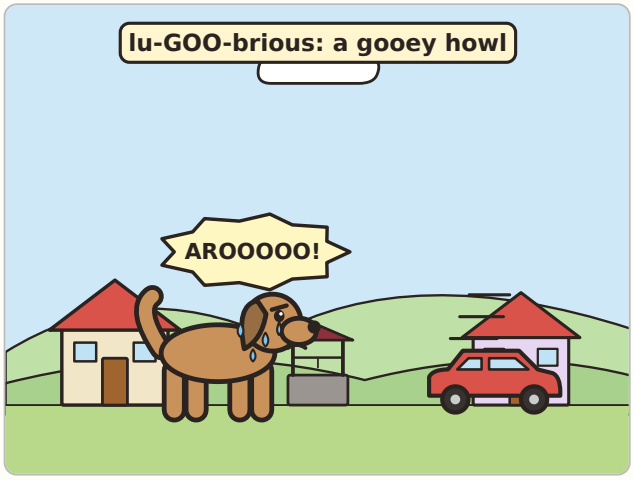
MEANING sadly longing for something past or out of reach

MEMORY HOOK **WIST-ful ~ WISH-ful.** Granny Mae turns the pages of her old dance photos, smiling but a little sad, wishing she could dance like that once more. Her smile is **wistful**.

Grandma gave a **wistful** *smile as she looked through her old dance photos.*

SIMILAR longing, yearning, nostalgic, pensive
OPPOSITE content, satisfied

lugubrious loo-**GOO**-bree-us *adjective*



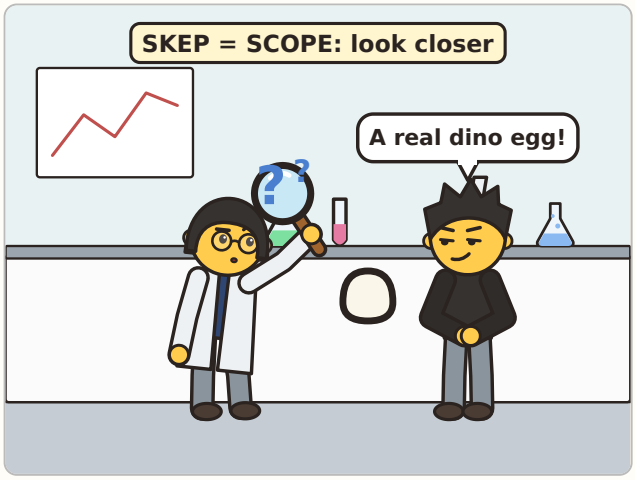
MEANING mournful, often in an exaggerated way

MEMORY HOOK **lu-GOO-brious: a howl as slow as GOO.** Every time the car pulls away, Biscuit the hound lets out a howl as slow and droopy as goo: “Aroooooo.” It is over the top, and it is **lugubrious**.

The hound gave a **lugubrious** *howl whenever the family left the house.*

PARTS **lugubr** mournful (Latin lugere, to mourn) + **-ious** full of
SIMILAR mournful, doleful, gloomy, sorrowful
OPPOSITE cheerful, merry, upbeat

skeptical **SKEP**-tih-kul *adjective*



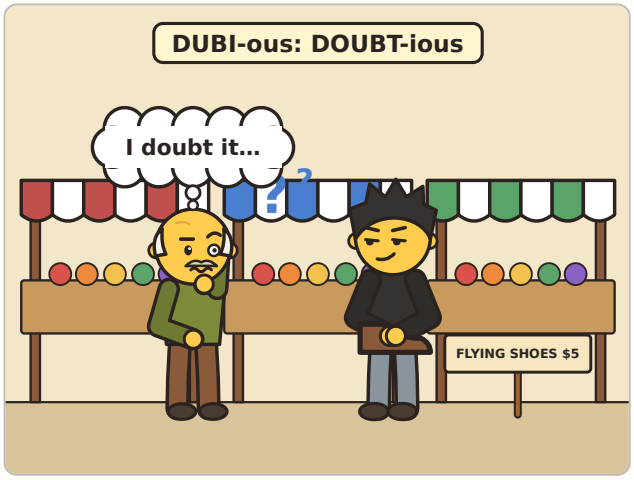
MEANING doubting; not easily convinced

MEMORY HOOK **SKEP = SCOPE: look closer first.** Rex claims his round rock is a dinosaur egg, so Ada pulls out her magnifying glass and looks very closely before believing a word. She is **skeptical**.

Dad was **skeptical** *when the ad promised a car that would never need a single repair.*

PARTS **skept** look at, examine (Greek) + **-ical** having to do with
SIMILAR doubtful, dubious, unconvinced, questioning
OPPOSITE credulous, trusting, convinced

dubious **DOO**-bee-us *adjective*



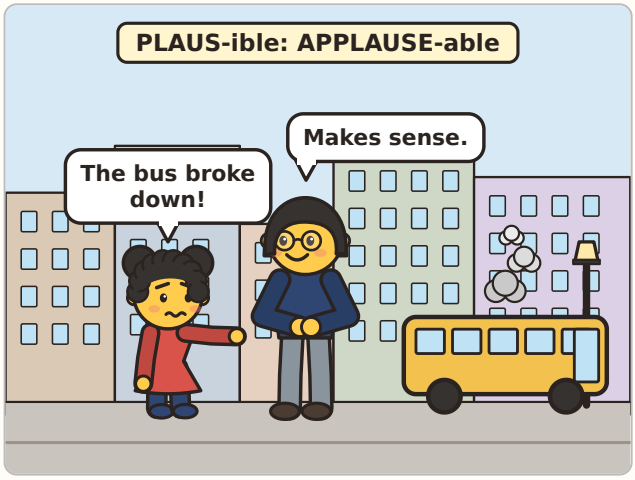
MEANING doubtful; also, possibly dishonest

MEMORY HOOK **DOO-bee-us = DOUBT-ious.** A sign promises shoes that let you fly for five dollars. Grandpa Gus squints at it, full of doubt, and the seller looks shady too. Gus is **dubious**.

Ivy was **dubious** *about her brother’s promise to clean the kitchen by himself.*

PARTS **dubi** doubt (Latin dubius) + **-ous** full of
SIMILAR doubtful, questionable, suspicious, uncertain
OPPOSITE certain, trustworthy, reliable

plausible PLAW-zuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING seeming reasonable or likely

MEMORY HOOK **PLAUS-ible: worth a little APPLAUSE.** Zoe says she is late because the bus broke down, and there it sits, steaming at the corner. Her excuse earns a nod and a clap: it is **plausible**.

Zoe's excuse was **plausible***: the bus really had broken down that morning.*

PARTS **plaus** applaud (Latin plaudere) + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR believable, reasonable, credible, likely

OPPOSITE implausible, unlikely, far-fetched

conviction kun-VIK-shun *noun*



MEANING a firmly held belief; also, a finding of guilt in court

MEMORY HOOK **con-VICT-ion: a belief that WINS you.** Everyone laughs at Tia's plan to turn the empty lot into a garden, but she plants her flag and won't budge. She speaks with **conviction**.

Nell spoke with **conviction** *about saving the old oak trees.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **vict** conquered (Latin vincere) + **-ion** the act or state of

SIMILAR belief, certainty, confidence, principle

OPPOSITE doubt, uncertainty

tenet TEN-it *noun*



MEANING a principle or belief held as true by a group

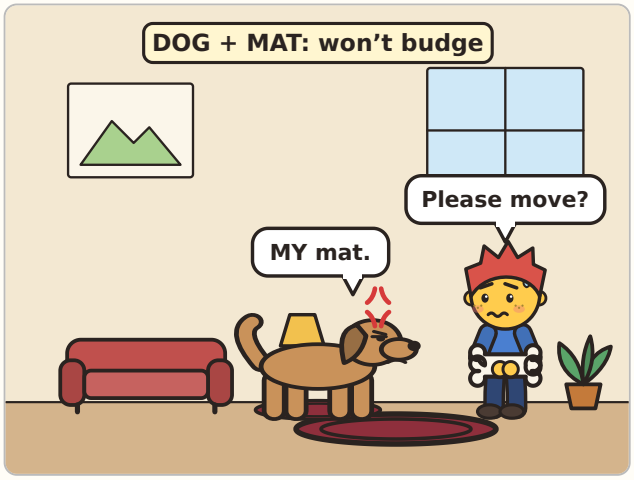
MEMORY HOOK **TEN = HOLD: a belief the club HOLDS.** The hiking club's sign lists the beliefs its members hold to, and number one is "Leave no trash." Each rule they hold is a **tenet**.

A basic **tenet** *of the hiking club is to leave no trash behind.*

PARTS **ten** hold

SIMILAR principle, belief, rule, doctrine

dogmatic dawg-MAT-ik *adjective*



MEANING insisting one's opinions are true without considering evidence

MEMORY HOOK **DOG + MAT: a dog that won't budge.** Rufus has decided that the doormat is his, and no treat, toy or argument will move him an inch. Stuck to an opinion like a dog on its mat is **dogmatic**.

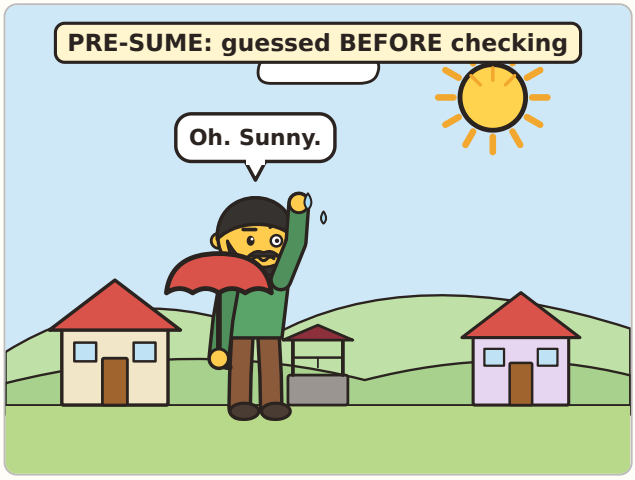
Our **dogmatic** *neighbor insists there is only one right way to mow a lawn.*

PARTS **dogma** opinion, belief (Greek) + **-tic** having to do with

SIMILAR opinionated, rigid, inflexible, closed-minded

OPPOSITE open-minded, flexible

presume prih-**ZOOM** *verb*



MEANING to suppose something is true without proof

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-SUME: take it as true BEFORE checking.** Omar sees wet umbrellas by the door and pops his own open before stepping out, into blazing sunshine. He did not check; he chose to **presume**.

I **presume** *you've already eaten, since there are crumbs on your shirt.*

PARTS **pre** before + **sum** take (Latin sumere)

SIMILAR assume, suppose, take for granted, guess

speculate **SPEK**-yuh-layt *verb*



MEANING to form ideas or theories without firm evidence

MEMORY HOOK **SPEC-ulate: look and guess, no peeking.** The kids stare at the big wrapped box and guess: a bike? a puppy? a robot? With no way to peek inside, all they can do is **speculate**.

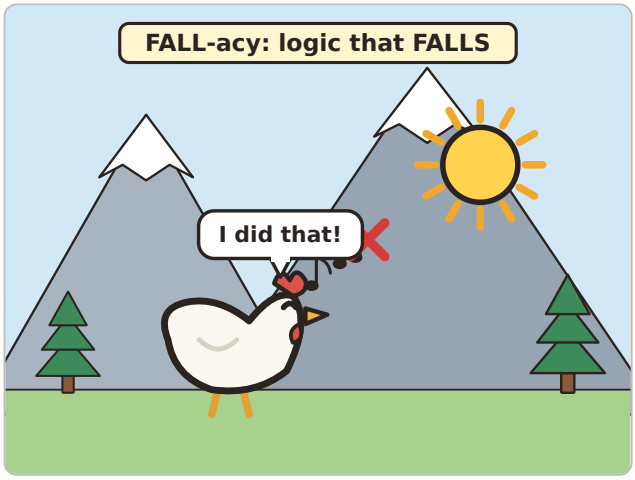
Fans **speculated** *about who would win the baking contest.*

PARTS **spec** look + **-ate** to do

SIMILAR guess, theorize, hypothesize, conjecture

OPPOSITE know, prove

fallacy **FAL**-uh-see *noun*



MEANING a mistaken belief, or a flaw in reasoning

MEMORY HOOK **FALL-acy: reasoning that FALLS apart.** The rooster crows, the sun comes up, and he proudly believes his crowing made it rise. That reasoning falls apart: it is a **fallacy**.

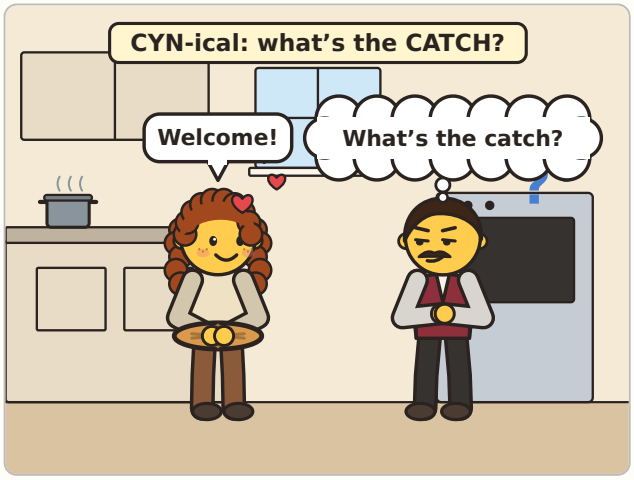
"Everyone I know likes pizza, so everyone in the world must like pizza" is a **fallacy**.

PARTS **fall** deceive (Latin fallere) + **-acy** the quality of

SIMILAR misconception, error, myth, false belief

OPPOSITE truth, fact

cynical **SIN**-ih-kul *adjective*



MEANING believing that people act only out of self-interest

MEMORY HOOK **CYN-ical: "What's the CATCH?".** Nell brings her new neighbor a pie, and Victor squints: "What's the catch? What do you want?" He thinks every kindness hides a selfish reason. Victor is **cynical**.

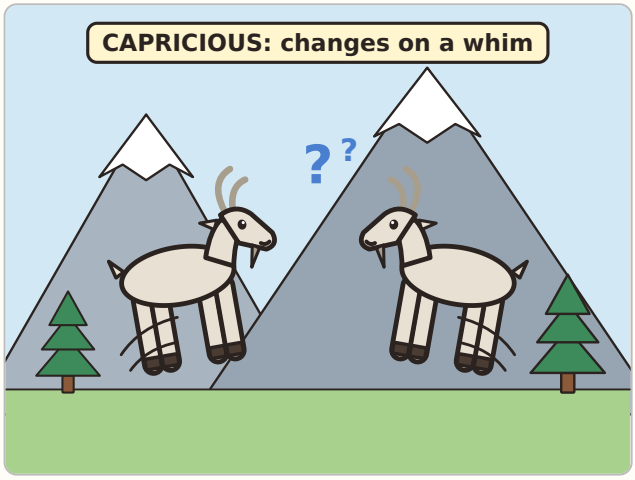
The **cynical** *shopper assumed the free samples must be some kind of trick.*

PARTS **cyn** dog (Greek kyon) + **-ical** having to do with

SIMILAR distrustful, suspicious, jaded, skeptical

OPPOSITE trusting, idealistic, naive

capricious kuh-**PRISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING changing suddenly and without reason

MEMORY HOOK **a goat on a whim: this way, then that.** The little goat leaps left, then right, then left again, for no reason at all: just a whim. Its leaping is **capricious**.

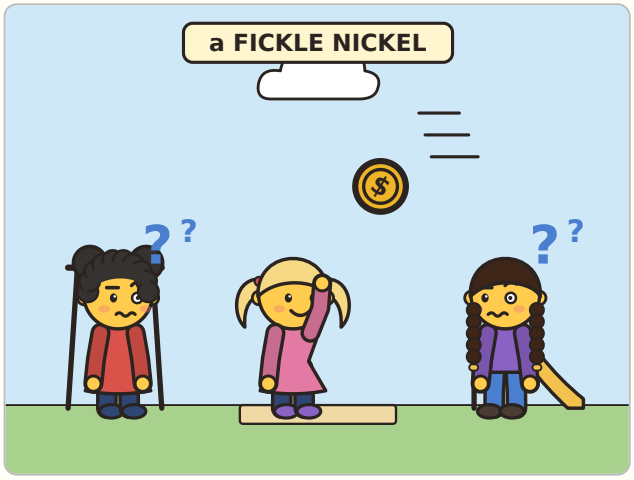
The **capricious** *weather switched from sunshine to hail three times in one afternoon.*

PARTS **capric** a whim (Italian capriccio) + **-ious** full of

SIMILAR fickle, unpredictable, changeable, whimsical

OPPOSITE steady, consistent, predictable

fickle **FIK**-ul *adjective*



MEANING changing loyalties or feelings often

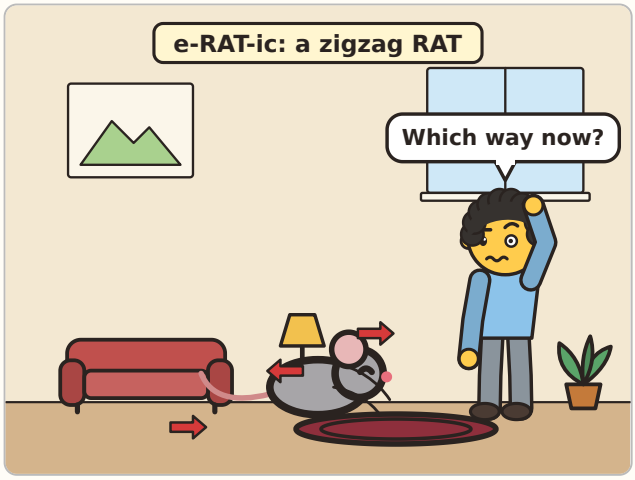
MEMORY HOOK **a FICKLE NICKEL: flips like a coin.** Ivy picks her best friend by flipping a nickel: heads it's Zoe, tails it's Lila, and tomorrow she flips again. Loyalty that flips like a coin is **fickle**.

The **fickle** *cat loved me on Monday and ignored me by Tuesday.*

SIMILAR changeable, inconstant, unreliable, capricious

OPPOSITE loyal, faithful, constant

erratic ih-**RAT**-ik *adjective*



MEANING not regular or predictable

MEMORY HOOK **e-RAT-ic: a RAT that zigzags.** The pet rat zigzags across the floor, left, right, back, around the sofa, so no one can guess where it will go next. Its path is **erratic**.

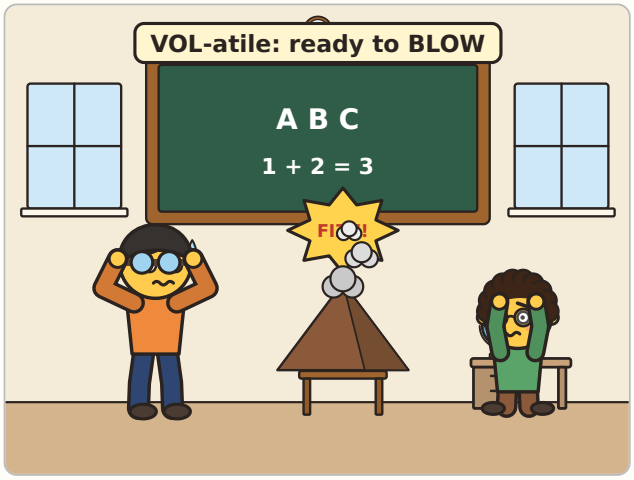
The old car's **erratic** *engine coughed, roared and then went silent.*

PARTS **err** wander (Latin errare) + **-atic** having to do with

SIMILAR unpredictable, irregular, inconsistent, uneven

OPPOSITE steady, regular, consistent

volatile **VOL**-uh-tul *adjective*



MEANING likely to change suddenly, often for the worse

MEMORY HOOK **VOL-atile: a VOLCANO ready to blow.** Dev's science-fair volcano rumbles and fizzes, and no one knows when it will blow. Anything ready to erupt or change suddenly is **volatile**.

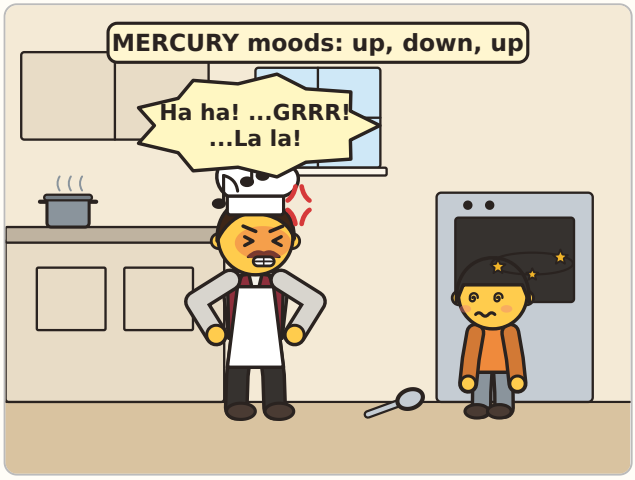
The **volatile** *stock market rose sharply in the morning and fell by afternoon.*

PARTS **vol** fly (Latin volare) + **-atile** able to

SIMILAR unstable, explosive, unpredictable, changeable

OPPOSITE stable, steady, calm

mercurial mer-**KYOOR**-ee-ul *adjective*



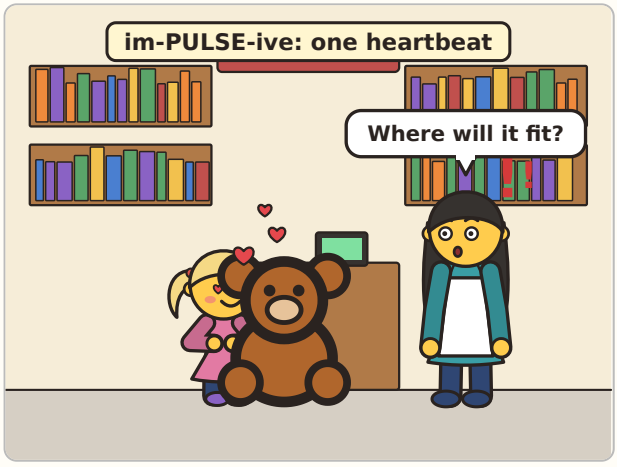
MEANING subject to sudden, unpredictable changes of mood

MEMORY HOOK **moods as quick as MERCURY.** Chef Victor laughs at a joke, roars at a dropped spoon, then hums happily, all in one minute. His moods slip and dart like quick, silvery mercury: he is **mercurial**.

The **mercurial** *chef was laughing one minute and shouting the next.*

SIMILAR temperamental, moody, volatile, changeable
OPPOSITE stable, steady, even-tempered

impulsive im-**PUL**-siv *adjective*



MEANING acting suddenly without thinking first

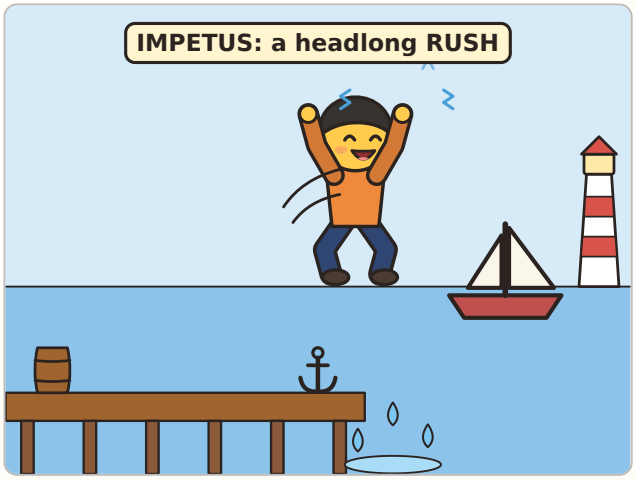
MEMORY HOOK **im-PULSE-ive: decided in one PULSE.** Ivy spots a giant teddy bear at the checkout and buys it in one heartbeat, without a thought about where it will fit. Her purchase is **impulsive**.

In an **impulsive** *moment, Jonah dyed his hair green the night before school photos.*

PARTS **im** on (from in-) + **puls** push, drive (Latin pellere) + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR rash, hasty, spontaneous, reckless
OPPOSITE cautious, deliberate, careful

impetuous im-**PECH**-oo-us *adjective*



MEANING acting quickly and rashly, without thought

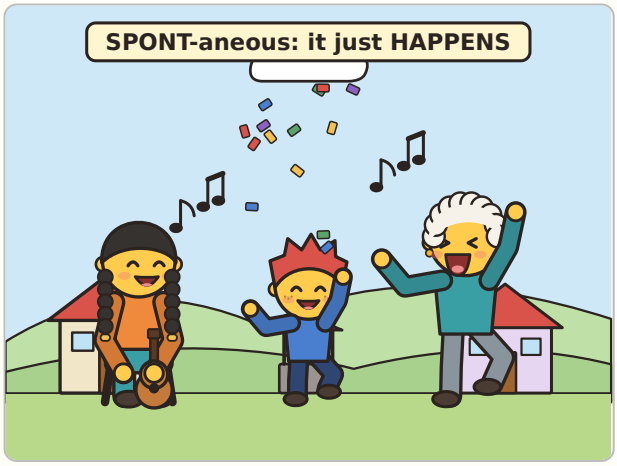
MEMORY HOOK **IMPETUS: a headlong RUSH.** Dev races down the dock and leaps into the lake without checking how cold it is. Splash! Brrr! His headlong leap was **impetuous**.

The **impetuous** *knight charged across the river without checking how deep it was.*

PARTS **im** on, against + **pet** rush at (Latin petere) + **-uous** full of

SIMILAR rash, hasty, impulsive, headlong
OPPOSITE cautious, careful, deliberate

spontaneous spon-**TAY**-nee-us *adjective*



MEANING happening naturally, without planning

MEMORY HOOK **SPONT-aneous: it just HAPPENS.** One neighbor starts strumming a guitar on her steps, and soon the whole street is dancing, with no plan at all. The party is **spontaneous**.

The crowd broke into **spontaneous** *applause when the puppy crossed the finish line.*

PARTS **spont** of one's own accord (Latin sponte) + **-aneous** having the quality of

SIMILAR unplanned, impromptu, natural, unrehearsed
OPPOSITE planned, rehearsed, deliberate

vacillate **VAS**-uh-layt *verb*



MEANING to waver back and forth between choices

MEMORY HOOK **VAS-illate: VANILLA? chocolate? VANILLA?.** Kai stares at the menu: vanilla? chocolate? vanilla? He sways back and forth so long that the shop closes. To waver like that is to **vacillate**.

Kai **vacillated** *between chocolate and vanilla until the shop closed.*

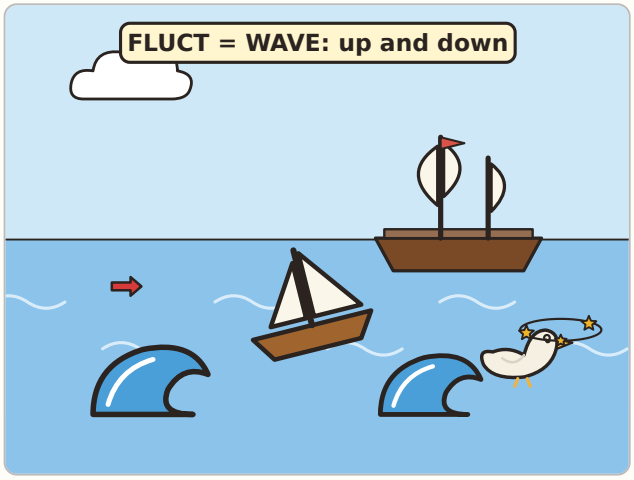
PARTS **vacill** sway, totter (Latin vacillare) + **-ate** to do

SIMILAR waver, dither, hesitate, seesaw

OPPOSITE decide, commit

17. Changeable

fluctuate **FLUK**-choo-ayt *verb*



MEANING to rise and fall irregularly

MEMORY HOOK **FLUCT = WAVE: up and down.** The little boat rides the waves up, down, up, down, never level for a moment. Things that rise and fall like waves **fluctuate**.

The price of strawberries **fluctuates** *with the seasons.*

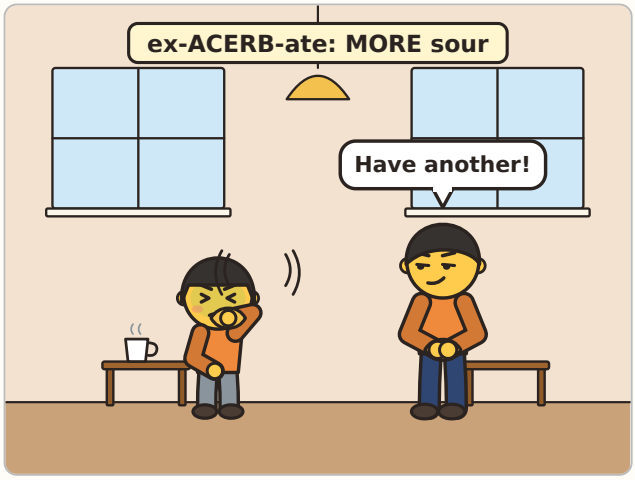
PARTS **fluct** wave (Latin fluctus) + **-uate** to do

SIMILAR vary, rise and fall, swing, seesaw

OPPOSITE stabilize, hold steady

17. Changeable

exacerbate ig-**ZAS**-er-bayt *verb*



MEANING to make a problem or pain worse

MEMORY HOOK **ex-ACERB-ate: add more SOUR to the sour.** Kai is already puckering from one lemon, and his brother hands him another. Adding sour to sour is how you **exacerbate** a problem.

Scratching a mosquito bite only **exacerbates** *the itch.*

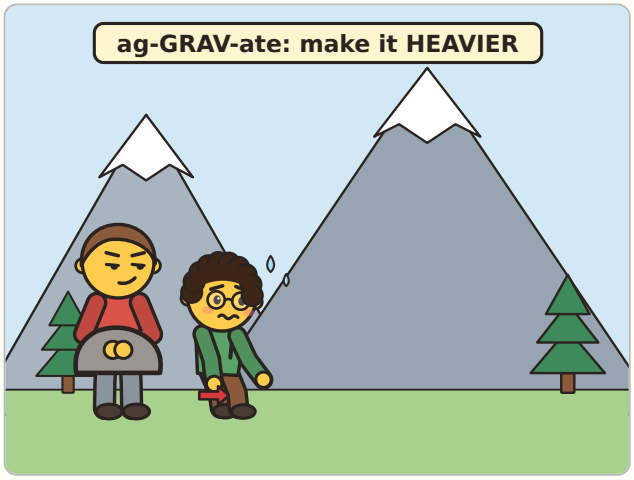
PARTS **ex** thoroughly + **acerb** harsh, bitter (Latin acerbus) + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR worsen, aggravate, intensify, inflame

OPPOSITE alleviate, ease, mitigate

18. Making Things Worse

aggravate **AG**-ruh-vayt *verb*



MEANING to make worse; also, in everyday speech, to annoy

MEMORY HOOK **ag-GRAV-ate: make it HEAVIER.** Sami's backpack is already heavy, and then Jonah sneaks a big rock into it. Grav means heavy: to **aggravate** a problem is to make it heavier.

Lifting heavy boxes **aggravated** *the coach's sore back.*

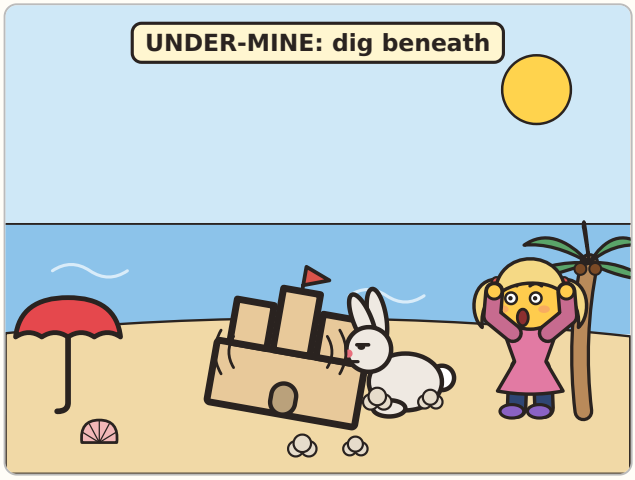
PARTS **ag** to (from ad) + **grav** heavy + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR worsen, exacerbate, inflame, compound

OPPOSITE alleviate, ease, improve

18. Making Things Worse

undermine un-der-**MINE** *verb*



MEANING to weaken gradually or secretly

MEMORY HOOK **UNDER-MINE: dig beneath it.** A rabbit tunnels under the sandcastle's tallest tower, and day by day the tower leans a little more. Weakening something from underneath is to **undermine** it.

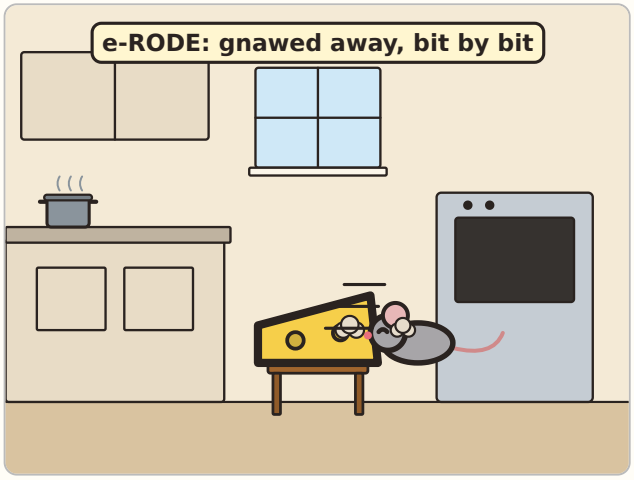
Constant teasing can **undermine** *a child's confidence.*

PARTS **under** beneath + **mine** dig a tunnel

SIMILAR weaken, erode, subvert, sabotage

OPPOSITE strengthen, support, bolster

erode ih-**ROHD** *verb*



MEANING to wear away slowly

MEMORY HOOK **e-RODE: gnawed away, as by a RODent.** Night after night, a little mouse nibbles the big wheel of cheese until only a sliver is left. Rodere means to gnaw: water, wind and time **erode** things the same slow way.

Waves **eroded** *the cliff a little more each winter.*

PARTS **e** away (from ex) + **rod** gnaw (Latin rodere)

SIMILAR wear away, wear down, corrode, undermine

OPPOSITE build up, strengthen

deteriorate dih-**TEER**-ee-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to become worse

MEMORY HOOK **de-TEAR-iorate: one TEAR, then more.** Kai's old kite starts with one small tear; after a week of wind, it is more holes than kite. It has **deteriorated**.

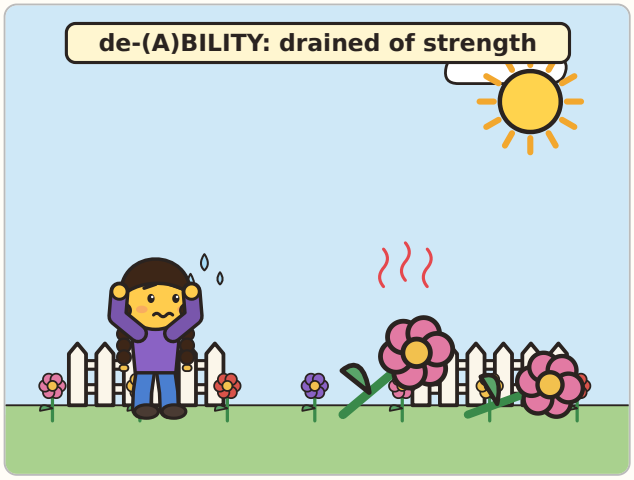
Left out in the rain, the old book **deteriorated** *until its pages stuck together.*

PARTS **deterior** worse (Latin deterior) + **-ate** to become

SIMILAR worsen, decline, decay, degenerate

OPPOSITE improve, recover

debilitate dih-**BIL**-ih-tayt *verb*



MEANING to weaken severely

MEMORY HOOK **de-(A)BILITY-ate: takes away all ABILITY.** Day after day of blazing heat drains every bit of strength from the sunflowers until they droop to the ground. A heat wave can **debilitate** a garden.

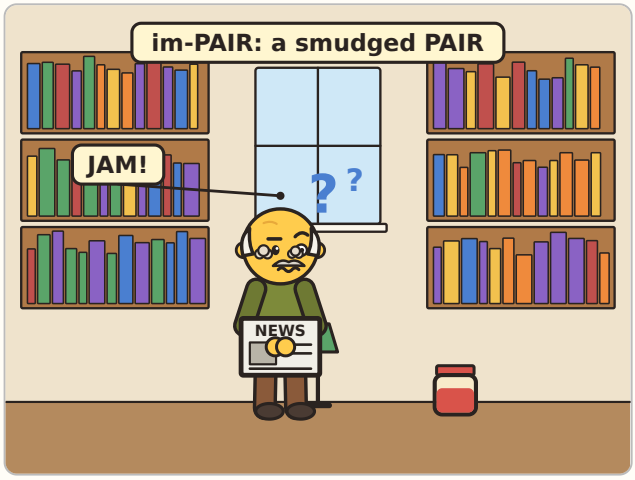
The long heat wave **debilitated** *the garden's tomato plants.*

PARTS **debil** weak (Latin debilis) + **-itate** to make

SIMILAR weaken, enfeeble, sap, exhaust

OPPOSITE strengthen, invigorate, energize

impair im-**PAIR** *verb*



MEANING to damage or weaken

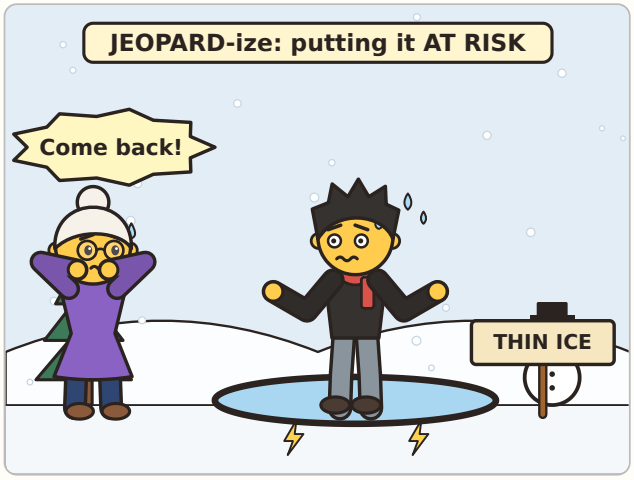
MEMORY HOOK **im-PAIR: a smudged PAIR of glasses.** Grandpa's pair of glasses is smeared with jam, and now he can barely read the paper. The smudges **impair** his sight.

Very loud music can **impair** *your hearing over time.*

PARTS **im** in, into + **pair** worse (Latin pejor)

SIMILAR damage, weaken, harm, diminish
OPPOSITE improve, enhance, strengthen

jeopardize **JEP**-er-dize *verb*



MEANING to put in danger or at risk

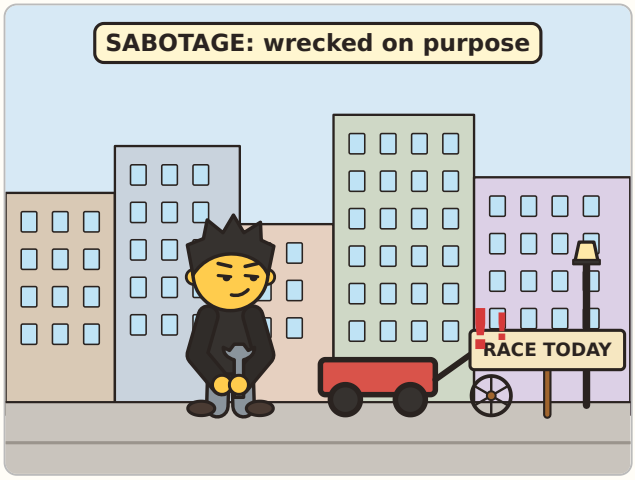
MEMORY HOOK **JEOPARD-ize: put in JEOPARDY.** Ignoring the THIN ICE sign, Rex skates right out to the middle of the pond, and every crack puts him in jeopardy. He chose to **jeopardize** his own safety.

Skipping practice could **jeopardize** *Rosa's spot on the team.*

PARTS **-ize** to make, to put into

SIMILAR endanger, risk, threaten, imperil
OPPOSITE protect, safeguard, secure

sabotage **SAB**-uh-tahzh *verb*



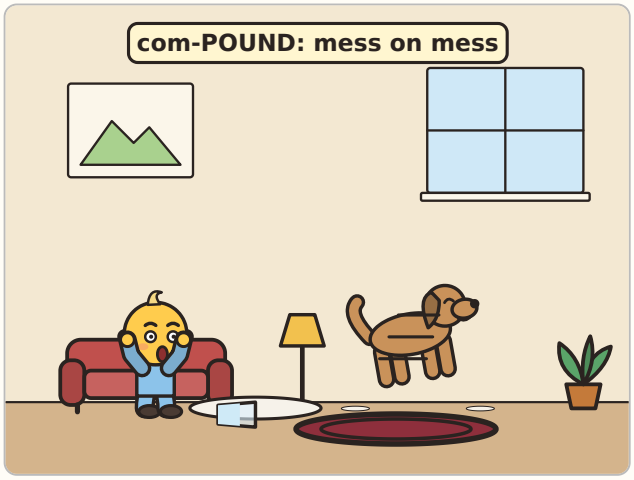
MEANING to damage or ruin on purpose

MEMORY HOOK **SAB-o-TAGE: a sneaky, secret wreck.** Before the wagon race, Rex creeps over and loosens a wheel on his rival's wagon. Wrecking something on purpose is to **sabotage** it.

Someone **sabotaged** *the science-fair volcano by swapping the baking soda for flour.*

SIMILAR undermine, wreck, spoil, disrupt
OPPOSITE support, protect, help

compound kum-**POWND** *verb*



MEANING to make a problem worse by adding to it

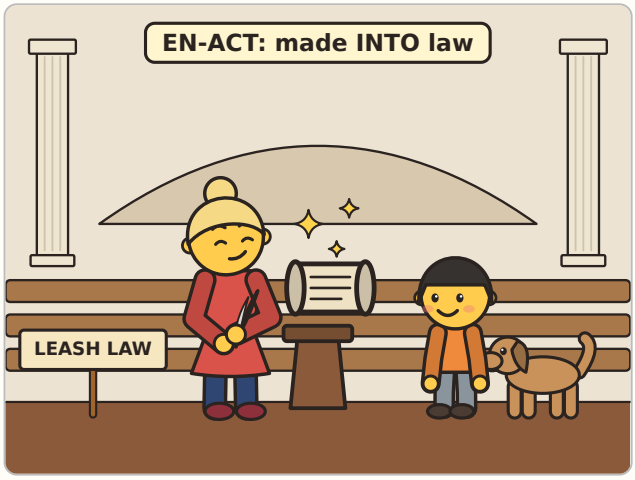
MEMORY HOOK **com-POUND: POUND more trouble on top.** Theo spills his milk, and then the puppy runs through the puddle and tracks white paw prints across the whole house. The puppy **compounded** the problem.

Arriving late, Dev **compounded** *the problem by forgetting his uniform.*

PARTS **com** together + **pound** put (Latin ponere)

SIMILAR worsen, aggravate, add to, exacerbate
OPPOSITE lessen, ease, alleviate

enact en-**AKT** *verb*



MEANING to make into law

MEMORY HOOK **EN-ACT: turn a plan INTO an ACT (a law).** The town council votes yes, and the mayor signs the new leash rule with a flourish: now it is an official act. To make a plan into law is to **enact** it.

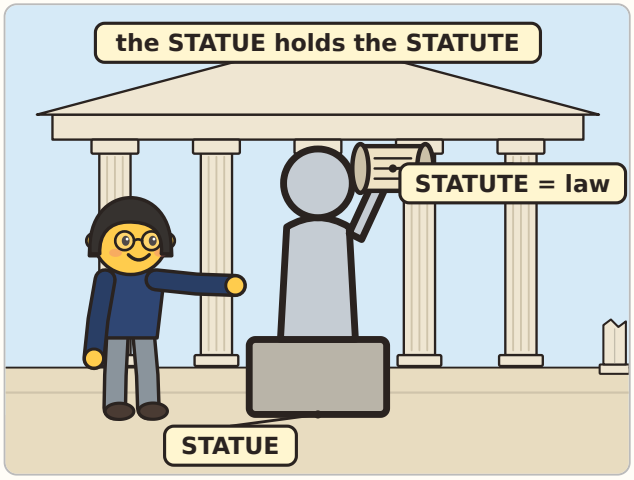
The town council **enacted** *a rule requiring dogs to be leashed in the park.*

PARTS **en** into + **act** a law, a thing done

SIMILAR pass, establish, make law

OPPOSITE repeal, abolish, rescind

statute **STACH**-oot *noun*



MEANING a written law

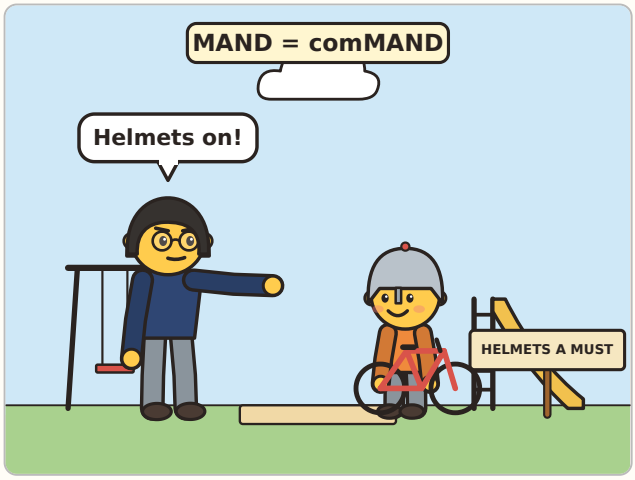
MEMORY HOOK **the STATUE holds the STATUTE.** In front of the courthouse, a stone statue holds up a scroll: the town's first written law. The statue is art; the scroll is a **statute**.

A **statute** *passed by the state lawmakers last spring bans fireworks after ten o'clock at night.*

PARTS **stat** set up, stand (Latin statuere)

SIMILAR law, act, regulation, ordinance

mandate **MAN**-dayt *noun*



MEANING an official order; also, authority given by voters

MEMORY HOOK **MAND = comMAND: an official order.** The principal posts the new command by the bike path: "Helmets required." An official order like that is a **mandate**.

The school board issued a **mandate***: every student must wear a helmet on the bike path.*

PARTS **mand** order, entrust + **-ate** the result of (a noun ending)

SIMILAR order, command, directive, authority

decree dih-**KREE** *noun*



MEANING an official order from a ruler or authority

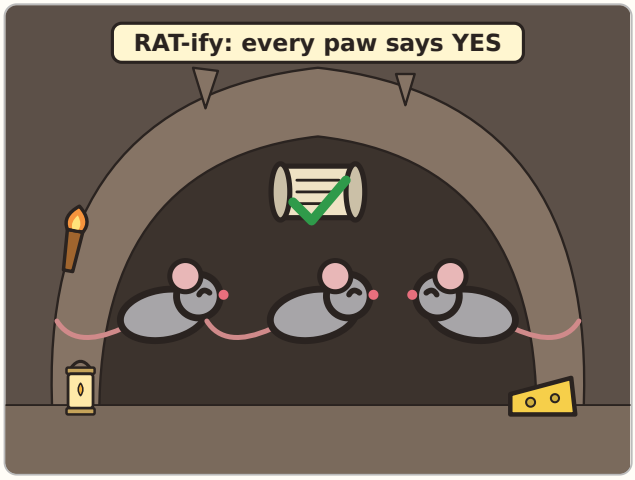
MEMORY HOOK **de-CREE: the king DECIDES, all AGREE.** The king raises his scepter: "From now on, every Friday is ice-cream day!" The king decides, and everyone must agree. A ruler's official order is a **decree**.

By royal **decree***, the last Friday in June became a holiday.*

PARTS **de** from + **cre** decide, sift (Latin cernere)

SIMILAR order, edict, command, proclamation

ratify RAT-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to formally approve an agreement or plan

MEMORY HOOK **RAT-ify: every RAT's paw says YES.** The rats hold a meeting on their new cheese-sharing rules, and every paw goes up. When a group formally approves an agreement, they **ratify** it.

The club members voted to **ratify** *the new rules.*

PARTS **rat** fixed, settled (Latin ratus) + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR approve, confirm, endorse, sanction

OPPOSITE reject, veto, repeal

veto VEE-toh *noun*



MEANING the power to reject a decision or law, or such a rejection

MEMORY HOOK **VETO: Latin for "I FORBID!".** The kids vote three to nothing to adopt a goat, but Mom holds up one hand: "I forbid it." That single blocking vote is a **veto**.

Mom used her **veto** *on our plan to adopt a goat.*

SIMILAR rejection, refusal, ban, block

OPPOSITE approval, ratification, assent

abolish uh-BOL-ish *verb*



MEANING to end something officially, completely and for good

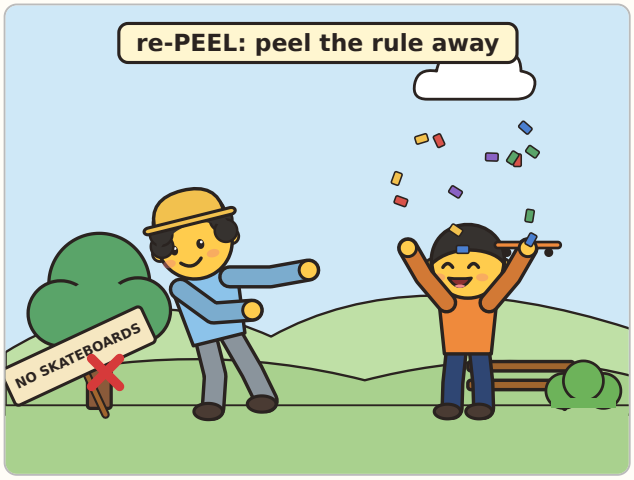
MEMORY HOOK **a-BOWL-ish: BOWLED over for good.** The town bowls over the old toll gate on the bridge: no more stopping, no more paying, gone for good. To end something completely is to **abolish** it.

The school **abolished** *its old rule against wearing hats in the hallway.*

SIMILAR end, eliminate, do away with, scrap

OPPOSITE establish, create, institute

repeal rih-PEEL *verb*



MEANING to cancel a law officially

MEMORY HOOK **re-PEEL: PEEL the old rule off the wall.** A worker peels the old "NO SKATEBOARDS" sign right off the park wall, and the skaters cheer. To officially cancel a law is to **repeal** it.

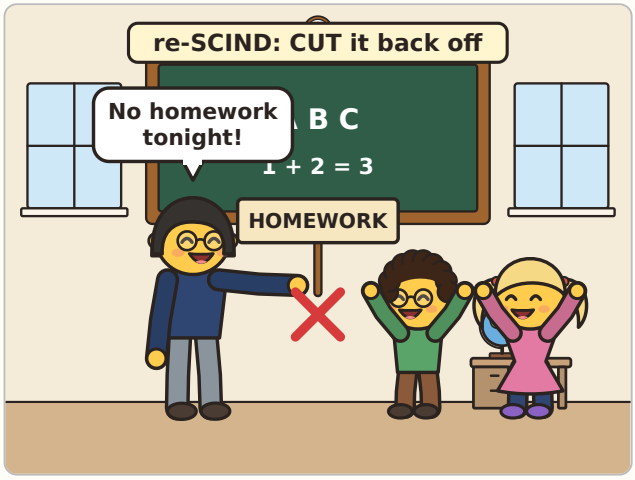
The city **repealed** *its old ban on skateboards in the park.*

PARTS **re** back + **peal** call (Old French apeler)

SIMILAR revoke, rescind, cancel, overturn

OPPOSITE enact, pass, ratify

rescind rih-**SIND** *verb*



MEANING to take back or cancel an order, offer or decision

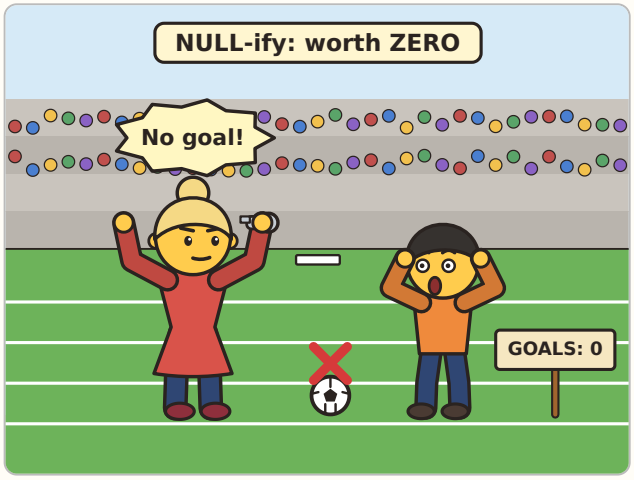
MEMORY HOOK **re-SCIND: CUT the order back off.** Ms. Ada writes HOMEWORK on the board, then the class wins the spelling bee, and she crosses it right off. To take back an order is to **rescind** it.

The coach **rescinded** *the extra laps after the team apologized.*

PARTS **re** back + **scind** cut (Latin scindere)

SIMILAR revoke, cancel, withdraw, take back
OPPOSITE grant, issue, enact

nullify **NUL**-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to make legally void; to cancel out

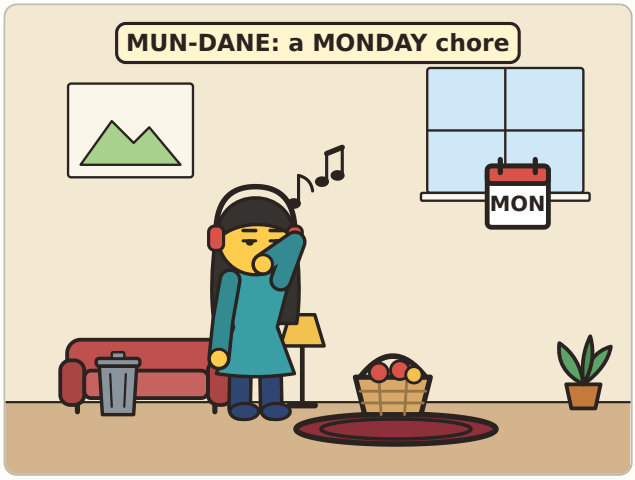
MEMORY HOOK **NULL-ify: make it NULL, worth ZERO.** Dev's goal flies in, but the referee blows her whistle and waves it off: offside. The goal now counts for zero; she has **nullified** it.

A missing signature **nullified** *the contract.*

PARTS **null** none, nothing (Latin nullus) + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR cancel, void, invalidate, negate
OPPOSITE validate, confirm

mundane mun-**DAYN** *adjective*



MEANING ordinary and everyday; dull

MEMORY HOOK **MUN-DANE: a MONDAY chore.** Every Monday it is the same: fold the laundry, take out the trash, wash the dishes. Plain, everyday chores like these are **mundane**.

Folding laundry is a **mundane** *chore, so Lin listens to music while she does it.*

PARTS **mund** world (Latin mundus) + **-ane** having to do with

SIMILAR ordinary, everyday, routine, humdrum
OPPOSITE extraordinary, exciting, remarkable

commonplace **KOM**-un-plays *adjective*



MEANING ordinary; not unusual

MEMORY HOOK **seen in COMMON PLACES everywhere.** A plane roars over the river, and nobody fishing even looks up; you can see planes in common places everywhere. They are **commonplace** now.

Phones that take pictures, once a wonder, are now **commonplace**.

PARTS **common** shared, ordinary + **place** spot

SIMILAR ordinary, common, everyday, routine
OPPOSITE rare, unusual, extraordinary

conventional kun-**VEN**-shuh-nul *adjective*



MEANING following what is usually done; traditional

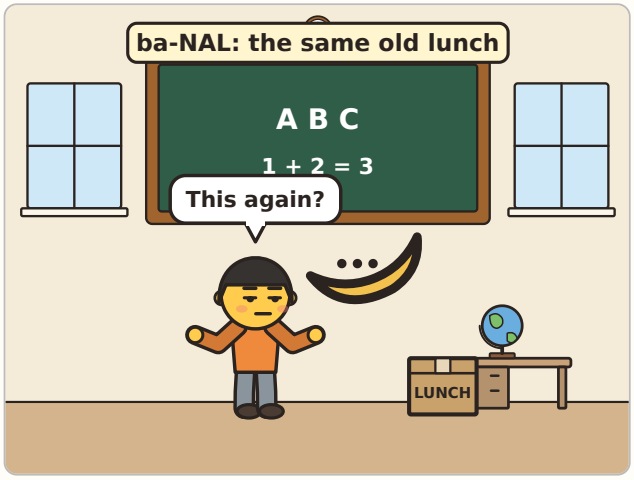
MEMORY HOOK **CONVENTION-al: the way everyone agreed on.** At the business convention, every guest wears the same gray jacket and tie, the way everyone agreed long ago. Their style is **conventional**.

Instead of a **conventional** *birthday cake, Dev asked for a tower of pancakes.*

PARTS **con** together + **vent** come (Latin venire) + **-ion** the act of + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR traditional, standard, customary, orthodox
OPPOSITE unconventional, unusual, original

banal buh-**NAL** *adjective*



MEANING dull and unoriginal because so common

MEMORY HOOK **ba-NAL: the same old BANANA.** Every single day, Kai's lunch is one plain banana: no surprise, no change, nothing new. A lunch that dull and predictable is **banal**.

The movie's ending was **banal***: the hero won, the villain lost, and everyone cheered, just as we expected.*

SIMILAR trite, hackneyed, unoriginal, dull
OPPOSITE original, fresh, novel

trite **TRITE** *adjective*



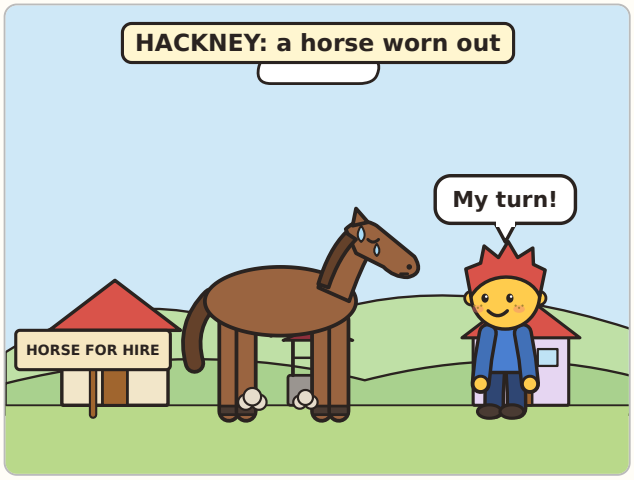
MEANING used so often that it is no longer interesting

MEMORY HOOK **TRITE: TRIED and TRIED and TRIED.** Grandpa tells his favorite joke for the hundredth time, and the whole family groans: it has been tried too many times. The joke is **trite**.

"Every cloud has a silver lining" felt **trite** *to Maya right after she lost the match.*

SIMILAR overused, hackneyed, stale, clichéd
OPPOSITE original, fresh, novel

hackneyed **HAK**-need *adjective*



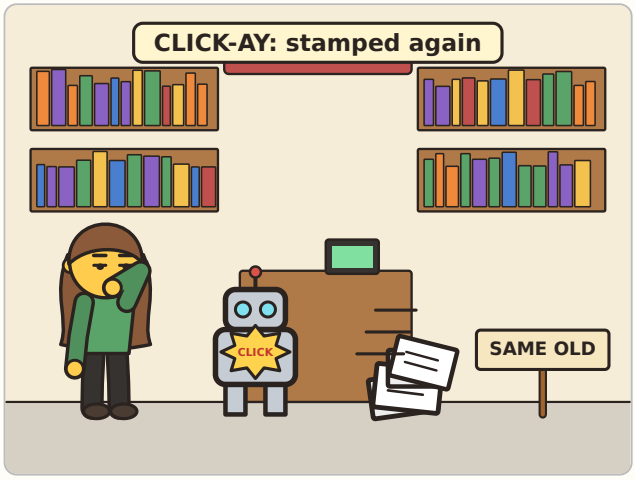
MEANING overused and unoriginal

MEMORY HOOK **HACKNEY: a hired horse worn out by use.** The old hired horse has carried every tourist in town and now plods along, worn out by use. An idea worn out the same way is **hackneyed**.

The **hackneyed** *plot, a lost dog finds its way home, had been filmed a dozen times.*

SIMILAR overused, trite, stale, clichéd
OPPOSITE original, fresh, innovative

cliché klee-**SHAY** *noun*



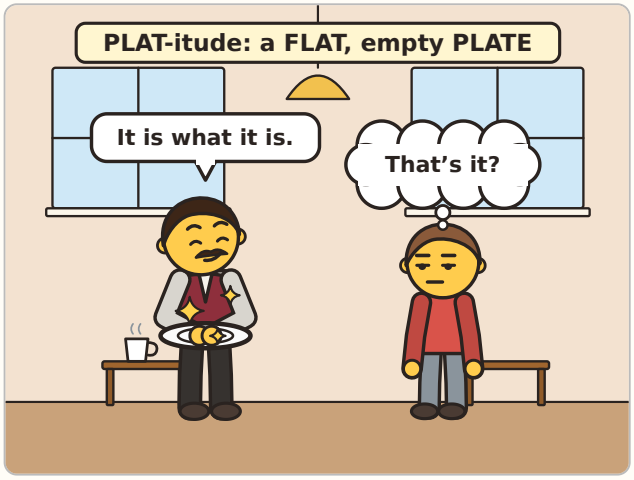
MEANING an overused phrase or idea

MEMORY HOOK **CLICK-AY: CLICK, the same stamp again.** Click! Click! Click! The old printing plate stamps the very same phrase on page after page. A phrase repeated that often is a **cliché**.

"At the end of the day" is a **cliché** *that adds nothing to most sentences.*

SIMILAR stock phrase, platitude, worn-out saying, commonplace

platitude **PLAT**-ih-tood *noun*



MEANING a dull, obvious remark offered as if it were wise or new

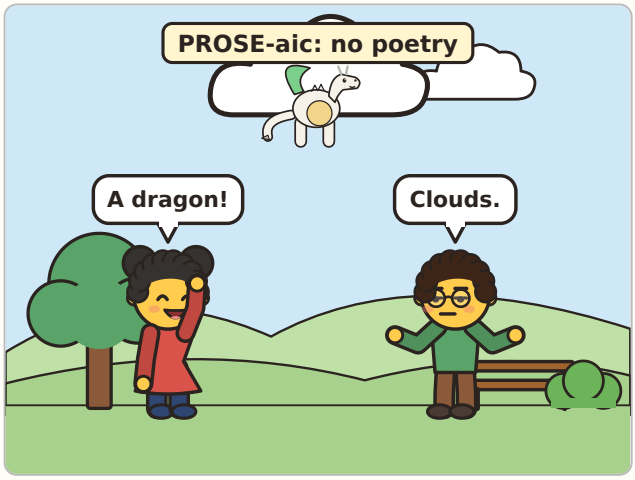
MEMORY HOOK **PLAT-itude: a FLAT, empty PLATE.** Uncle Victor serves up an empty plate of wisdom: "Well, it is what it is." A flat, obvious remark offered as if it were deep is a **platitude**.

"Everything happens for a reason" was the only **platitude** *the coach could offer after the loss.*

PARTS **plat** flat (French plat) + **-itude** the state of

SIMILAR cliché, truism, commonplace, banality

prosaic proh-**ZAY**-ik *adjective*



MEANING dull and unimaginative; lacking poetry

MEMORY HOOK **PROSE-aic: plain PROSE, no poetry.** Zoe looks up and sees a dragon, a castle and a ship in the clouds. Sami looks up and says, "Those are clouds." His plain, unpoetic answer is **prosaic**.

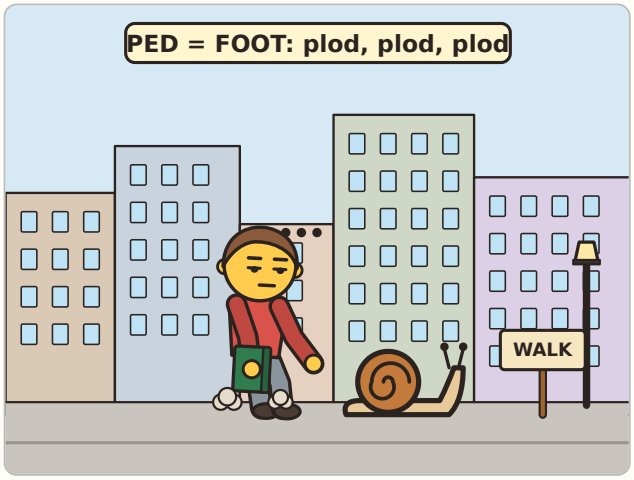
Asked what the clouds looked like, the **prosaic** *boy said only, "Clouds."*

PARTS **prosa** prose, plain writing + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR dull, unimaginative, ordinary, matter-of-fact

OPPOSITE imaginative, poetic, inspired

pedestrian puh-**DES**-tree-un *adjective*



MEANING ordinary and dull; lacking imagination

MEMORY HOOK **PED = FOOT: plods along, never flies.** Jonah's story plods along like a tired walker, step, step, step, with a snail for company. Writing that never takes flight is **pedestrian**.

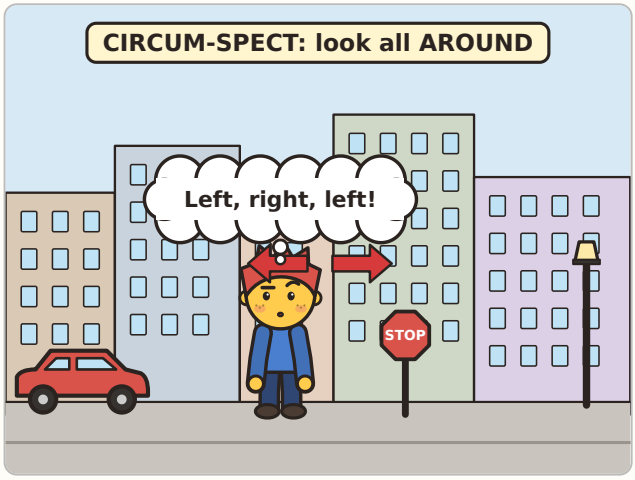
The band's second album was **pedestrian** *compared with its brilliant first one.*

PARTS **ped** foot

SIMILAR dull, uninspired, ordinary, mediocre

OPPOSITE inspired, exciting, original

circumspect **SUR**-kum-spekt *adjective*



MEANING careful to think about risks before acting

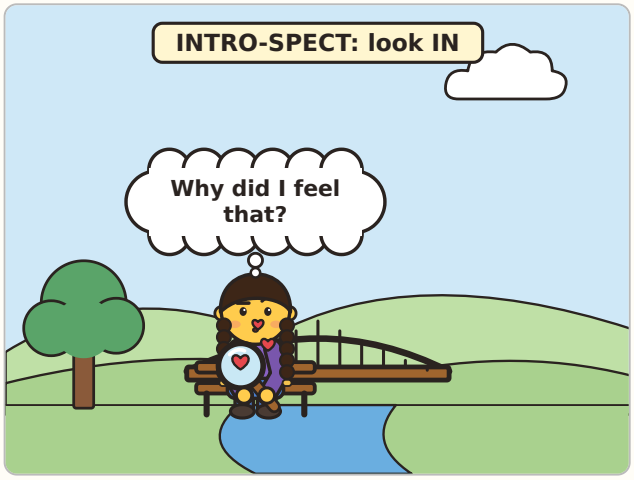
MEMORY HOOK **CIRCUM-SPECT: look all AROUND.** Before Pip crosses the busy street, he looks all around: left, right and left again. Looking all around before you act is being **circumspect**.

A **circumspect** *hiker checks the weather twice before setting out.*

PARTS **circum** around + **spect** look

SIMILAR cautious, careful, wary, prudent
OPPOSITE rash, reckless, careless

introspective in-truh-**SPEK**-tiv *adjective*



MEANING looking inward at your own thoughts and feelings

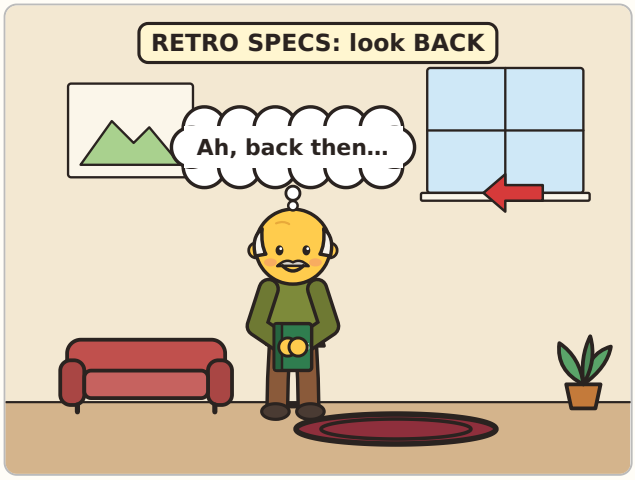
MEMORY HOOK **INTRO-SPECT: look IN.** Lila holds a magnifying glass up to her own heart: she is looking inside herself. A person who looks in like that is **introspective**.

After the game, the **introspective** *pitcher sat alone, replaying every choice he had made.*

PARTS **intro** inward, within + **spect** look + **-ive** tending to (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR reflective, thoughtful, self-examining, contemplative
OPPOSITE unreflective, outward-looking

retrospect **RET**-ruh-spekt *noun*



MEANING a look back at things that have already happened

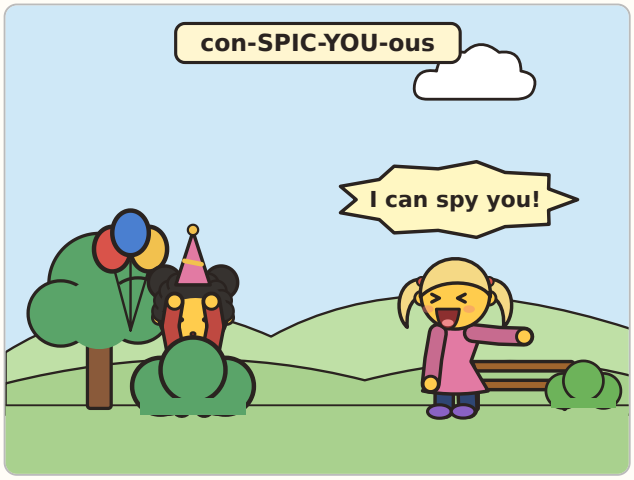
MEMORY HOOK **RETRO SPECS: glasses that look back.** Grandpa Gus puts on his old-fashioned specs and pages through photos from fifty years ago. Looking back like that is **retrospect**.

In **retrospect**, *packing three sweaters for a beach trip was silly.*

PARTS **retro** backward + **spect** look

SIMILAR hindsight, looking back, review, remembrance
OPPOSITE foresight, prospect

conspicuous kun-**SPIK**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING easy to see or notice; standing out

MEMORY HOOK **I CAN SPY YOU: con-SPIC-YOU-ous.** Zoe hides behind a little bush, but her balloons and party hat stick out. “I can spy you!” Ivy calls. Zoe is **conspicuous**.

Dad’s orange hat made him **conspicuous** *in the crowd at the airport.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **spic** look + **-uous** having (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR noticeable, obvious, eye-catching, prominent
OPPOSITE inconspicuous, hidden, unnoticeable

auspicious aw-**SPISH**-us *adjective*



MEANING promising good things to come; favorable

MEMORY HOOK **AW, SPECIAL! a rainbow on race day.** On the morning of the big race, a rainbow arches over the track and Tia gasps, "Aw, special!" A sign that things will go well is **auspicious**.

A sunny sky on opening day was an **auspicious** *start for the new farmers' market.*

PARTS **au** bird + **spic** look + **-ious** full of

SIMILAR promising, favorable, hopeful, encouraging
OPPOSITE ominous, unpromising, inauspicious

specious **SPEE**-shus *adjective*



MEANING seeming true or right at first but false underneath

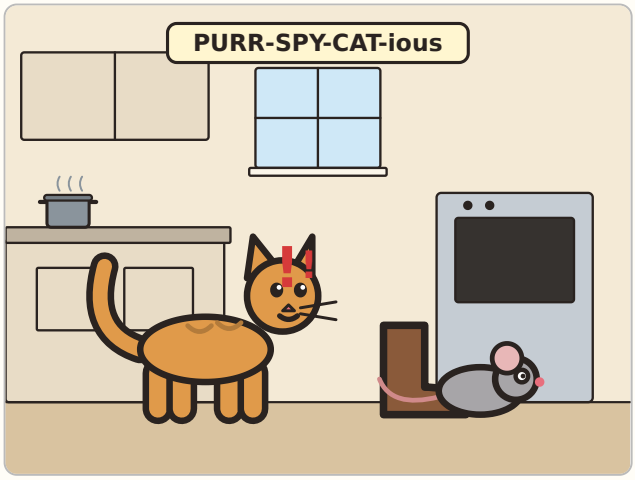
MEMORY HOOK **SEE? SHUSH! Don't check it.** "See? Shush, don't check!" says the salesman, because his claim only sounds right until someone looks closely. It is **specious**.

The ad's **specious** *promise that the shoes would make anyone run faster fooled no one on the track team.*

PARTS **spec** look, appearance + **-ious** full of

SIMILAR misleading, deceptive, false, hollow
OPPOSITE sound, valid, genuine

perspicacious pur-spih-**KAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING quick to notice and understand things; sharp-minded

MEMORY HOOK **PURR-SPY-CAT: she sees through it all.** The Purr-Spy Cat spots the mouse hiding by the boot that everyone else walked right past. A sharp noticer like her is **perspicacious**.

The **perspicacious** *detective noticed that the muddy boots were two sizes too small.*

PARTS **per** through + **spic** look + **-acious** inclined to, full of

SIMILAR perceptive, sharp, shrewd, insightful
OPPOSITE obtuse, dull, slow-witted

provident **PROV**-ih-dunt *adjective*



MEANING planning wisely for the future, especially by saving

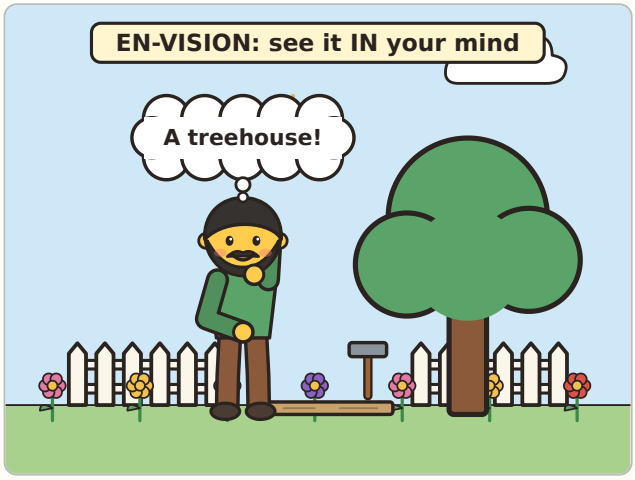
MEMORY HOOK **PROVIDE-ent: see winter coming, PROVIDE for it.** The squirrel sees winter coming and provides for it, one basket of food at a time. Seeing ahead and saving is being **provident**.

The **provident** *squirrel buried nuts all autumn and ate well all winter.*

PARTS **pro** ahead, forward + **vid** see + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR prudent, thrifty, farsighted, careful
OPPOSITE improvident, wasteful, shortsighted

envision en-**VIZH**-un *verb*



MEANING to picture something in the mind, especially something that could happen

MEMORY HOOK **EN-VISION: see it IN your head.** Before Omar saws a single board, he can see the whole treehouse in his head. To **envision** is to see it in your mind first.

Ada could **envision** *the empty lot as a garden full of sunflowers.*

PARTS **en** in, into + **vis** see + **-ion** the act of (a noun ending)

SIMILAR imagine, picture, visualize, foresee

visage **viz**-ij *noun*



MEANING a person's face, or the look on it

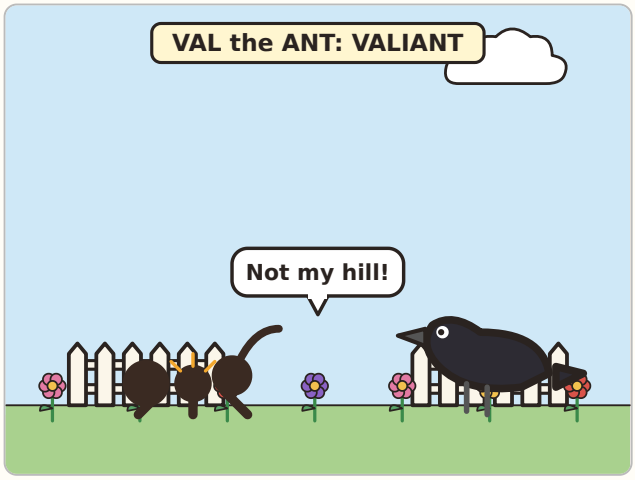
MEMORY HOOK **VIS-AGE: the face shows your AGE.** Grandpa's face in the mirror shows his age: every smile line from eighty happy years. That face is his **visage**.

The old captain's weathered **visage** *broke into a wide grin.*

PARTS **vis** see, a look

SIMILAR face, countenance, features, expression

valiant **val**-yunt *adjective*



MEANING brave and determined, especially in a hard fight

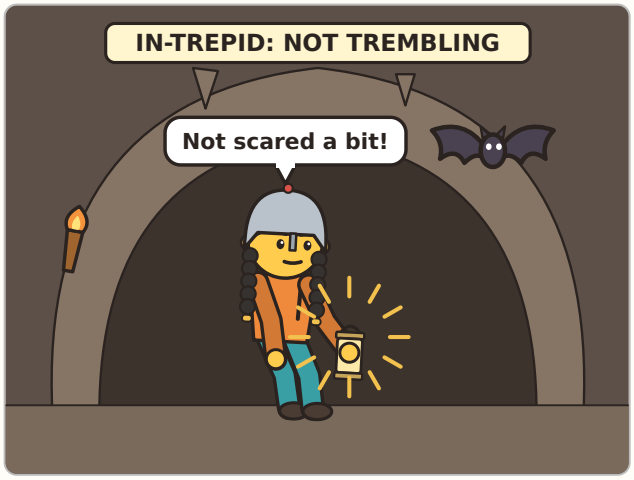
MEMORY HOOK **VAL the ANT: small but VALIANT.** Val the ant plants her feet and faces the hungry crow to guard her hill. Tiny Val is **valiant**.

The **valiant** *firefighters carried every last puppy out of the burning shelter.*

SIMILAR brave, courageous, heroic, bold

OPPOSITE cowardly, craven, timid

intrepid in-**TREP**-id *adjective*



MEANING fearless and adventurous

MEMORY HOOK **IN-TREPID: NOT TREMBLING.** Trepid means trembling, and in- means not. Tia steps into the dark cave with her lantern without a single shiver: she is **intrepid**.

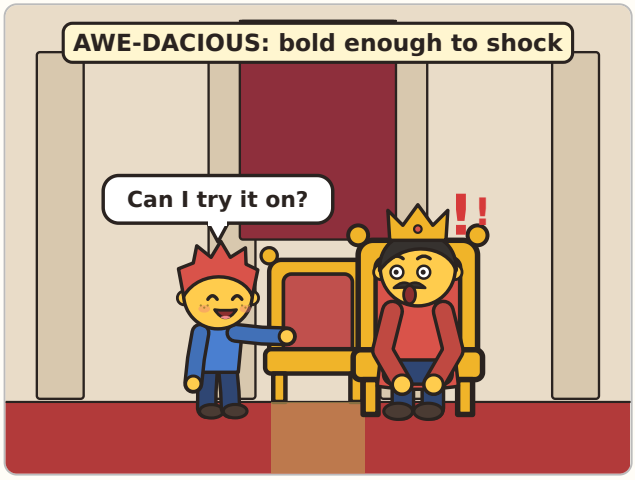
The **intrepid** *explorer paddled alone up the unmapped river.*

PARTS **in-** not + **trepid** trembling, alarmed

SIMILAR fearless, brave, bold, daring

OPPOSITE timid, fearful, timorous

audacious aw-**DAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING boldly daring, sometimes to the point of rudeness

MEMORY HOOK **AWE-DACIOUS: so bold it leaves us in AWE.** Little Pip marches up to the king and asks to try on his crown. The whole court gasps in awe at such an **audacious** request.

Asking the famous chef for her secret recipe on live TV was an **audacious** *move.*

PARTS **aud** dare (from Latin audere) + **-acious** full of, inclined to

SIMILAR daring, bold, brazen, gutsy

OPPOSITE timid, cautious, meek

dauntless **DAWNT**-lis *adjective*



MEANING not discouraged by danger or difficulty

MEMORY HOOK **DAWN-TLESS: out at DAWN in any storm.** Every day at dawn, through snow and howling wind, Greta delivers the mail. No storm can discourage her: she is **dauntless**.

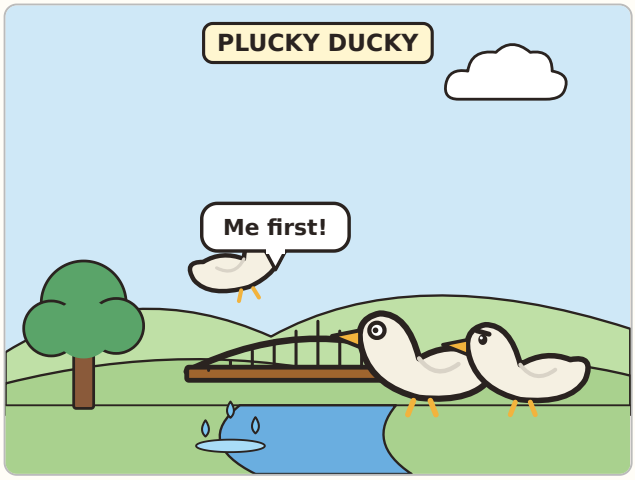
The **dauntless** *mail carrier delivered every letter through the blizzard.*

PARTS **daunt** to frighten, discourage + **-less** without

SIMILAR undaunted, fearless, brave, unflinching

OPPOSITE fainthearted, timid, discouraged

plucky **PLUK**-ee *adjective*



MEANING brave and spirited, especially against the odds

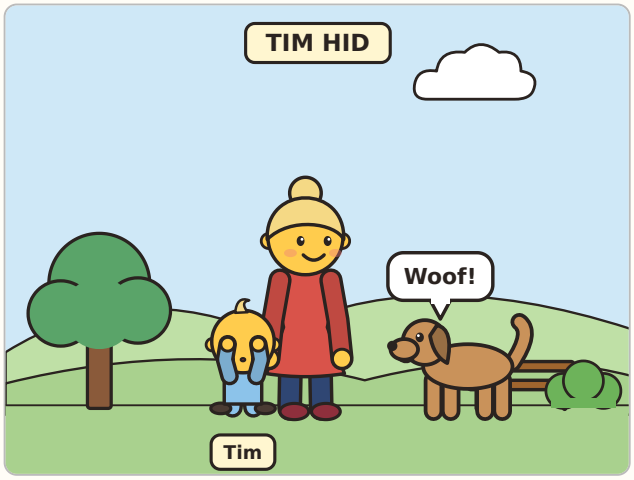
MEMORY HOOK **PLUCKY DUCKY.** The smallest duckling plucks up her courage and leaps into the pond first, ahead of all the big ducks. That brave little bird is **plucky**.

The **plucky** *little goalie stopped shot after shot from the older team.*

SIMILAR spirited, gutsy, brave, spunky

OPPOSITE timid, fainthearted, cowardly

timid **TIM**-id *adjective*



MEANING easily frightened; shy

MEMORY HOOK **TIM HID behind Mom.** When the friendly puppy trots up, little Tim hides behind his mom's legs. Shy, easily frightened Tim is **timid**.

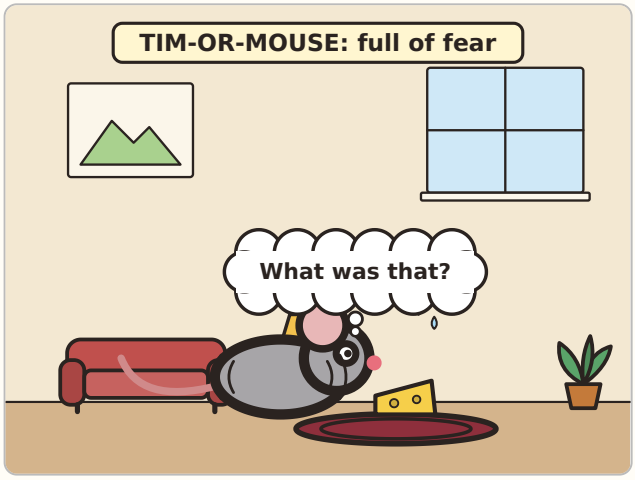
The **timid** *kitten hid under the bed whenever the doorbell rang.*

PARTS **tim** fear + **-id** having a quality (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR shy, fearful, timorous, nervous

OPPOSITE bold, confident, brave

timorous TIM-er-us *adjective*



MEANING fearful and nervous by nature

MEMORY HOOK **TIM-OR-MOUSE: a mouse full of fear.** Timmy the mouse trembles at every creak of the floor and every shadow on the wall. A creature that is always afraid is **timorous**.

The **timorous** *deer froze at the snap of a twig.*

PARTS **tim** fear + **-orous** full of

SIMILAR fearful, timid, nervous, jumpy

OPPOSITE bold, brave, fearless

apprehensive ap-rih-**HEN**-siv *adjective*



MEANING worried that something bad may happen

MEMORY HOOK **a-pre-HEN-sive: a worried HEN.** The hen spots a fox sniffing around the coop and cannot sleep all night, worrying about what he might do. She is **apprehensive**.

Jonah was **apprehensive** *about his first day at the new school.*

PARTS **ad** to, toward + **prehend** seize, grasp + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR uneasy, anxious, worried, nervous

OPPOSITE calm, confident, carefree

trepidation trep-ih-**DAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING nervous fear about something that is about to happen

MEMORY HOOK **TREP-idation: TREMBLING before.** Before his solo, Kai's knees knock and his bow shakes. That trembling fear of what is about to happen is **trepidation**.

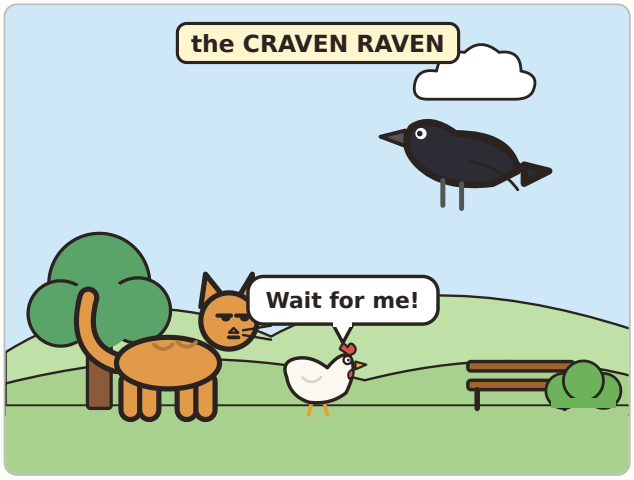
With some **trepidation**, *Kai stepped onto the stage for his first violin solo.*

PARTS **trepid** trembling, alarmed + **-ation** the act or state of

SIMILAR dread, apprehension, fear, alarm

OPPOSITE calm, confidence, composure

craven **KRAY**-vun *adjective*



MEANING shamefully cowardly

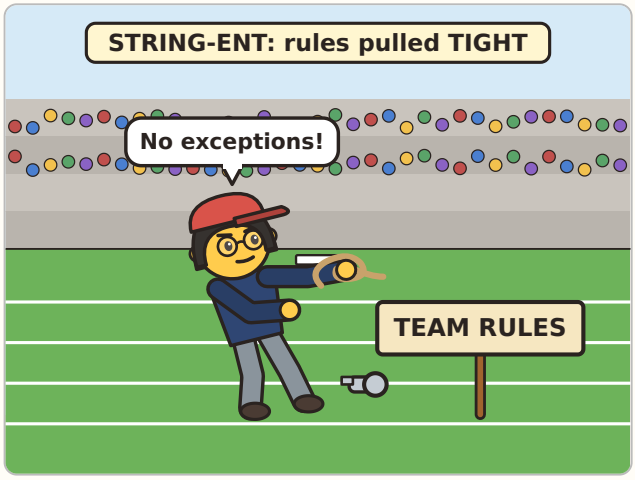
MEMORY HOOK **the CRAVEN RAVEN.** When the cat creeps close, the raven flies off and leaves the little birds to fend for themselves. That shameful coward is a **craven** raven.

The **craven** *guard dropped his post and ran at the first sound of trouble.*

SIMILAR cowardly, spineless, fainthearted, fearful

OPPOSITE brave, valiant, courageous

stringent **STRIN**-junt *adjective*



MEANING strict and exact about rules or standards

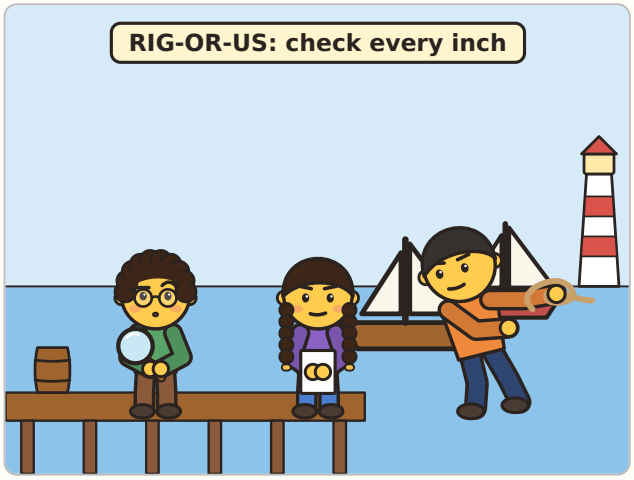
MEMORY HOOK **STRING-ent: rules pulled STRING-tight.** Coach Ada keeps her team rules pulled as tight as a string: no slack, no exceptions. Rules that tight are **stringent**.

The pool has **stringent** *rules: no running, no glass and no swimming without a lifeguard.*

PARTS **string** draw tight (from Latin stringere) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR strict, rigid, tight, demanding
OPPOSITE lax, lenient, loose

rigorous **RIG**-er-us *adjective*



MEANING extremely thorough and careful

MEMORY HOOK **check the RIG, ALL of US.** Before the sailboat race, all of us check every rope and knot of the rig, then check them again. An inspection that careful is **rigorous**.

After a **rigorous** *search of the house, Mom found the missing key inside the cereal box.*

PARTS **rigor** stiffness, strictness + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR thorough, meticulous, strict, demanding
OPPOSITE sloppy, careless, lax

exacting ig-**ZAK**-ting *adjective*



MEANING demanding great effort, care or skill

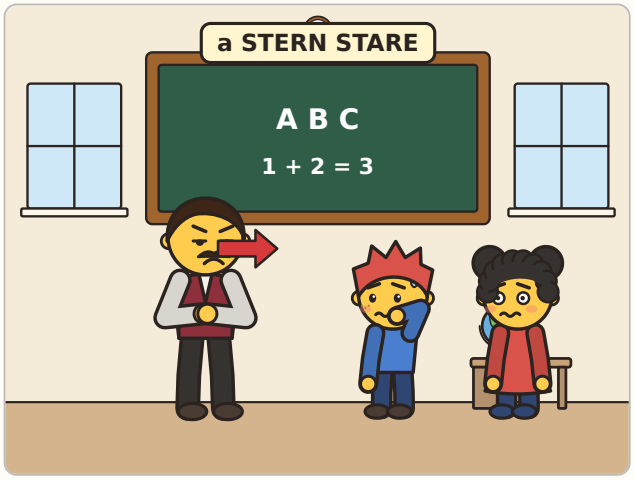
MEMORY HOOK **EXACT-ing: it must be EXACT.** Chef Lin makes her new cook measure the sugar again and again until it is exact. A boss who demands that much care is **exacting**.

The **exacting** *piano teacher made Rosa play the hard measure twenty times.*

PARTS **ex** out + **act** drive, do (from Latin agere)

SIMILAR demanding, strict, painstaking, tough
OPPOSITE easy, undemanding, lax

stern **STURN** *adjective*



MEANING serious and strict in manner

MEMORY HOOK **a STERN STARE.** Principal Victor gives the noisy hallway one long stare, and everyone falls silent. A serious, strict look like that is **stern**.

One **stern** *look from the librarian quieted the whole table.*

SIMILAR strict, severe, serious, grim
OPPOSITE gentle, lenient, kindly

draconian dray-**KOH**-nee-un *adjective*



MEANING far too harsh and severe

MEMORY HOOK **DRAGON-IAN rules: way too harsh.** In the dragon's castle the rule is: take one cookie and get no dessert for a whole year. Rules that harsh are **draconian**.

Taking away recess for a whole month for one late homework is **draconian**.

SIMILAR harsh, severe, strict, brutal
OPPOSITE lenient, mild, merciful

lenient **LEE**-nee-unt *adjective*



MEANING merciful; less strict or harsh than expected

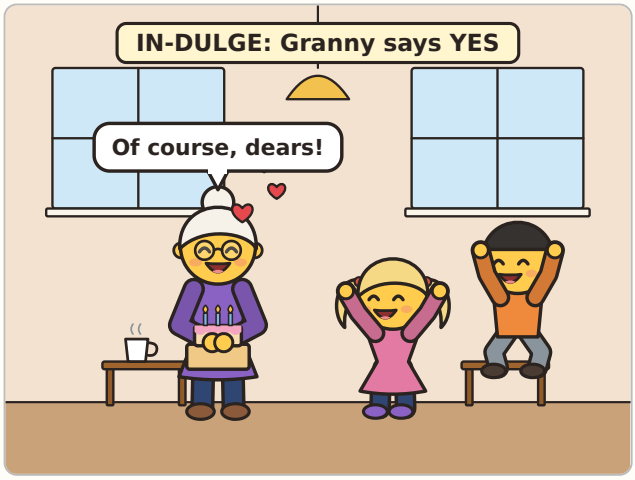
MEMORY HOOK **LEAN-IENT: the judge LEANS toward mercy.** The judge leans down, smiles at the nervous boy who broke a window, and says, "Just fix it and say sorry." She is **lenient**.

The **lenient** *referee let the little kids redo their throw-ins.*

PARTS **leni** soft, mild (from Latin lenis) + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR merciful, forgiving, easygoing, tolerant
OPPOSITE strict, harsh, stern

indulgent in-**DUL**-junt *adjective*



MEANING quick to give others what they want; not strict

MEMORY HOOK **IN-DULGE: Granny says yes to everything.** Granny Mae indulges every wish: cake for breakfast, a pony ride, staying up late. A granny who gives the kids whatever they want is **indulgent**.

The **indulgent** *aunt let the twins eat birthday cake for breakfast.*

SIMILAR easygoing, doting, permissive, soft
OPPOSITE strict, stern, stringent

permissive per-**MIS**-iv *adjective*



MEANING allowing a great deal of freedom

MEMORY HOOK **PERMISS-IVE: PERMISSION for everything.** At Uncle Omar's house you have permission for everything: pillow fights, pancakes at midnight, a fort in the living room. His house is **permissive**.

The camp had a **permissive** *bedtime: campers could stay up as long as they were quiet.*

PARTS **per** through + **miss** let go, send + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR easygoing, liberal, tolerant, indulgent
OPPOSITE strict, restrictive, stringent

lax LAKS *adjective*



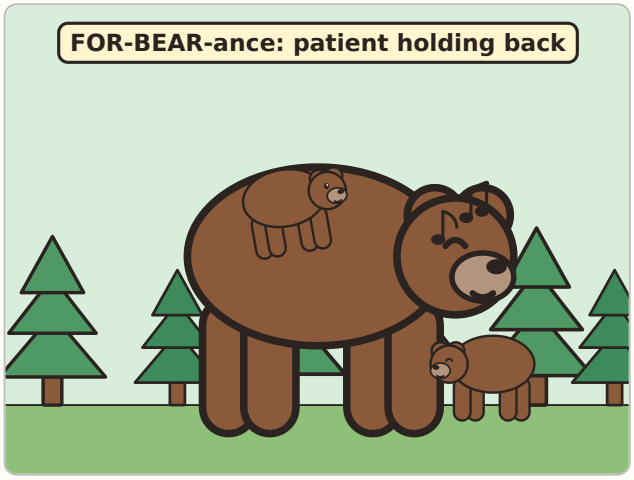
MEANING not strict or careful enough; loose

MEMORY HOOK **reLAXed: too relaxed to do the job.** The guard is so relaxed that he naps in his chair while the dog helps himself to the cookies. That careless guard is **lax**.

Security at the cookie jar was **lax**, *and the dog took full advantage.*

SIMILAR slack, loose, careless, easygoing
OPPOSITE strict, rigorous, careful

forbearance for-**BAIR**-uns *noun*



MEANING patient self-control; holding back from anger or punishment

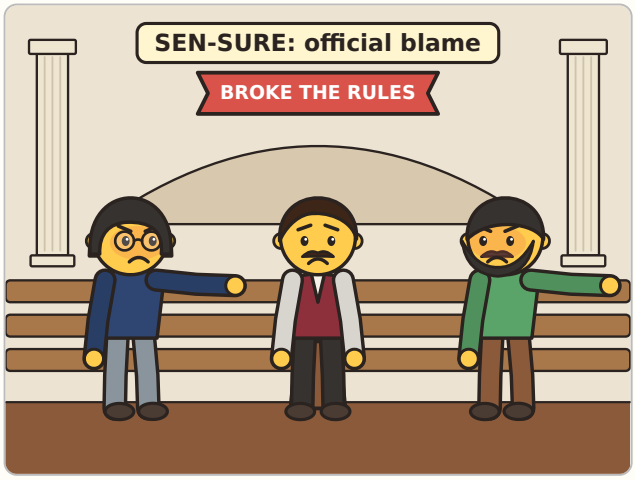
MEMORY HOOK **FOR-BEAR-ance: the patient BEAR.** The cubs tug the big bear's ears and climb on his back, but he never growls; he just waits. That patient holding back is **forbearance**.

The babysitter showed great **forbearance** *when the twins painted the kitchen door blue.*

PARTS **forbear** to hold back + **-ance** the act or state of

SIMILAR patience, restraint, tolerance, self-control
OPPOSITE impatience, intolerance

censure **SEN**-sher *verb*



MEANING to criticize strongly and officially

MEMORY HOOK **SEN-SURE: the council is SURE you were wrong.** The whole council stands up and votes together: they are sure their member broke the rules. To **censure** is to blame someone officially.

The school board voted to **censure** *the member who leaked the private report.*

SIMILAR condemn, criticize, reprove, denounce
OPPOSITE praise, commend, approve

rebuke rih-**BYOOK** *verb*



MEANING to scold someone sharply

MEMORY HOOK **RE-BOOK: the BOOKS fell AGAIN.** When Kai knocks the books off the shelf a second time, the librarian snaps, "Not again, young man!" She **rebukes** him sharply.

The lifeguard **rebuked** *the boys for running on the wet deck.*

SIMILAR scold, reprove, reprimand, upbraid
OPPOSITE praise, compliment, commend

reproach rih-**PROHCH** *verb*



MEANING to tell someone you are disappointed in what they did

MEMORY HOOK **the sad APPROACH: re-PROACH.** Mom approaches the broken lamp, sighs and says, "I expected better from you." To **reproach** someone is to show your disappointment in them.

Grandma did not yell; she simply **reproached** *him with a sad shake of her head.*

SIMILAR scold, reprove, upbraid, blame
OPPOSITE praise, commend

admonish ad-**MON**-ish *verb*



MEANING to warn or scold gently but firmly

MEMORY HOOK **ad-MOM-ish: a gentle MOM-ish warning.** "Helmet on, please," says Mom, in her gentle but firm Mom-ish way. To **admonish** is to warn someone gently but firmly.

The coach **admonished** *the players to drink water before practice.*

PARTS **ad** to, toward + **mon** warn, remind

SIMILAR warn, caution, counsel, advise
OPPOSITE praise, encourage

reprimand **REP**-ruh-mand *verb*



MEANING to scold formally, as a boss or official does

MEMORY HOOK **a RAP on the HAND from the boss.** The boss calls Dev into her office and gives him a formal rap on the hand for the late report. To **reprimand** is to scold officially.

The manager **reprimanded** *the clerk for leaving the register open.*

PARTS **re** back + **prim** press (from Latin premere)

SIMILAR scold, rebuke, reprove, discipline
OPPOSITE praise, commend, reward

chastise chas-**TIZE** *verb*



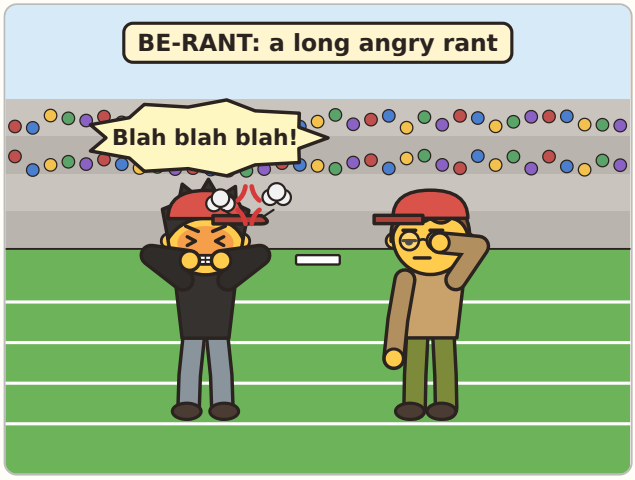
MEANING to scold or punish severely

MEMORY HOOK **CHASE-TISE: chased and scolded.** The farmer chases the goats out of his garden, scolding them hard the whole way. To **chastise** is to scold or punish severely.

The farmer **chastised** *his son for leaving the barn door open all night.*

SIMILAR scold, castigate, punish, discipline
OPPOSITE praise, reward, commend

berate bih-**RAYT** *verb*



MEANING to scold angrily and at length

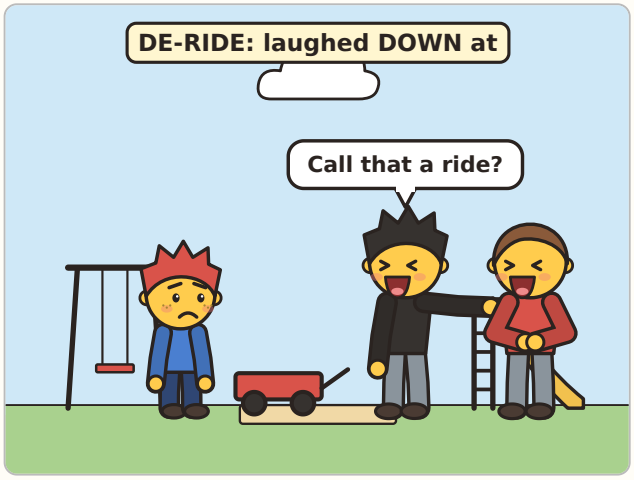
MEMORY HOOK **BE-RANT: a long, angry rant.** Rex rants at the umpire for ten whole minutes over one call, shouting and stomping. To **berate** someone is to scold them angrily and at length.

The fan **berated** *the umpire for ten straight minutes over one call.*

PARTS **be-** thoroughly (an English prefix) + **rate** to scold (an old verb)

SIMILAR scold, upbraid, rail at, yell at
OPPOSITE praise, compliment

deride dih-**RIDE** *verb*



MEANING to mock and make fun of with scorn

MEMORY HOOK **DE-RIDE: "You call that a RIDE?".** The older kids point and laugh at Pip's homemade cart: "Ha! You call that a ride?" To **deride** is to mock with scorn.

Some kids **derided** *her homemade costume, but it won first prize.*

PARTS **de** down + **rid** laugh

SIMILAR mock, ridicule, scorn, jeer at
OPPOSITE praise, admire, respect

disparage dih-**SPAIR**-ij *verb*



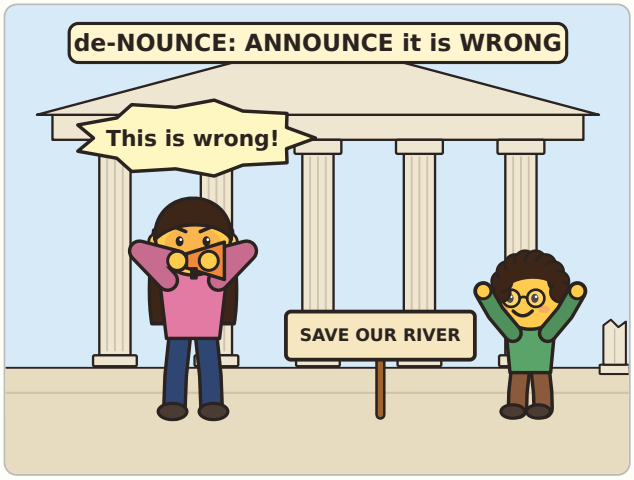
MEANING to speak of something as if it had little worth

MEMORY HOOK **DIS the PARADE.** Victor stands at the curb and disses the whole parade: "Silly floats, tiny band, nothing special." To **disparage** something is to talk about it as if it had little worth.

He **disparaged** *his sister's painting as "just a bunch of blobs."*

SIMILAR belittle, run down, put down, scorn
OPPOSITE praise, extol, celebrate

denounce dih-**NOWNS** *verb*



MEANING to declare publicly that something is wrong or evil

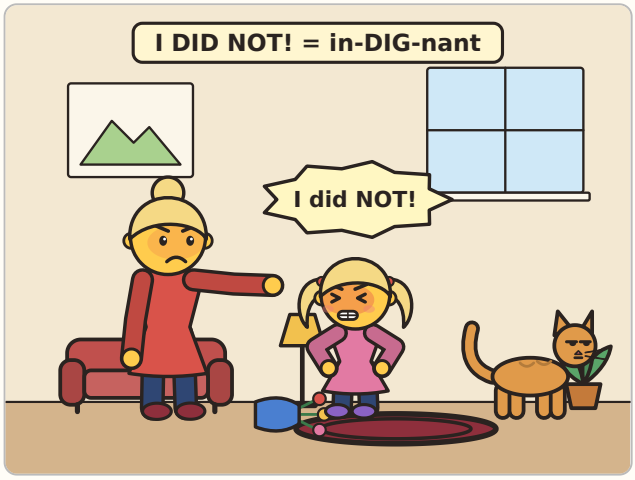
MEMORY HOOK **de-NOUNCE: ANNOUNCE it is WRONG.** From the town hall steps, the mayor announces to everyone that dumping trash in the river is wrong and must stop. To **denounce** is to declare publicly that something is wrong.

The mayor **denounced** *the dumping of trash in the river.*

PARTS **de** down, completely + **nounce** announce, report

SIMILAR condemn, decry, criticize, speak out against
OPPOSITE praise, support, defend

indignant in-**DIG**-nunt *adjective*



MEANING angry because something seems unfair

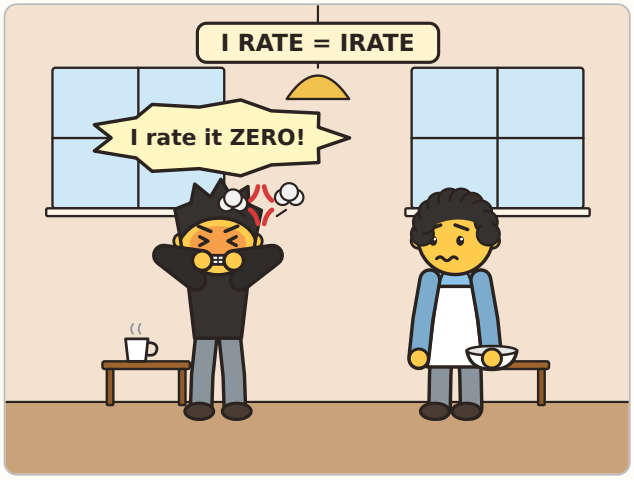
MEMORY HOOK **in-DIG-NANT: "I did NOT!".** Ivy is blamed for the broken vase she never touched. "I did NOT!" she cries, angry at the unfairness. She is **indignant**.

Ivy was **indignant** *when she was blamed for the vase the cat had broken.*

PARTS **in-** not + **dign** worthy + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR outraged, offended, resentful, aggrieved
OPPOSITE pleased, content, satisfied

irate eye-**RAYT** *adjective*



MEANING very angry, often loudly so

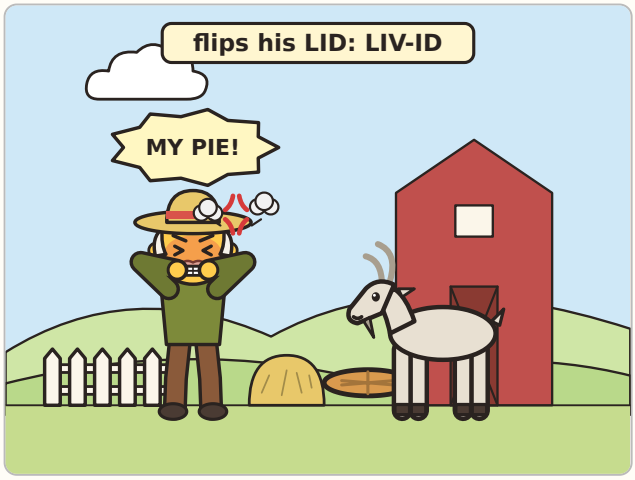
MEMORY HOOK **"I RATE it ZERO!".** Rex finds his soup stone cold, turns red and shouts, "I rate this place zero stars!" He is **irate**.

Usually the calmest man on the street, Mr. Lee was **irate** *when he found his garden trampled.*

PARTS **ira** anger + **-ate** having (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR furious, enraged, outraged, fuming
OPPOSITE calm, pleased, content

livid **LIV**-id *adjective*



MEANING furious; also, bluish-gray in color

MEMORY HOOK **he flips his LID: LIV-ID.** When the goat eats his prize pie, Farmer Gus is so furious he flips his lid. He is **livid**.

Dad was **livid** *when he saw the scratch on his new car.*

SIMILAR furious, enraged, fuming, outraged
OPPOSITE calm, pleased

irascible ih-**RAS**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING easily angered; quick-tempered

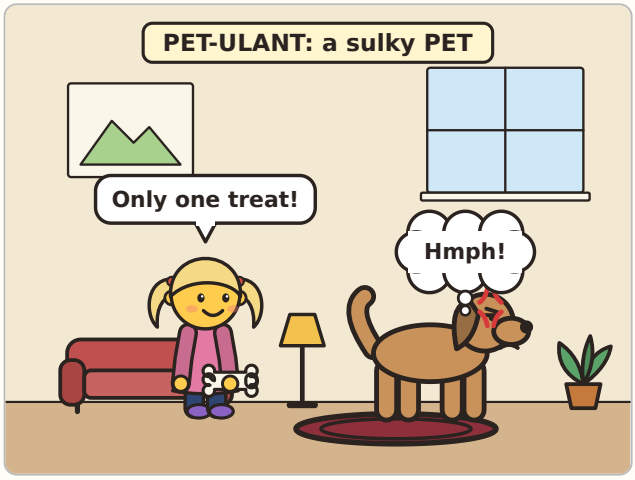
MEMORY HOOK **IRA-SCIBLE: IRA flares up at everything.** Old Ira snaps at the mail carrier, the wind and even the birds; the smallest thing sets him off. Ira is **irascible**.

The **irascible** *old cat hissed at anyone who came near its basket.*

PARTS **ira** anger + **-ible** apt to, able to

SIMILAR hot-tempered, testy, cranky, touchy
OPPOSITE easygoing, good-natured, calm

petulant **PECH**-uh-lunt *adjective*



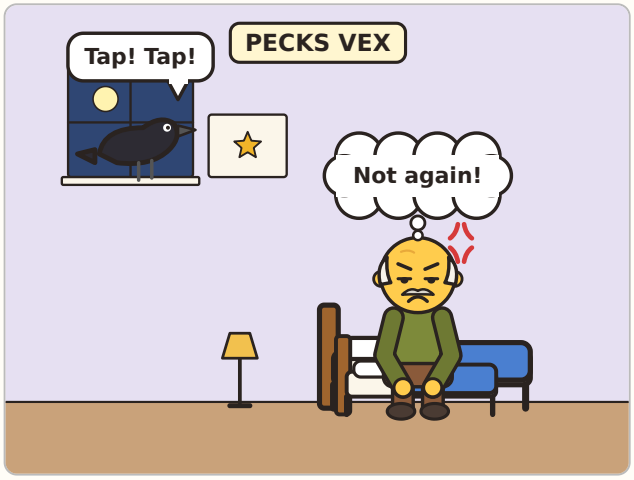
MEANING childishly sulky and bad-tempered

MEMORY HOOK **PET-ulant: sulks like a spoiled PET.** When he doesn't get a second treat, Biscuit the puppy turns his back and sulks. What a **petulant** pet!

Told to turn off his game, the **petulant** *boy pouted, sulked and stomped up the stairs.*

SIMILAR sulky, peevish, cranky, testy
OPPOSITE good-humored, cheerful, easygoing

vex **VEKS** *verb*



MEANING to annoy, puzzle or frustrate

MEMORY HOOK **PECKS VEX.** Tap, tap, tap: every morning at five, a crow pecks at Grandpa's window. Those pecks **vex** him no end.

The squeaky door **vexed** *Grandpa all winter.*

SIMILAR annoy, irritate, bother, frustrate
OPPOSITE please, soothe, delight

wrath **RATH** *noun*



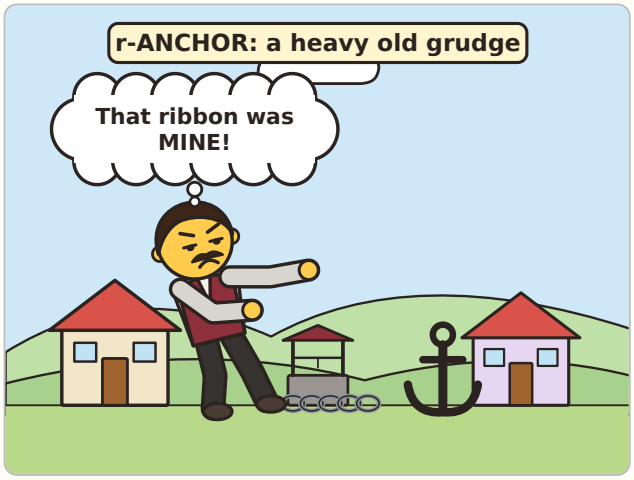
MEANING fierce anger

MEMORY HOOK **WRATH rhymes with BATH.** Try to give the cat a bath and you will see true **wrath**: hissing, splashing, fur-on-end fury.

The cat's **wrath** *was terrible when it was lifted into the bathtub.*

SIMILAR rage, fury, anger, ire
OPPOSITE calm, forgiveness, delight

rancor **RANG**-ker *noun*



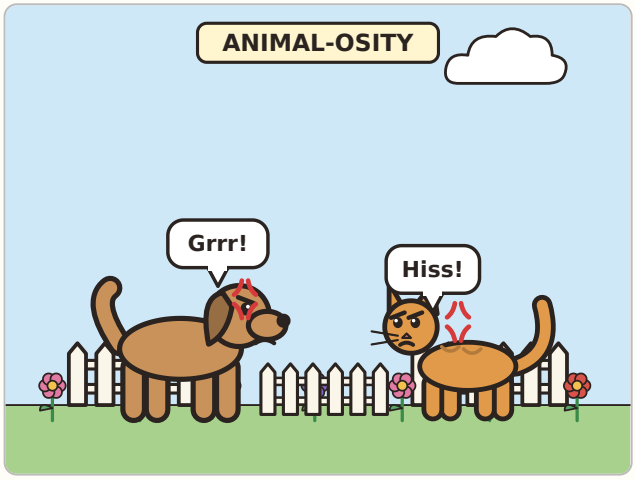
MEANING bitter resentment that lasts a long time

MEMORY HOOK **r-ANCHOR: a grudge you drag for years.** Thirty years after losing the pie contest, Victor still drags his grudge around like a heavy anchor. Bitter resentment that lasts that long is **rancor**.

Years after the contest, he still spoke of the judges with **rancor**, *a bitterness that never faded.*

SIMILAR bitterness, resentment, ill will, spite
OPPOSITE goodwill, friendliness, forgiveness

animosity an-uh-**MOS**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING strong dislike or hostility

MEMORY HOOK **ANIMAL-OSITY: cat versus dog.** The cat and the dog next door hiss and growl at each other across the fence every single day. Their **animosity** is plain to see.

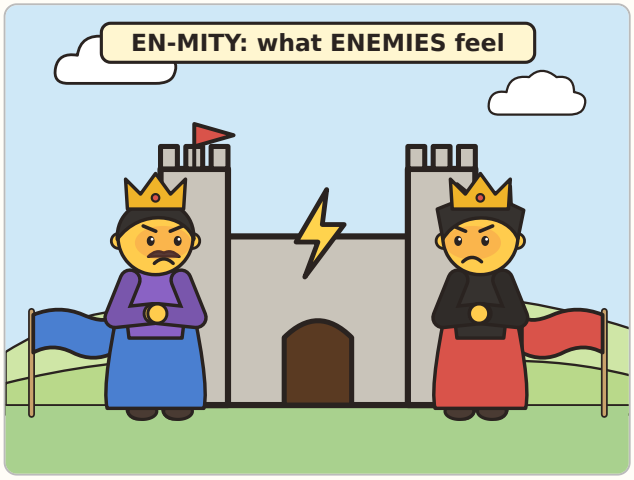
There was no **animosity** *between the rivals; they shook hands after every match.*

PARTS **anim** spirit, mind + **-osity** the quality of being full of

SIMILAR hostility, ill will, antagonism, dislike

OPPOSITE friendship, goodwill, affection

enmity **EN**-mih-tee *noun*



MEANING deep, lasting hatred between enemies

MEMORY HOOK **EN-MITY: what ENEMIES feel.** The kings of the two castles have been enemies for a hundred years, and neither will even nod to the other. Their **enmity** never fades.

The **enmity** *between the two families lasted three generations.*

PARTS **-ity** the state or quality of

SIMILAR hatred, hostility, ill will, feud

OPPOSITE friendship, amity, goodwill